

Whenever it Rains



Some memories
never fade...
they just smell
like rain and
coffee..



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Chapter 1 — The House Full of Warmth

The evening sky moved slowly above the hills of *Dindigul*.

Clouds drifted lazily across the fading sunlight while the cool wind touched the earth with a strange kind of peace. It was one of those evenings where the world felt quiet... as if life itself had paused for a moment to breathe.

Far away from the crowded streets of the city, a single house stood near the hills.

At first glance, the house looked lonely.

There were no nearby homes.

No loud traffic.

No noisy neighbors.

Only silence, wind, trees, and the distant sound of birds returning home before nightfall.

But the loneliness existed only outside.

Inside that house—

life was overflowing.

Warmth lived there.

Love lived there.

And happiness echoed through every corner of the walls.

The house itself was beautiful in a calm and elegant way. A wide open space stretched across the front yard, decorated with small trees, flowering plants, and soft garden lights that slowly began glowing as evening approached.

Three cars rested quietly near the parking area.

- **A black BMW M3**
- **A silver Volkswagen Tayron**
- **A white-and-gold Porsche 911**

The golden sunset reflected softly across their surfaces, making the peaceful house feel even more alive.

Near the entrance, a pair of wooden chairs faced the hills. The wind moved gently through the leaves while the fading sunlight painted the sky in shades of orange and gold.

And inside the house—

laughter ruled everything.

Because today was special.

Today was **Akira's birthday.**

Akira was sixty-one years old.

But age had never managed to take away the calm strength in his eyes.

He carried himself with a quiet wisdom that only life could teach — *the kind of wisdom earned through years of struggle, love, sacrifice, and silence.*

He was the kind of man who spoke softly, listened deeply, and loved completely.

He was the heart of the family.

And around him, the family itself felt complete.

His wife, Yuki, still looked at him with the same love she had carried for thirty-four years.

His son, Paari, had inherited Akira's kindness.

And Paari's wife, Venitha, was only weeks away from giving birth to their first child.

Another life was preparing to enter this peaceful family.

Another heartbeat was waiting to join their world.

Inside the living room, darkness gently filled the space while the television screen became the only source of light.

The blue glow danced softly across the walls.

Paari stood in front of the television with the remote in his hand, completely focused as he searched through movie options.
“This one?” he asked.

Venitha, sitting nearby with her phone, immediately shook her head.
“No... too boring.”

Paari sighed dramatically.
“You reject every movie.”

“That’s because your taste is terrible,” she replied proudly.

Paari turned slowly toward her.
“My taste?”

“Yes,” Venitha replied without hesitation.

A small smirk appeared on Paari’s face.
“My taste brought you into this house.”

Venitha narrowed her eyes while trying not to smile.
 Before she could answer, **Yuki** suddenly laughed softly from the sofa.

And that laughter alone made the room feel warmer.
 At the far side of the living room, **Akira** sat quietly on the sofa while Yuki rested against him peacefully.

Her head leaned gently on his chest while his fingers moved softly through her hair with the same care a parent would give a sleeping child.

There was something deeply peaceful about them.
 Not dramatic love.
 Not loud romance.
 Just comfort.

The kind of love that survives time itself.

Yuki slowly lifted her face and looked at him.
 Akira lowered his eyes toward her at the exact same moment.

For a few seconds—
they simply looked at each other.

Like two people who had already spent an entire lifetime together... yet still found something new to love every single day.

Akira smiled faintly before placing a soft kiss on her forehead.
 Yuki immediately hid her face against his chest, embarrassed like a young girl despite all these years.
 Akira laughed quietly.
 From across the room, **Paari** noticed them.

His expression slowly softened.

And suddenly—
 his eyes became wet.
 Not because he was sad.
 But because seeing his parents love each other like that made his heart feel full.

Venitha noticed him silently wiping his tears and smiled gently.
“You’re crying again?”

Paari sniffed once.
“I’m not crying.”

“Paari... you literally are.”

He placed a hand on his chest with fake seriousness.
“It’s emotional damage.”

Venitha laughed softly and leaned her head against his shoulder.

And for a moment—
the room felt less like a house...
and more like heaven.

Finally, Venitha found a movie on her phone and quickly showed it to Paari.
“This one!”

Paari stared at the title for a few seconds before giving a small nod.
“Okay... this actually looks good.”

Venitha smiled proudly. “See? You should trust me more.”

Paari grabbed the remote and shook his head dramatically.
“That sounds like dangerous advice.”

She lightly smacked his arm while he laughed and pressed play.

The movie began.

The television light flickered across their faces while outside, evening slowly melted into night.

Inside that home—
everyone sat together peacefully.

No one knew what life would bring tomorrow.
No one thought about pain.
No one imagined loss.

At that moment—
they simply lived.

And sometimes...
that alone becomes the purest form of happiness.

By the time the movie ended, the sky outside had already begun surrendering itself to dusk.

Soft orange light spread across the hills surrounding the house, while the evening wind carried the smell of wet soil and trees through the balcony.

The world outside looked peaceful.
But inside the house—
peace felt warmer.

The clock slowly moved toward **6:30 PM.**

Akira sat alone on the balcony now, leaning comfortably against the blue-and-white double sofa near the railing. One leg rested over the other while his eyes remained fixed on the sunset ahead.

He had always loved sunsets.
Not because they were beautiful.

But because they reminded him of *time*.
Every minute, the sky changed colors.
Every second, something faded while something else quietly appeared.

And somehow...
life felt similar.

Behind him, the balcony door opened softly.

Yuki stepped outside carrying two cups of coffee.

The warm smell instantly filled the cool evening air.

She walked toward him slowly before placing one cup gently into his hand.

Akira looked up at her with a small smile.
“Thank you.”

Yuki sat beside him, holding her own cup carefully between both hands.

For a few moments, neither of them spoke.
They simply watched the sunset together.
Comfortable silence.

The kind only true love understands.
Finally, Yuki broke the silence.
“You’ve been staring at the sunset for a long time today.”

Akira smiled faintly without taking his eyes off the sky.
“The sky changes every minute during sunset,” he said softly.
“No color stays forever.”

Yuki turned toward him slightly.
“And you watch it every day?”

Akira nodded quietly.
“Hmm.”

Yuki looked at him curiously. “Why?”

This time, Akira slowly looked at her.
The fading sunlight shimmered softly in his eyes.
“Because it feels like my life.”

Yuki’s expression softened immediately.

Akira took a small sip of coffee before continuing quietly.
“When I look at the sunset... old memories return one by one.”

A pause.

“The struggles.”
“The happy moments.”
“The mistakes.”
“The people I met.”

His eyes slowly rested on her face.
“And the luckiest thing that ever happened to me.”

Yuki blinked once.
A faint blush appeared across her cheeks almost instantly.

Even after ***thirty-four years***—
she still reacted the same way whenever he looked at her like that.
Akira smiled softly at the sight.
For him, Yuki’s shy expression had never become old.

Not even once.

Yuki quickly looked away and hid her smile behind the coffee cup.
“You still talk too much,” she whispered.

“And you still blush too easily,” Akira replied immediately.

Yuki lightly pushed his shoulder while laughing quietly.

The wind moved gently around them.

Below the balcony, trees swayed slowly while the distant hills disappeared deeper into the evening light.

And for a moment—
the world felt unbelievably calm.

Suddenly—
“Mama!”

Venitha’s voice echoed from inside the house.

Yuki immediately straightened herself while Akira laughed softly under his breath.

Venitha stepped onto the balcony holding a folded shopping list.

“Mama, can you buy these things from the supermarket?” she asked carefully.

Akira accepted the paper and adjusted his glasses slightly while reading through it.
“Hmm... vegetables... milk... cleaning supplies...”

He looked up at her.
“Anything else?”

Venitha shook her head.
“That’s all.”

Akira nodded once.
“Okay. I’ll go now.”

Yuki immediately frowned.
“At this time?”

Akira gave her a calm look. “I’ll come back quickly.”

“What time exactly is ‘*quickly*’?” she asked suspiciously.

Akira pretended to think seriously.
“Maybe... 8:30?”

Yuki narrowed her eyes.
“That’s not quick.”

Akira laughed.

Venitha smiled softly while watching them.

Even simple conversations between **Akira** and **Yuki** somehow carried warmth.

“Drive safely, Mama,” Venitha said gently.

Akira smiled faintly. “I always do.”

“That confidence is dangerous,” Yuki muttered.

Akira placed a hand dramatically against his chest.
“You wound me.”

Yuki rolled her eyes while trying not to laugh.

A few minutes later, Akira walked toward the parking area with his car keys in hand.

The evening wind moved through his silver hair while the sunset faded slowly behind him.

Yuki followed him all the way to the entrance, arms folded across her chest.

Akira stopped beside the **BMW M3** and looked back at Yuki with amusement in his eyes.

“You’re watching me like I’m leaving for war,” Akira said.

Yuki crossed her arms immediately. “That’s because you forget things.”

Akira placed a hand on his chest dramatically. “I only forgot once.”

Yuki narrowed her eyes at him. “You forgot *me* at a supermarket.”

Akira pointed at her in defense. “That happened twenty years ago.”

“And yet the trauma survived,” Yuki replied calmly.

For a second, Akira tried to stay serious.

Then he burst into laughter.

Even from inside the house, **Paari** could hear them bickering like an old married couple.

And honestly—

he loved hearing it.

Because their love never felt artificial.

It felt alive.

Akira finally opened the car door before looking toward Yuki one last time.

“I’ll be back by 8:30.”

Yuki nodded slowly.

Then Akira suddenly shouted dramatically from inside the car—

“I love you!”

Yuki froze for a second before quickly looking around in embarrassment.

“Why are you shouting?!”

“So the entire world knows.”

Yuki failed to hide her smile.

“Just drive safely.”

Akira leaned slightly out of the window.

“I love you too,” she finally whispered softly.

And somehow—

that quiet answer made Akira happier than anything else.

The engine started.

The **BMW** slowly moved out through the gate while Yuki continued standing there until the car disappeared down the road.

Inside the house—

something else was already beginning.

A surprise.

One carefully prepared with love.

The moment Akira’s car disappeared beyond the road near the hills—

the peaceful atmosphere inside the house changed completely.

Not into chaos.

But into excitement.

The kind that only families carry when they prepare something special for someone they love deeply.

Inside the terrace area, **Paari** stood in the middle of scattered decorations with a balloon ribbon hanging from his shoulder and tape stuck to his fingers.

“Why is this balloon refusing to cooperate with me?” he muttered seriously.

Below him, **Venitha’s** laughter echoed from downstairs.
“Because even balloons are tired of your drama!”

Paari clicked his tongue dramatically.
“Very disrespectful behavior from my own wife.”

“You deserve worse,” she shouted back immediately.

And somewhere near the kitchen—
Yuki laughed softly while mixing cake batter.

The entire house felt alive.
The terrace slowly transformed under the fading evening sky.
Warm decorative lights stretched across the walls.
Small balloons floated gently in the cool wind.

A projector stood near the corner beside a white screen Paari had carefully tied between two poles.

Near the center of the terrace sat a long table covered neatly with decorations, candles, and a space reserved for the birthday cake still being prepared downstairs.

Paari stepped back slowly to observe everything.

For a few seconds—
he simply smiled.
Not because the decorations were perfect.
But because ***today mattered to him.***

Akira had spent his entire life protecting this family quietly.

And tonight—
Paari wanted his father to feel loved.

Truly loved.

The wind moved gently through the terrace while Paari adjusted the projector settings again.
A soft smile slowly appeared across his face as old memories began returning one by one.

This terrace had witnessed almost every important moment in his life.
His childhood laughter.
Late-night conversations with Akira.
Rainy evenings with tea.
Silent heartbreaks.
And beautiful beginnings.
Especially one memory.

One person.

Venitha.
Paari leaned quietly against the railing while staring into the distance.

And slowly—
the past returned.

Years ago...

Back when college life still felt endless.
Back when responsibilities had not yet become heavy.
Back when love arrived unexpectedly.

Paari had first seen **Venitha** during placement training in their final year.

He was studying **B.E Computer Science**.

She was from **Information Technology**.

At first—

she was just another student among hundreds.

Until she looked up once.

And somehow—

everything changed.

Paari still remembered that exact moment clearly.

The classroom had been noisy.

Students were talking.

Placement tension filled the air.

But when his eyes met hers for the first time—

the entire world strangely became quiet.

Not dramatic.

Not magical.

Just... *still*.

Like his heart suddenly recognized someone before his mind could understand it.

He remembered sitting there pretending to focus while secretly watching her every few seconds.

The way she adjusted her hair while reading.

The way she smiled politely during introductions.

The calmness in her eyes.

And for reasons he himself couldn't explain—

his chest had started feeling strangely warm.

That day, only twenty students were selected for the next placement round.

Both **Paari** and **Venitha** were among them.

And somehow—

that small coincidence alone had felt important to him.

Very important.

The memory continued unfolding slowly in his mind.

He remembered receiving the offer letter.

Remembered searching across the campus hoping to see her one more time.

Remembered failing.

And later that evening—

he had sat alone on this same terrace feeling confused by emotions he couldn't even explain properly.

That was the night **Akira** had found him sitting silently under the sky.

Akira had quietly sat beside him without asking questions immediately.

For a while, both father and son had simply watched the stars together.

Then Akira finally spoke.

“What happened, boy?”

Paari had hesitated.

But somehow—

talking to Akira always felt easy.

So he told him everything.

About the girl.

About the strange feeling.

About how his mind refused to calm down.

Akira listened quietly before smiling knowingly.
 “I think you found your soulmate.”

Paari had immediately frowned.
 “How do you know?”

Akira leaned back comfortably.
 “Because your eyes are speaking more than your mouth.”

Paari groaned dramatically.
 “This is real life, Dad. Not some magical movie.”

But almost immediately—
 his phone vibrated.
 Paari remembered checking the message casually at first...

before freezing completely.

Venitha had sent him a message.
 A simple congratulations text.
 But to him—
it had felt like the universe itself answered.

Paari still remembered looking at Akira with shock.
 And Akira—
 smiling proudly like he had predicted the future itself.

Back in the present—
 Paari laughed softly to himself while remembering everything.
 Sometimes memories did not return to hurt us.
 Sometimes they returned only to remind us how blessed we once were.

And how blessed we still are.

Suddenly—
 the terrace door opened.

Yuki stepped outside carefully.
 “Paari,” she called softly.

He turned immediately.
 “Hmm?”

“Your father will reach home soon.”

Paari quickly checked the time.

8:20 PM.

His eyes widened instantly.
 “Oh no.”

Yuki laughed softly while watching him panic.
 “Relax. Everything is ready.”

Paari looked around once more.

Lights.
 Projector.
 Balloons.
 Cake table.
 Memories waiting inside the video.
 Love hidden in every small detail.
 He took a deep breath slowly.

Then nodded.

“Okay.”

Yuki smiled gently.

“Turn off the lights.”

Within seconds—

the entire terrace fell into darkness.

Below them, the peaceful house became quiet once again.

And somewhere beyond the hills—

Akira’s car was already making its way home.

The city lights of Dindigul glowed softly beneath the evening sky as **Akira** slowly parked the **BMW** near the supermarket entrance.

The clock inside the car showed **7:10 PM.**

He adjusted his glasses slightly before stepping out of the car, locking it with a small click from the key.

For a brief second, he turned back and looked at the car proudly.

Not because it was expensive.

But because ***every single thing in his life carried memories behind it.***

Then, with calm steps, Akira entered the supermarket.

Inside, the atmosphere felt peaceful.

Soft old melodies played through hidden speakers while people moved through the aisles carrying baskets and pushing trolleys.

Children begged for chocolates.

Couples argued over snacks.

An old man searched carefully for tea powder while a tired mother carried a sleeping baby against her shoulder.

Life existed everywhere around him.

Simple.

Ordinary.

Beautiful.

Akira slowly pushed the trolley through each section.

Milk.

Vegetables.

Cleaning supplies.

Small household items.

He checked every product carefully while quietly humming along to the old song playing nearby.

The cashier noticed him immediately when he reached the billing counter.

“Good evening, sir.”

Akira smiled politely.

“Good evening.”

“How are you, sir?”

“I’m doing well.”

The cashier scanned the items while speaking respectfully.

People naturally spoke carefully around Akira. There was something calm and dignified about him that earned quiet respect without effort.

After the bill was completed, Akira handed over his card.

The cashier returned it with a smile.

“Thank you, sir. Have a happy day.”

Akira nodded warmly.

“You too.”

A few minutes later, he placed all the bags carefully inside the car trunk before slowly closing it.

The wind felt cooler now.

Night had almost arrived completely.

Akira checked the time.

7:45 PM.

Still early.

Still enough time.

And suddenly—

his heart wanted silence.

Not loneliness.

Just silence.

The peaceful kind.

Without overthinking it, **Akira** got back into the car and drove quietly toward a nearby park outside the city.

The park looked calm beneath the night sky.

Streetlights glowed softly along the walking paths while the sound of wind moved gently through the trees.

A few people walked quietly.

Some children still played near the swings.

Young couples sat beneath dim lights talking softly about futures they hadn't lived yet.

Akira parked near the entrance and slowly walked toward an empty wooden bench.

Then he sat down.

And simply watched.

That was one thing Akira loved about life.

Observing.

Noticing.

Small details most people ignored.

The tired father carrying his sleeping child carefully.

The old woman feeding stray dogs near the pathway.

The teenager laughing loudly while pretending he wasn't heartbroken.

Life always spoke quietly.

Most people were simply too busy to hear it.

Akira leaned back against the bench peacefully.

The cool wind touched his face while the distant city lights flickered softly beyond the trees.

For a moment—

his mind became completely calm.

Then suddenly—

someone sat beside him.

Akira turned slightly.

A young man.

Maybe in his early twenties.

His eyes looked red.

Wet.

And although he tried hiding it—

pain sat heavily across his face.

For a few seconds, neither of them spoke.

The young man looked down at the ground silently.

Then **Akira** finally asked gently—
“Are you okay, boy?”

The young man laughed softly.

But there was no happiness inside it.
“I don’t know.”

Akira didn’t interrupt.
He simply waited.
And somehow—
that patience alone made the stranger continue speaking.

“I loved someone,” the young man whispered quietly.
“Today... I told her.”
A pause.
“She said I’m just a friend.”

The wind moved softly between them.

Akira nodded slowly.
“First love?”

The young man gave a small painful smile.
“Was it that obvious?”

Akira chuckled softly.
“Very.”

For a moment, silence returned.

Then the young man suddenly spoke again.
“I think life hates me.”

Akira raised one eyebrow slightly.
“That’s a strong accusation.”

The young man looked frustrated now.
“Everything goes wrong. Every single time.”

His voice slowly cracked beneath the weight he had been holding inside for too long.

“I studied properly.”
“I worked hard.”
“I adjusted for everyone.”
“But still... nothing feels right.”

He swallowed heavily before whispering—
“I don’t even know why I’m running anymore.”

Those words hung quietly in the night air.

And for one brief second—
Akira’s own eyes changed slightly.

Because somewhere deep inside those words...

he recognized something familiar.
Pain.
Not the dramatic kind.
The silent kind.

The kind people carry while still smiling normally every day.

Akira slowly looked toward the sky above the park.

Dark clouds drifted gently across the moonlight while wind whispered through the trees.

Finally, he spoke.
“Life doesn’t move in one straight line.”

The young man stayed silent and listened carefully.
“Sometimes life gives.”
“Sometimes it takes away.”
“Sometimes it breaks things quietly.”

Akira’s voice remained calm.
“But that doesn’t mean your story is over.”

The young man lowered his head.
“How do I forgive people when they hurt me?”

Akira smiled faintly.
“Think about water.”

The young man frowned slightly.
“Water?”

“You don’t fight water,” Akira explained softly.
“You let it flow.”

A pause.

“Forgiveness is the same.”
“Not for them.”
“For your own peace.”

The young man’s breathing slowly became steadier.

For the first time since sitting there—
his chest felt slightly lighter.

Then his phone suddenly rang.

He quickly answered.
“Yeah... yeah, I’ll come. Just five minutes.”

The call ended.

He stood up slowly before turning toward Akira.
“Thank you, sir.”

Akira smiled gently.
“For what?”

“For listening.”

And honestly—
sometimes listening saves people more than advice ever can.

The young man began walking away quickly before disappearing toward the park entrance.

Akira remained seated quietly on the bench.

Then suddenly—
a child nearby burst into laughter.

Pure laughter.

The kind without fear.
Without stress.
Without pretending.

Akira turned slowly toward the sound and smiled softly.

A small child sat near the pathway, laughing at absolutely nothing while their exhausted mother watched lovingly nearby.

Akira’s eyes softened deeply.
And almost unconsciously—
he whispered to himself,
“This... is real happiness.”

Not money.
Not success.
Not achievement.
Just moments like this.

Simple moments.
Living moments.
A few minutes later, footsteps returned toward the bench.
The same young man stopped beside him again, slightly embarrassed.
“You’re still here?”

Akira laughed quietly.
“I could ask you the same thing.”

The young man rubbed the back of his neck awkwardly.
“I forgot to ask your name.”

For a brief second, Akira thought silently.

Then he answered calmly—
“Gopinath.”
Not because he wanted to lie.

But because tonight—
he didn’t want to be known as anyone important.

He only wanted to be another human sitting beneath the same sky.

The young man smiled.
“I’m Varun.”

Akira nodded warmly.
“Take care of yourself, Varun.”

Varun smiled properly this time.
“You too, sir.”

Akira checked the time again.
8:20 PM.

His eyes widened slightly.
“Oh no.”

Varun laughed softly.
“You’re late?”

“My wife will begin a world war.”

Varun laughed harder now.
“That serious?”

“You have no idea.”

Both of them smiled.

And somehow—
the heaviness inside Varun had already become lighter.

Akira stood up slowly.
“Have a happy life, boy.”

Varun nodded respectfully.
“Drive safely, sir.”

Akira gave a small wave before walking back toward the parking area beneath the calm night sky.

A few minutes later—

the **BMW** engine started softly.

Akira searched through old songs until one finally played.

“***Nee Kavithaigala...***”

The melody filled the car quietly.

And under the peaceful night of Dindigul—

Akira drove home.

Completely unaware of the love waiting for him above the house.

The road leading toward Akira’s house was quiet beneath the night sky.

Streetlights passed one by one beside the BMW while the old melody inside the car continued playing softly.

“***Nee Kavithaigala...***”

Akira rested one hand on the steering wheel while the cool night wind entered gently through the slightly open window.

His mind felt peaceful.

The conversation with Varun still lingered somewhere inside him.

Sometimes strangers leave quietly...

but their pain stays in our thoughts longer than expected.

Akira smiled faintly to himself.

Life really was strange.

One person cried because love ended.

Another person survived only because love still existed.

And somehow—
both people continued living beneath the same sky.

The car slowly approached the gate of the house.

And immediately—
Akira noticed something unusual.

The terrace lights were off.

Completely dark.

His eyebrows lifted slightly.

A small smile almost escaped his lips.

“Ah...”

He understood immediately.

“So this is their plan.”

Still—

he pretended not to notice.

Because ***some surprises become more beautiful when we act surprised for the people we love.***

The gate slowly opened.

The **BMW** entered quietly before stopping near the parking area.

Akira parked carefully and stepped out of the car carrying the shopping bags in both hands.

The night air felt cooler here near the hills.

And near the entrance—

Yuki was already waiting for him.

The moment she saw him, her face brightened automatically.

Not because he brought gifts.

Not because of his birthday.

Simply because he returned home safely.

And sometimes—

that alone becomes love.

Akira noticed her expression immediately and smiled softly.

“I’m back.”

Yuki crossed her arms dramatically.

“And did you forget anything this time?”

Akira placed a hand against his chest.

“You still haven’t forgiven that supermarket incident?”

“You forgot your own wife.”

“That happened twenty years ago.”

“That pain is permanent.”

Akira laughed quietly while walking toward her.

Yuki reached forward naturally and took one of the heavier bags from his hand before entering the house beside him.

Their movements felt automatic.

Comfortable.

Practiced through decades of living together.

Inside the kitchen, they placed the shopping bags down carefully.

Akira looked around slightly.

“Where are Paari and Venitha?”

Yuki answered casually—

“Terrace.”

Akira nodded slowly while pretending complete innocence.
“Oh?”

“Mhm.”

“What are they doing there?”

Yuki shrugged dramatically.
“I don’t know.”

Akira almost laughed.

Terrible acting.

But cute.

Very cute.

Yuki turned toward him again.
“Shall we go upstairs?”

Akira looked at her suspiciously.
“Why do I suddenly feel unsafe?”

“Because you’re old.”

“That’s disrespectful.”

Yuki smiled proudly and began walking toward the stairs.

Akira followed slowly behind her.

And as they climbed higher—

the house became strangely quiet.

Too quiet.

The terrace remained completely dark.

No lights.

No sound.

Only wind.

Akira reached the final step and paused slightly.

Then suddenly—

“SURPRISE!!”

Lights exploded across the terrace all at once.

Warm golden decorations illuminated the entire rooftop while balloons danced softly in the wind.

Paari and **Venitha** stood near the center smiling brightly.

“Happy Birthday, Dad!”

“Happy Birthday, Mama!”

Behind him, **Yuki** stepped closer quietly before whispering softly near his shoulder—

“Happy Birthday... Akira.”

For a brief moment—

Akira simply stood there silently.

His eyes slowly moved across everything.

The lights.

The decorations.

The balloons.

The projector.

The table.

The effort.

The love hidden inside every detail.

And then—

his smile appeared.

Not a small smile.

A real one.

Bright.

Warm.

Emotional.

The kind of smile that only comes when the heart feels completely full.

“You all did this... for me?”

Paari immediately walked forward dramatically.

“Of course. You’re our old man.”

Akira pretended to look offended.

“Old?”

“Ancient.”

Venitha laughed loudly while Yuki shook her head helplessly.

Akira pointed toward Paari seriously.

“I raised you with love and this is how you speak to me?”

Paari grinned proudly.

“I learned from the best.”

And honestly—

Akira couldn’t stop smiling anymore.

The cool night wind moved gently through the terrace while warm lights glowed around them.

Everything looked beautiful beneath the dark sky.

Then Paari suddenly pointed toward the projector screen.

“Wait. There’s one more thing.”

Akira looked confused.

Paari quickly turned off the nearby music before starting the projector.

The screen lit up softly.

A black background appeared first.

Then slowly—
words faded into view.

“**Happy Birthday, Appa.**”

A calm melody began playing quietly.

And then—
photos started appearing one by one.

Old memories.

Akira holding baby **Paari** for the first time.

Young **Yuki** laughing beside him.

College photos.

Family trips.

Birthday celebrations.

Small ordinary moments captured over decades.

Every image carried a piece of life inside it.

Every memory carried love.

Akira’s expression slowly changed while watching the screen.

The smile on his face softened.

His eyes became wetter.

And when the final image appeared—
all three of them together smiling directly at the camera—

his heart broke beautifully.

The screen slowly faded black.

Then a final video appeared.

Yuki.
Paari.
Venitha.

Standing together.

Smiling warmly.
“Happy Birthday.”

For a few seconds—
nobody spoke.

Akira lowered his head slightly.
His shoulders trembled once.

Then quietly—
tears escaped.
Not painful tears.
Grateful tears.

The kind that come when someone realizes how deeply they are loved.

Paari’s expression immediately softened.

Without saying anything, he walked toward his father and hugged him tightly.

Akira hugged him back instantly.

Then Yuki joined them.

Then Venitha.

And under the peaceful night sky—

the entire family stood together in one silent embrace.

A small family.

A complete family.

A happy family.

And somewhere above them—

the stars watched quietly.

The wind moved softly across the terrace while the family slowly pulled away from the embrace.

But the warmth of that moment still remained between them.

Akira wiped the corner of his eyes once before looking at Paari.

“You made all this?”

Paari immediately pointed toward Venitha.

“She helped.”

Venitha crossed her arms proudly.

“I did most of the work.”

“That is a complete lie.”

“I emotionally supported the project.”

Akira laughed quietly while Yuki shook her head with a smile.

Even simple arguments sounded peaceful inside this family.

And somehow—

that peace itself felt rare.

Near the center of the terrace stood the birthday table decorated with candles and warm lights.

At the very middle—

the cake finally arrived.

Venitha carefully carried it toward the table while protecting it dramatically from the wind.

“Move carefully!” Paari shouted.

“I KNOW!”

“If the cake falls, Appa’s birthday becomes a funeral.”

“Paari!”

Everyone burst into laughter instantly.

Venitha finally placed the cake safely onto the stand and exhaled dramatically.

“There. Safe.”

Akira looked at the cake quietly.

Simple.
Beautiful.
Made with love.

And for some reason—
that mattered more to him than anything expensive in the world.

Yuki slowly stepped beside him.
“Cut it before your son says something worse.”

Paari looked offended immediately.
“I am a respectful person.”

“No,” all three answered together.

Paari placed a hand against his chest in betrayal.
“This family bullies me emotionally.”

Akira laughed again before finally picking up the knife.

For one brief second—
he looked at each of them carefully.

Yuki.
Paari.
Venitha.

His world.

Then slowly—
he cut the cake.

The moment the knife passed through the soft layers, applause and laughter immediately filled the terrace.

“Happy Birthday!”

Warm wind passed through the lights above them while the sound of happiness echoed into the quiet night.

Akira smiled helplessly.

He truly didn’t know how to explain what he was feeling anymore.

Some happiness becomes too large for words.

As expected—
the first piece went to Yuki.

Akira held the small piece of cake carefully near her lips.
Yuki looked at him for a second before smiling softly and taking a bite.

Paari immediately made a dramatic face.
“Thirty-four years later and still romantic. Disgusting.”

Yuki calmly grabbed cream from the cake and placed it directly on Paari’s cheek.

The entire terrace exploded with laughter.
“AMMA!”

“Respect your elders.”

Venitha almost fell laughing while Akira stood there proudly enjoying the chaos.
“You deserved that,” he said.

“This house supports violence,” Paari muttered sadly.

Then **Akira** fed cake to Venitha carefully.

“Take care of yourself, ma.”

Venitha smiled warmly.

“Always.”

Finally—

Akira turned toward **Paari**.

Instead of a small piece—

he intentionally gave him a massive bite of cake.

Paari’s eyes widened.

“Appa! I can’t even fit that—”

Too late.

Everyone laughed again while Paari struggled dramatically.

“This is attempted murder.”

“This is fatherly love,” Akira corrected proudly.

A little later, dinner was arranged across the terrace.

Warm food filled the table while soft music played quietly in the background.

The night sky above them looked unbelievably clear now.

Stars spread across the darkness while cool wind continued moving gently around the rooftop.

For hours—

they simply sat together.

Eating.

Talking.

Laughing.

Living.

And sometimes—

those ordinary nights become the memories people carry forever.

Paari leaned comfortably against his chair while holding a glass of juice.

“Appa,” he suddenly asked, “what was Amma like when you first met her?”

Yuki immediately narrowed her eyes.

“Careful what you say.”

Akira smiled slowly.

“She was scary.”

Yuki looked genuinely offended.

“I was NOT scary.”

“You rejected me three times.”

“That was called dignity.”

Paari laughed loudly.

“Three times?!”

Akira nodded dramatically.

“I suffered greatly.”

Yuki folded her arms.
 “You deserved it.”

Akira placed one hand over his heart.
 “See how she treats me even now?”

Venitha smiled softly while listening.
 She loved moments like this.
 Not because the stories were extraordinary.
 But because **the love inside them felt real.**

Akira leaned back slightly while remembering the past.
 “When I first saw your mother,” he said quietly, “I honestly thought she was too beautiful for me.”

Yuki’s expression softened immediately.
 “And now?” she asked softly.

Akira looked directly at her.
 “Now I know she still is.”

Silence fell for a brief second.

Not awkward silence.

Warm silence.

The kind created when love becomes too honest.

Venitha slowly smiled while **Paari** looked away dramatically.
 “I suddenly feel single.”

“You ARE married,” Venitha reminded him.

“That’s true.”

“Unfortunately.”

Paari gasped.
 “This house is emotionally dangerous.”

Hours passed quietly beneath the stars.

The projector continued showing old photos occasionally while stories moved from one memory to another.
 Akira spoke about Paari’s childhood.
 Yuki spoke about old vacations.
 Venitha listened while laughing softly at every embarrassing story about her husband.

And through all of it—

Akira kept watching them.
 Not obviously.
 Quietly.
 Like someone trying to memorize happiness itself.

Because deep inside his heart—
moments like this felt priceless.

Near midnight, the wind became colder.

Yuki slowly leaned against Akira once again while everyone’s energy softened into comfortable tiredness.

The lights above them continued glowing warmly against the dark sky.

And for one peaceful moment—

life felt perfect.

Not rich.

Not luxurious.

Not extraordinary.

Just perfect in the simplest way possible.

The family slowly began cleaning the terrace together while teasing each other endlessly.

Paari almost dropped plates twice.

Venitha yelled at him both times.

Akira laughed so hard he nearly lost balance.

And **Yuki** watched everything with soft eyes full of love.

Because this—

this right here—

was the life she had always dreamed of.

A peaceful home.

A loving husband.

A happy son.

A growing family.

No loneliness.

No emptiness.

Only warmth.

Only love.

Only togetherness.

And under the silent sky of Dindigul—

none of them realized how precious this night would later become in their memories.

By the time the terrace became quiet again, the clock had already crossed midnight.

The decorations still moved gently in the wind.

A few balloons floated lazily near the corners while the projector screen remained hanging beneath the night sky, softly touched by the cold air.

The birthday celebration had ended.

But ***the warmth of it still remained everywhere.***

Inside the house—

small traces of happiness could still be seen.

Half-finished coffee cups.

Cake cream on plates.

Laughter still echoing faintly inside memory.

And footsteps slowly growing quieter as everyone became tired.

Paari carried the last few plates toward the kitchen while Venitha followed behind him carefully.

“You almost dropped three plates today,” she said.

Paari looked offended immediately.

“It was only two.”

“That’s not better.”

“I was emotionally distracted.”

Venitha laughed softly.

“By what?”

Paari looked toward the living room where **Akira** and **Yuki** were still talking quietly.

“By them.”

Venitha’s expression softened immediately.

Honestly—

everyone inside that house secretly admired Akira and Yuki’s love.

Not because it was dramatic.

But because *it stayed beautiful even after time touched it.*

That kind of love had become rare.

Meanwhile, near the balcony area inside the house, Akira sat quietly while loosening the sleeves of his shirt.

Yuki returned from the kitchen carrying water and placed a glass beside him.

“You should sleep,” she said softly.

Akira looked at her.

“You too.”

Yuki smiled faintly before sitting beside him.

The house had become peaceful now.

No loud voices.

No movement.

Only the distant sound of crickets outside and the soft wind brushing against the windows.

For a while—

they simply sat together in silence.

Comfortable silence.

The kind built through decades of knowing each other completely.

Finally, Yuki leaned gently against his shoulder.

“Tired?”

Akira smiled softly.

“A little.”

“Happy?”

This time—

Akira didn’t answer immediately.

Instead, he looked around the house quietly.

At the family photos hanging on the wall.

At the hallway leading toward Paari’s room.

At the peaceful darkness filling the home.

Then finally—

his eyes returned to **Yuki**.

“Very.”

Yuki’s lips curved into a small smile.

“That’s good.”

Akira slowly reached for her hand and intertwined his fingers with hers naturally.

“You know something?” he whispered softly.

“What?”

“I don’t think I could ask life for anything more.”

Yuki looked at him silently for a few seconds.

Then lowered her eyes slightly.

“Me too.”

And somehow—

those two simple words carried an entire lifetime inside them.

A few minutes later, footsteps approached from behind.

Paari stood near the hallway entrance while rubbing the back of his neck awkwardly.

“Appa...”

Akira looked up.

“Hm?”

Paari hesitated for a second before speaking quietly.

“Thank you.”

Akira blinked once.

“For what?”

“For... everything.”

The room became still.

Paari wasn’t smiling now.

His voice carried honesty too deep to joke about.

“You gave us this life,” he continued softly.

“This home.”

“This peace.”

“You always protected us without making us feel the weight of it.”

Akira looked at his son silently.

And suddenly—

he saw the little boy Paari once was.

The child who used to hold his finger while crossing roads.

The teenager who once cried over heartbreak on the terrace.

And now—

a man preparing to become a father himself.

Time really moved quietly.

Akira slowly stood up and walked toward him.

Then placed one hand gently against **Paari’s** cheek.
 “You already gave me everything I wanted,” he said softly.

Paari’s eyes immediately became wet again.
 “Why do I cry so easily in this house?”

“Bad genetics,” Yuki answered instantly.

Paari laughed through his tears while **Akira** smiled helplessly.

Then suddenly—

Venitha appeared from behind the hallway.
 “Mama...”

Akira turned toward her.

She smiled shyly before speaking softly.
 “Thank you for treating me like your daughter.”

Akira’s expression softened deeply.

Without hesitation, he walked toward her and gently placed one hand on her head.
 “You already are.”

Venitha immediately looked down to hide the tears forming in her eyes.

And for a moment—
the house became emotional again.

Not because of sadness.

But because ***love itself sometimes becomes overwhelming.***

Later that night, everyone slowly returned to their rooms.

The lights inside the house turned off one by one until only the soft balcony light remained glowing quietly near the hallway.

Outside—
 the hills stood peacefully beneath the moonlight.

The wind continued moving through the trees while clouds drifted slowly across the sky.

And inside their room—
 Yuki quietly arranged the blanket while Akira changed clothes nearby.

“You’re still smiling,” she said suddenly.

Akira looked at her innocently.
 “Can’t I smile?”

“You look too happy.”

“I am too happy.”

Yuki laughed softly before sitting on the edge of the bed.

For a brief moment, Akira simply stood there watching her.

Even after all these years—
his heart still softened every time he looked at her peacefully like this.

Yuki noticed him staring again.
 “What?”

Akira shook his head slowly.

“Nothing.”

“That’s a lie.”

Akira walked closer before sitting beside her.

Then quietly—

he rested his forehead gently against hers.

“Thank you,” he whispered.

Yuki smiled softly.

“For what this time?”

“For staying.”

The room became silent.

Yuki slowly closed her eyes for a moment while holding his hand gently.

“I’ll always stay,” she whispered back.

And somewhere outside—

the night wind moved softly through the hills of Dindigul.

As if ***the world itself wanted to protect this moment forever.***

That night—

sleep arrived peacefully inside the house.

No fear.

No pain.

No sadness.

Only warmth.

Only family.

Only love.

And above them—

the quiet sky watched silently.

Knowing something they did not yet know themselves.

That sometimes—

the most beautiful nights become memories far too soon.

Chapter 2 — The Night Park and Old Memories

Morning arrived slowly over the hills of *Dindigul*.

Soft sunlight slipped through the curtains while cold wind moved gently across the balcony outside. Birds sang somewhere near the trees, and the peaceful house slowly began waking from sleep.

Inside the kitchen—

Akira was already awake.

The smell of coffee quietly filled the air while steam rose gently from four cups placed neatly across the counter.

Even after last night’s celebration, he had still woken up before everyone else.

Old habits never really leave people.

Akira moved calmly through the kitchen preparing breakfast.

Boiled eggs.

Cut fruits.

Vegetable salad.

Simple food.

Healthy food.

The kind Yuki always forced everyone to eat.

A faint smile appeared on his face while remembering all the years she had argued with Paari about vegetables.

Suddenly—

soft footsteps approached behind him.

“Good morning...”

Yuki’s sleepy voice carried through the kitchen softly.

Akira turned immediately.

And for one brief second—

he simply looked at her.

Messy hair.

Sleepy eyes.

Oversized nightwear.

And a face that still made his heart feel peaceful after all these years.

“Good morning, my love,” he replied quietly.

Yuki smiled faintly before walking closer.

Akira gently wrapped one arm around her waist and pulled her toward him slowly.

Then he kissed her forehead softly.

“Did you brush your teeth?” he asked suspiciously.

Yuki immediately punched his shoulder lightly.

“Akira!”

“What? Important question.”

“You ruin romantic moments.”

Akira laughed quietly.

“Go brush first. Coffee is waiting.”

Yuki narrowed her eyes dramatically.

“You’re lucky I love you.”

“I know.”

Still mumbling complaints under her breath, **Yuki** walked toward the washroom while **Akira** continued smiling to himself like a teenager.

A few minutes later, Yuki returned properly awake this time.

“I brushed,” she announced proudly.

Akira handed her a coffee cup immediately.

“Very good. Society is safe again.”

Yuki laughed softly before sitting near the kitchen counter beside him.

Morning sunlight slowly entered the room while the peaceful sound of boiling tea and birds outside filled the silence between them.

Akira leaned slightly against the counter while sipping coffee.

“So,” he asked casually, “any plans today?”

Yuki thought for a moment.

“I don’t think so.”

Akira nodded slowly.

“That means we can create a new plan.”

Yuki smiled.

“You always need a plan for something.”

“That’s because life becomes boring otherwise.”

“Your son already inherited that problem.”

Akira looked proud immediately.

“Good.”

Suddenly—

a loud scream shattered the peaceful atmosphere.

“PAARI—!”

Both Akira and Yuki froze instantly.

Venitha.

Without wasting even one second, Akira rushed toward Paari’s room while Yuki followed behind him anxiously.

Another scream came from inside.

This time louder.

More painful.

Akira knocked hard against the door.

“Paari!”

The door opened immediately.

Paari stood there completely panicked.

“Appa—!”

Inside the room, Venitha held her stomach tightly while breathing heavily.

Pain covered her face.

Akira understood instantly.

The baby.

“It started?” he asked quickly.

Paari nodded helplessly.

“Yes!”

Akira immediately pulled out his phone and called the ambulance.

But after hearing the delay time, his expression changed sharply.

Too long.

Without hesitation, he looked directly at Paari.

“Bring the car keys.”

Within minutes—

the **BMW M3** roared out of the house.

The roads of *Dindigul* blurred beneath the speeding car.

Akira drove with complete focus while Paari held **Venitha** carefully from the backseat.

Yuki continuously tried calming her.

“It’s okay, ma...”

“Just breathe...”

Venitha cried out again while gripping Paari’s hand tightly.

Paari’s face had already turned pale.

“Appa, drive faster.”

“I am driving fast.”

“This is not fast enough.”

Akira glanced once through the mirror.

“You panic more than the pregnant woman.”

“I AM SCARED!”

Even in the middle of fear—

Akira almost smiled.

Because Paari’s eyes carried something beautiful right now.

Love.

Pure love.

The hospital doors opened quickly the moment they arrived.

Nurses immediately rushed Venitha toward the emergency maternity ward while doctors began preparing everything rapidly.

And suddenly—

everything became quiet.

Not outside.

Inside.

That strange silence people feel when fear enters the heart.

Paari stood frozen near the hallway.

His fingers trembled slightly.

His mind refused to think clearly anymore.

Akira quietly placed one hand on his shoulder.

“She’ll be okay.”

Paari swallowed hard.

“What if something goes wrong?”

Akira’s voice remained calm.

“Nothing will happen.”

“But what if—”

“Paari.”

Akira’s tone softened slightly.

“Trust her.”

Silence returned.

And slowly—

Paari nodded.

Time began moving strangely after that.

Minutes felt longer.

The hospital lights felt colder.

Every sound became noticeable.

Footsteps.

Machines.

Voices from distant rooms.

Even breathing.

Yuki sat quietly nearby praying silently beneath her breath while Paari continued pacing endlessly across the hallway.

Akira watched him carefully.

Then finally spoke.

“I’ll be back in twenty minutes.”

Paari stopped walking immediately.

“Where are you going?”

“Small work.”

“At this time?”

Akira simply smiled faintly.

“Trust me.”

And without explaining further—

he quietly walked away from the hospital.

Neither Yuki nor Paari stopped him.

Because sometimes—

Akira carried a calmness that made people believe everything would somehow become alright.

The hospital hallway felt colder as time moved forward.

White walls.

Soft footsteps.

Distant machine sounds.

And ***fear silently sitting inside every heartbeat.***

Paari continued walking back and forth near the maternity ward like a man trying to outrun his own thoughts.

Every few seconds, his eyes moved toward the delivery room doors.

Waiting.

Praying.

Hoping.

Yuki sat quietly nearby with both hands tightly folded together. Her lips moved softly beneath her breath as she whispered small prayers again and again.

And through all of it—

Akira still hadn’t returned.

Inside the delivery room, Venitha cried out once more while doctors and nurses worked quickly around her.

Sweat covered her forehead.

Pain shook her entire body.

But beneath all the fear—

one thing remained stronger.

The desire to hold her child.

A nurse gently held her hand.

“Just a little more.”

Venitha closed her eyes tightly while trying to breathe properly.

Meanwhile outside—

Paari suddenly stopped walking.

His chest tightened.

For some reason, he felt helpless.

Completely helpless.

No matter how much he loved her...

he couldn’t take away her pain.

That realization alone almost broke him.

He slowly sat down and buried his face in his hands.

Yuki quietly looked at her son.

Then softly—

she placed one hand over his head.

Exactly the same way she used to comfort him during childhood.

“She’s strong,” Yuki whispered.

Paari’s eyes became wet again.

“I know...”

His voice cracked slightly.

“But I’m scared.”

Yuki smiled faintly through her own worry.
“That means you already became a father.”

Time passed slowly.

Painfully slowly.

Then suddenly—
the maternity room doors opened slightly.

A doctor stepped outside.

Paari stood up immediately.

His heartbeat became louder than everything else around him.

The doctor removed his mask slowly.

And smiled.
“Congratulations.”

For one brief second—

Paari stopped breathing entirely.
“You have a baby girl.”

Silence.

Then—
emotion exploded inside him all at once.

Relief.
Happiness.
Shock.
Love.

Fear disappearing instantly.

His eyes filled with tears before he could even stop them.
“A... girl?”

The doctor nodded warmly.
“Both mother and baby are healthy.”

Yuki immediately covered her mouth emotionally while tears rolled down her cheeks.

And at that exact moment—

Akira returned.

He had just entered the hallway when he heard the words.
“You have a baby girl.”

Akira froze for half a second.

Then slowly—
a smile spread across his face.

A real one.
Warm.
Proud.
Beautiful.

He walked directly toward Paari and pulled him into a tight embrace.
“Congratulations, da...”

Paari hugged him back immediately.

And suddenly—
he began crying like a child.

Not because he was weak.
 But because *some happiness becomes too large for the human heart to carry quietly.*

Akira gently tapped his son’s back.

And for a brief moment—
 his own eyes became wet too.
 Because he still remembered the day Paari himself was born.

And now—
life had moved forward again.

Another generation.
 Another heartbeat.
 Another beginning.

A few minutes later, a nurse carefully walked out carrying the newborn baby wrapped in a soft white cloth.

“Father?” she called gently.

Paari froze completely.
 Then slowly stepped forward.

The nurse carefully placed the baby into his trembling hands.
And the world changed.

Instantly.

The little girl moved slightly beneath the blanket while tiny fingers curled weakly against his chest.

Paari stared at her silently.
 His breathing became uneven.
 His hands trembled.
 And tears continued falling without permission.

“She’s so small...” he whispered.

The nurse smiled softly.
 “That’s usually how babies work.”

But Paari barely heard her.

Because *nothing else existed anymore.*
 Not the hospital.
 Not the noise.
 Not the world.

Only her.
 His daughter.

His entire heart suddenly living outside his body.

And yet—
 even while holding the baby—
 his eyes searched desperately for one person.

Venitha.
 “Is she okay?” he asked immediately.

The nurse nodded warmly.
 “She’s perfectly fine. She just needs rest.”

Only then did **Paari** finally breathe properly again.

That was love too.

Not choosing between mother and child.

But ***fearing to lose either one.***

A little later, the nurse finally informed them that **Venitha** had regained consciousness. Everyone immediately moved toward the room.

Inside, Venitha looked exhausted.

Weak.

But peaceful.

The moment Paari entered carrying the baby—
her eyes slowly softened.

And suddenly—
all the pain she suffered felt worth it.

Paari carefully sat beside her while holding her hand tightly.

“How do you feel?” he whispered.

“Tired,” she replied honestly.

Then her eyes immediately moved toward the baby.
“How does she look?”

Paari smiled through tears.
“Like you.”

Venitha laughed weakly.
“That poor child.”

Yuki smiled warmly nearby while **Akira** stood silently watching the scene unfold.

And for a brief moment—
his heart felt unbelievably full.

This was life.

Pain and happiness arriving together.

Then suddenly, Venitha spoke again.
“Mama...”

Akira stepped slightly closer.
“Yes, ma?”

Venitha hesitated for a moment before speaking softly.
“I wish my parents were here...”

The room became quiet instantly.

Paari lowered his eyes.

Because everyone knew the situation between Venitha and her family had remained complicated since the marriage.

Venitha forced a small smile.
“They probably won’t come...”

Then—
Akira calmly answered.
“I think they’re already here.”

Everyone turned toward him immediately.

Venitha blinked in confusion.

“What?”

Akira smiled faintly.

“They’re waiting outside.”

For a moment—

Venitha looked completely frozen.

Then suddenly—

her eyes filled with tears.

“You brought them?”

Akira nodded gently.

“You wanted them here.”

Venitha covered her mouth emotionally while crying silently.

“Can... can you call them inside?”

Akira smiled softly.

“Of course.”

As he turned and walked toward the door, **Paari** followed behind him quickly.

The moment they stepped outside into the hallway, Paari suddenly grabbed Akira’s arm.

His voice became serious.

“How did you know?”

Akira looked at him innocently.

“Know what?”

“That she wanted her parents here.”

Akira smiled quietly.

Then gently tapped Paari’s chest.

“Because you forgot something.”

Paari frowned slightly.

“What?”

Akira’s expression softened with pride.

“I’m your father.”

And somehow—

that single sentence carried years of love inside it.

Paari immediately hugged him again without saying another word.

Because sometimes—

there are no words strong enough for gratitude.

Twenty-one days passed quietly after Lisa’s birth.

And within those twenty-one days—
the entire house changed.

Before, the home had carried the voices of four people.

Now—
a fifth voice ruled everything.

A tiny voice.

Sometimes crying.
Sometimes laughing.
Sometimes making sounds that nobody understood—

yet everyone responded to immediately.

Little **Lisa** had unknowingly become the center of the house.

And honestly—
nobody minded.

Morning no longer began peacefully.

Now it began with panic.
“Why is she crying?”
“Did she drink milk?”
“Did she sleep properly?”
“Where’s the blanket?”

“Paari, support the neck properly!”

Every single day—
the house became louder.

Messier.
More chaotic.

And strangely—
far happier.

One morning, **Akira** walked into the living room holding Lisa carefully against his chest while softly humming an old melody.

The little girl stared at him with wide curious eyes.

“Why are you looking at me like that?” Akira whispered gently.
“Hmm?”

Lisa moved her tiny fingers weakly against his shirt.
Akira immediately smiled like she had solved the secrets of the universe.

Behind him, **Paari** walked into the room carrying baby bottles and looking completely sleep-deprived.
“I haven’t slept properly in three days,” he muttered dramatically.

Akira looked proud.
“Good. Fatherhood has started.”

“This feels illegal.”

Venitha entered slowly from the kitchen while shaking her head helplessly.
“You wanted a baby.”

“I wanted a cute baby.”

Lisa immediately began crying loudly the moment Paari held her.

The entire room burst into laughter.

“See?” Venitha pointed proudly.
“She already has standards.”

Paari looked betrayed.
“This child is against me.”

Akira laughed so hard he almost lost balance while holding **Lisa**.

And somehow—
moments like this filled the house every single day now.

Even **Yuki** seemed brighter around the baby.

She carried Lisa gently through the house while singing old lullabies under her breath.
Sometimes she sat near the balcony rocking the baby slowly while evening wind moved through the curtains.
Sometimes she simply watched her sleep peacefully for long periods without speaking at all.
And every single time Akira noticed that expression on Yuki’s face—

his heart softened quietly.

Because ***motherhood had never truly left her.***
Not even after all these years.

One evening, all four of them sat together in the living room discussing only one important matter.

Lisa’s name.

Or rather—
what her name should become.

Papers filled with name ideas were scattered across the table.

Venitha rejected almost everything immediately.
“No.”
“Too common.”
“No.”
“Too complicated.”
“No.”

“That sounds like a movie villain.”

Paari sighed dramatically.
“This child will grow up nameless.”

Yuki laughed softly while holding the baby carefully.

Then suddenly—

Akira spoke.
“What about Lisa?”

The room became quiet for a moment.

Venitha slowly repeated it.
“Lisa...”

Paari looked thoughtful.

Yuki smiled faintly.
“It sounds beautiful.”

Akira gently reached forward and carried the baby carefully into his arms.

Then slowly—

he leaned closer toward her tiny ear.
“Lisa...”

The baby blinked once.

Akira smiled softly.
“Lisa...”

And then—
something small happened.
But something ***nobody there would ever forget.***

The baby smiled.
A tiny smile.
A sudden one.
Pure.

Instantly—

everyone reacted emotionally.
“She smiled!”

“Did you see that?!”

“I think she likes it!”

Yuki laughed softly while tears almost reached her eyes.
And Akira—
Akira simply looked at the baby silently.
His expression carried something deeper than happiness.

Connection.
As if the child had already accepted the name herself.

From that day onward—
she became Lisa.

The days continued peacefully after that.

Late-night crying.
Family dinners.
Sleepless mornings.
Small arguments over diapers.
Warm evenings on the balcony.
Tiny moments slowly becoming unforgettable memories.

And through all of it—
Akira kept watching everyone quietly.

The happiness inside the house felt complete now.

Complete in a way words could barely explain.

But slowly—
something began changing.

Small things at first.
Almost unnoticeable.

Yuki became tired more often.
Sometimes she sat down silently after doing simple work.
Sometimes she stopped eating halfway through meals.

Sometimes she smiled normally—
but looked exhausted beneath it.

At first, nobody worried too much.
Not even **Akira**.
He thought it was normal tiredness.
Age.
Stress.
Lack of sleep because of the baby.

But one evening—
while everyone sat together near the living room—
Yuki suddenly became dizzy while standing.

Akira immediately noticed.

Before anyone else.

He stood up quickly.
“Yuki?”

She forced a small smile instantly.
“I’m okay.”

But her voice felt weaker than usual.

Akira walked toward her slowly.
“Sit down first.”

Yuki obeyed quietly.

For a few moments, nobody spoke.
Lisa’s small noises still filled the room softly while tension slowly formed beneath the silence.
Akira crouched slightly near Yuki.
“You’ve been tired for days.”

“It’s nothing.”

“You’re not eating properly.”

“I’m fine.”

Akira looked directly into her eyes.
And for the first time in many years—
something inside his chest felt uneasy.
Not fear.
Not yet.
Just...

a strange heaviness.
The kind that arrives before storms.

Yuki noticed the change in his expression immediately.

So she gently smiled and touched his hand.
“Don’t look at me like that,” she whispered softly.

Akira tried smiling back.

But somehow—
his heart no longer felt peaceful.

And outside the house—
the evening sky slowly darkened above the hills of *Dindigul*.

As if *life itself had quietly begun changing direction.*

Chapter 3 — The Birth of Lisa

The drive toward the hospital felt longer this time.

Not because the road had changed.

But because ***Akira’s heart had.***

The **BMW** moved steadily through the evening streets while rain clouds slowly gathered above Dindigul.

Inside the car—

silence sat heavily between them.

Yuki rested quietly against the seat beside him while holding her stomach gently.

Her face looked pale.

Tired.

And even though she continued trying to smile normally—

Akira noticed everything.

He always did.

“Are you feeling worse?” he asked softly without taking his eyes off the road.

Yuki shook her head slowly.

“I’m okay.”

That answer only made him worry more.

Because after ***thirty-four years together***—

Akira had learned one important thing.

Whenever Yuki said “*I’m okay*” softly like that...

she usually wasn’t.

The wind outside became stronger while the car continued climbing the road toward the hospital.

Akira tightened his fingers slightly around the steering wheel.

Something inside him refused to calm down.

When they finally arrived, the hospital atmosphere immediately felt colder than usual.

White walls.

Bright lights.

The smell of medicine.

People walking quickly through hallways carrying invisible worries inside them.

A nurse guided Yuki toward the scanning room while Akira completed the registration process nearby.

Even while speaking to the receptionist—

his eyes continuously searched for Yuki.

As if losing sight of her even briefly made his chest uncomfortable.

A little later, Yuki returned slowly after the first scan.

Akira immediately stood up.

“How was it?”

Yuki tried smiling

“They’re asking for more tests.”

Akira’s expression changed slightly.

“More tests?”

The nurse nodded professionally.

“The doctor wants additional scans just to confirm a few things.”

“Is something wrong?” Akira asked immediately.

“Please wait for the doctor,” the nurse answered gently before walking away.

And suddenly—

the silence around Akira became heavier.

Hours passed slowly inside the hospital.

Too slowly.

Yuki completed one test after another while Akira remained beside her through all of it.

Every hallway.

Every waiting room.

Every report.

He never once left her alone.

Even now—

he still held her hand whenever they walked together.

As if ***love itself had become instinct.***

At one point, while waiting near another scanning room, Akira quietly looked toward her.

“You need anything?”

Yuki smiled weakly.

“No.”

“Juice?”

“No.”

“Coffee?”

“You’ll drink it before me.”

“That’s true.”

Yuki laughed softly despite her exhaustion.

And hearing that small laugh somehow eased his chest slightly.

Even in fear—

he still wanted her to smile.

Finally, the doctor called them into his office.

The room felt strangely quiet.

Too quiet.

Akira immediately noticed the seriousness in the doctor’s expression.

And somewhere deep inside—

his heart already understood before the words arrived.

“Please sit.”

Both of them sat down slowly.

The doctor looked carefully through the reports again before finally removing his glasses.

For a brief second—

nobody spoke.

Then quietly—

the doctor began explaining.

“There’s a condition affecting the brain.”

Akira’s fingers slowly tightened.

Yuki remained completely silent.

The doctor continued gently.

“It has already progressed beyond the early stages.”

Akira stared at him.

His mind refused to process the words properly.

“There must be treatment options,” he said immediately.

The doctor hesitated.

“There are procedures we could attempt...”

“Then do them.”

“But the risk is extremely high.”

“I don’t care about the risk.”

The doctor’s expression softened sadly.

“The surgery itself could take her life immediately.”

Silence.

The room suddenly felt smaller.

Heavier.

Harder to breathe inside.

Akira looked toward Yuki instantly.

She hadn’t cried.

Not even once.

But her eyes—

her eyes had already begun breaking quietly.

The doctor lowered his voice gently.

“We can slow the progression with medication...”

A pause.

“But realistically...”

He stopped himself for a second.

Then finally spoke the sentence neither of them were prepared to hear.

“She may only have around one month left.”

The world became silent.

Not emotionally silent.
Completely silent.
Like sound itself had disappeared.

Akira stared ahead without moving.

His mind rejected the sentence immediately.
One month?
Impossible.

No.
No.

This was Yuki.
His Yuki.

The woman who built his entire life beside him.
The woman who turned a house into a home.
The woman who stood beside him through every struggle.

How could life suddenly place a time limit on someone like her?
“There must be another way,” he whispered.

The doctor slowly shook his head.
“I’m sorry.”

Akira asked again.

This time weaker.
“There has to be something.”

The doctor lowered his eyes silently.

And that silence alone became the answer.

For the first time in years—
Akira broke.
Not loudly.
Not dramatically.
Just quietly.
His breathing became uneven.

His eyes filled slowly.

And despite every attempt to stay strong—
tears escaped.

Yuki immediately turned toward him.
Even now—

even in her own fear—
she worried about him first.

Slowly, she reached for his hand.

Akira looked at her.
And seeing her trying to comfort him...

hurt even more.

Yuki finally leaned gently against his shoulder.

And only then—
did her own tears begin falling too.

No loud crying.

No screaming.

Just *two people silently realizing that time had suddenly become precious.*

Painfully precious.

The doctor quietly gave them the medicines and explained a few precautions afterward.

But honestly—

neither of them truly heard most of it anymore.

Their hearts were elsewhere now.

Somewhere between fear...

love...

and the unbearable weight of losing tomorrow.

When they finally stepped outside the hospital—

night had already fallen across the city.

Rain clouds covered the sky completely.

The world looked darker now.

Or maybe—

their hearts did.

Akira opened the car door for Yuki carefully before sitting inside himself.

For several minutes—

neither of them spoke.

Only rain began falling softly against the windshield.

Then finally—

Akira asked the question quietly.

“Where do you want to go?”

Yuki slowly turned toward him.

Her eyes were still wet.

But her voice remained gentle.

“I don’t want any special place.”

A pause.

Then softly—

“Wherever you go... I want to go too.”

And hearing those words—

completely shattered him.

Rain continued falling softly as the **BMW** moved through the quiet roads outside Dindigul.

Streetlights blurred across the wet windshield while old songs played faintly through the speakers.

Inside the car—
silence remained.

But it was no longer an empty silence.

It was ***the silence of two hearts trying to stay strong for each other.***

Akira drove slowly without deciding on a destination.

Or maybe—
his heart had already chosen one unconsciously.

After nearly thirty minutes, the car finally left the city roads and began climbing toward the hills.

The rain became lighter there.

Mist slowly moved between the trees while cold wind wrapped around the mountain roads.

Finally, Akira stopped the car near a quiet viewpoint overlooking the sleeping city below.

For a moment—
neither of them moved.
Only the sound of rain touching leaves filled the darkness.

Then Akira quietly stepped out first and walked toward Yuki’s side before opening the door carefully.

The cold wind touched them immediately.

Nearby, an old wooden bench rested beneath a dim streetlight facing the hills.

Akira slowly held Yuki’s hand.

And together—
they walked toward it.

The mountain felt unbelievably quiet tonight.

Clouds drifted slowly across the sky while distant city lights shimmered far below like scattered stars.

Yuki sat beside Akira on the wooden bench and leaned gently against his shoulder.

Their fingers remained intertwined tightly.
Neither of them wanted to let go.
Not tonight.
Maybe not ever.

For a long time—
they simply sat there silently watching the fog move through the hills.

Then finally—

Yuki spoke softly.
“You’re thinking too much.”

Akira laughed weakly beneath his breath.
“How do you still notice that?”

“You married me,” she whispered.

“That’s your mistake.”

Akira slowly turned toward her.

“No,” he said quietly.

“That was the best thing I ever did.”

Yuki smiled faintly.

Even now—

his words still reached her heart the same way they always had.

The wind became colder.

Akira gently adjusted her shawl around her shoulders carefully.

The movement felt automatic.

Loving someone for decades turns care into instinct.

Yuki watched him silently while he fixed the edges properly.

Then softly—

she asked,

“Are you angry?”

Akira looked confused.

“At what?”

“At life.”

The question stayed between them quietly.

Akira slowly leaned back against the bench and looked toward the dark sky above the hills.

For several seconds—

he didn’t answer.

Then finally—

he spoke honestly.

“I don’t know.”

A pause.

“I think I’m scared.”

That sentence alone carried more pain than tears ever could.

Because ***Akira was not a man who feared easily.***

But losing Yuki—

that terrified him.

Yuki slowly held his hand tighter.

“You know something?” she whispered softly.

Akira looked toward her.

“I never asked life for perfection.”

Her voice became calmer.

“I only wanted a peaceful life beside you.”

Akira’s eyes immediately softened.

Yuki smiled gently through her tears.

“And I got it.”

The wind moved softly around them.

“I lived the life I dreamed of, Akira.”

Those words ***broke something inside him quietly.***

Because ***she truly meant them.***

No regrets.

No complaints.

Only gratitude.

And somehow—

that made everything hurt even more.

Akira suddenly lowered his head while tears escaped again.

“I can’t do this,” he whispered painfully.

“I can’t lose you.”

Yuki immediately moved closer and held his face gently between both hands.

“Hey...”

Her voice softened further.

“Look at me.”

Akira slowly lifted his eyes.

Yuki smiled faintly despite the tears resting there.

“You once told Paari something,” she whispered.

Akira frowned slightly.

“What?”

“That life gives...”

“And life takes away.”

Silence.

Then Yuki gently touched his forehead against hers.

“So don’t spend my remaining time fearing the ending.”

A pause.

“Spend it loving me.”

The rain slowly faded around the hills.

And for one long moment—

Akira simply closed his eyes.

Trying to memorize her voice.

Her warmth.

Her presence.

Everything.

Because suddenly—

every second mattered.

After a while, Yuki looked toward the distant city lights below.

“I have one wish.”

Akira immediately answered.
“Anything.”

“You must not tell Paari and Venitha.”

Akira froze.

“What?”

Yuki looked at him quietly.
“If they know...”

Her voice trembled slightly for the first time.
“They’ll stop smiling.”

Akira immediately shook his head.
“They deserve to know.”

“And they deserve happiness too.”

Tears rolled slowly down Yuki’s cheeks now.
“If we tell them... every remaining day will become fear.”

She lowered her eyes.
“I don’t want Lisa’s first month inside sadness.”

Akira looked at her silently.

Yuki continued softly—
“I want this house to stay warm.”
“I want laughter.”
“I want movie nights.”
“I want balcony coffee.”
“I want to see them happy naturally.”

Then slowly—
she smiled again.
“Because when they smile...”
“I feel alive.”

Akira completely broke again hearing that.

How could someone facing death still think only about protecting others?
He held her tightly without speaking.

And beneath the cold mountain wind—
he cried quietly against her shoulder.

After some time, Yuki gently wiped his tears herself.

Then suddenly—
she laughed softly.

Akira blinked in confusion.
“What?”

“You look terrible when you cry.”

Akira stared at her for a second.

Then unbelievably—
he laughed too.
A broken laugh.

But real.

Yuki smiled proudly.

“There. Better.”

The mountain remained silent around them while the night deepened slowly.

And there—

between fog, rain, and fading time—

two people chose something important.

Not fear.

Not despair.

Love.

Pure love.

The kind that stays gentle even while breaking apart.

Eventually, Yuki leaned against him once more and whispered softly—

“I’m hungry.”

Akira looked at her immediately.

“Now?”

“Yes.”

“What do you want?”

Yuki thought seriously for a moment.

“Home food.”

Akira smiled faintly.

“Very expensive request.”

“Can you afford it?”

“For you?”

He gently kissed her forehead.

“I would buy the whole world.”

And finally—

the **BMW** slowly began driving back toward home.

Back toward the house filled with warmth.

Back toward the family that still knew nothing.

Back toward ***one final month***—

that would quietly become ***the most precious days of their lives.***

When the car finally entered the gate of the house, the night had already become quiet again.

The terrace lights were off now.

The birthday decorations still moved gently in the cold wind while the house itself rested peacefully beneath the hills of Dindigul.

Inside—
laughter still existed.
Warmth still existed.

And somehow—
that made the truth even harder to carry.

Akira parked the car slowly before stepping out first.
 He immediately walked toward Yuki’s side and opened the door for her carefully.
 Even the smallest actions became gentler now.

More careful.
 More protective.

Yuki noticed it immediately.
 “You’re treating me like glass,” she whispered softly.

Akira forced a faint smile.
 “You’re precious.”

Yuki looked at him silently for a moment before holding his hand again.

And together—
they walked inside the house carrying a secret heavy enough to destroy peace itself.

The moment they entered—
Paari immediately stood up from the sofa.
 “What happened? Why did it take so long?”

His voice carried concern instantly.

Venitha also looked worried while holding sleeping **Lisa** carefully against her chest.

Akira answered calmly before Yuki could speak.
 “Nothing serious.”

Paari frowned.
 “Then why were you there for hours?”

“Doctor said she became weak because she’s not eating properly.”

Yuki quietly followed the lie with a soft smile.
 “They gave medicines.”

Venitha sighed in relief.
 “That scared us.”

Akira nodded gently.
 “She only needs rest.”

And somehow—
he said those words without his voice breaking.
 Even though *his heart already felt shattered.*

That night, dinner became strangely emotional for Akira.

Not because anyone else noticed something.
 But because suddenly—
every small moment mattered.

The sound of **Yuki** laughing.

The way she adjusted **Lisa’s** blanket.

The way she looked at everyone while listening to conversations.

Even ordinary things felt painfully beautiful now.

As if ***life itself had become fragile.***

Paari sat near Lisa while trying to make funny faces at her.
“She definitely smiled at me.”

Venitha immediately shook her head.
“She smiled because you finally stopped talking.”

“Unbelievable disrespect in this house.”

Yuki laughed softly beside them.

And hearing that laugh—
Akira quietly looked away.

Because he suddenly realized something terrifying.

***One day...
this sound would disappear.***
Later that night, everyone gathered in the living room.

Lisa rested peacefully between them while conversations slowly drifted toward old memories.

Paari spoke about college life.
Venitha complained about pregnancy cravings.
Yuki teased Akira about forgetting anniversaries years ago.

And through all of it—
Akira simply watched.

Memorizing.

Collecting moments silently inside his heart.

Because now—
every second felt temporary.

After some time, Lisa slowly began crying.

Venitha carefully lifted her and tried calming her gently.

But the baby continued crying stubbornly.

Paari panicked instantly.
“Why is she crying?”

“She’s a baby.”

“But WHY?”

“Paari,” Venitha sighed helplessly, “babies cry.”

“This feels personal.”

Akira finally stood up smiling faintly before taking Lisa carefully into his arms.

And almost immediately—
the crying stopped.

The room became silent.

Paari looked offended.
 “She likes Appa more than me.”

Akira looked proud immediately.
 “Excellent child.”

Yuki laughed quietly while watching them.

The warmth inside the room became softer again.

And for a brief moment—
even Akira forgot the fear sitting inside him.
 Hours later, everyone slowly returned toward their rooms.

Only Akira and Yuki remained awake.
 The bedroom felt peaceful beneath the dim yellow light while cold wind moved gently through the curtains near the balcony.

Yuki sat quietly against the bed while brushing her hair slowly.
 Akira stood near the balcony door watching her silently.

Not speaking.
Just looking.
 Like a man trying to hold onto time itself.

Finally, Yuki noticed.
 “You’ve been staring at me for ten minutes.”

Akira didn’t deny it.
 “I know.”

Yuki smiled faintly.
 “What are you thinking?”

Akira slowly walked toward her before sitting beside her carefully.

Then quietly—
 he whispered the truth he couldn’t tell anyone else.
 “I’m scared to sleep.”

Yuki’s expression softened instantly.
 “Why?”

“What if I wake up one day...”

His voice cracked slightly.
 “And you’re gone?”

Silence filled the room immediately.

Yuki slowly reached for his hand and intertwined her fingers with his.
 “I’m still here.”

Akira closed his eyes briefly.
 “Yes.”

“But not long enough.”

The tears returned again.
Quietly.

He tried controlling them.

But *love that deep cannot hide pain easily.*

Yuki gently rested her forehead against his shoulder.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“Then let’s stop counting how much time is left.”

A pause.

“And start living every second properly.”

Akira slowly looked at her.

Yuki smiled weakly.

“Promise me something.”

“Anything.”

“When I’m with you...”

Her voice became softer.

“Don’t look at me like I’m dying.”

That sentence alone *almost destroyed him.*

Because he realized—

she was trying harder to protect him than herself.

Akira carefully held her face between both hands.

Then kissed her forehead gently.

“I promise.”

And for the rest of the night—

they stayed awake together.

Talking softly.

Remembering old stories.

Sharing forgotten memories.

Sometimes laughing.

Sometimes crying quietly.

But *never leaving each other’s side.*

Because somewhere deep inside both their hearts—

they already understood something painful.

Love becomes most beautiful...

right before time tries to take it away.

Chapter 4 — The Days of Happiness

The following days passed slowly.

Softly.

Beautifully.

And inside the house near the hills of Dindigul—

life continued smiling without knowing how fragile it had already become.

Morning sunlight still entered through the same windows.

Coffee still filled the kitchen with warmth.

Lisa’s tiny cries still echoed through the halls.

And every evening—

the balcony still waited for **Akira** and **Yuki**.

From the outside—

nothing had changed.

But inside Akira’s heart—

everything had.

Now, every ordinary moment felt sacred.

Every laugh became a memory while it was still happening.

Every smile felt temporary.

And somehow—

that made love even deeper.

Lisa had slowly begun recognizing faces now.

Especially Akira’s.

Whenever he carried her, the little girl became unusually calm.

Paari hated this fact completely.

One morning, Paari sat on the sofa trying desperately to make Lisa laugh.

“Look at Appa,” he whispered dramatically while making strange faces.

Lisa stared at him for three full seconds.

Then immediately began crying.

Venitha burst into laughter from the kitchen.

“She rejected you.”

“This child is attacking me emotionally.”

Akira entered the living room carrying coffee.

“What happened?”

“She doesn’t love me.”

Akira calmly sat beside him before carefully taking Lisa into his arms.

Instantly—

the crying stopped.

Lisa blinked slowly before smiling weakly at him.

Paari looked genuinely betrayed.
“This is corruption.”

Akira looked proud.
“She has excellent judgment.”

Even **Yuki** laughed harder than usual at that.

And for a few moments—

the entire house forgot about pain again.

At night, things became even more chaotic.

Lisa rarely slept properly.

And because of that—
nobody else slept properly either.

One night around **2:30 AM**, Lisa suddenly began crying loudly.

Paari woke up in panic immediately.
“What happened?!”

Venitha, half asleep, looked ready to throw something at him.
“She’s crying.”

“I KNOW SHE’S CRYING!”

“Then why are you shouting louder than her?”

Meanwhile, Akira quietly walked into the room carrying warm milk calmly like he had handled this exact situation a thousand times before.

Yuki followed behind him smiling sleepily.
“Move,” Akira said gently.

Paari immediately stepped aside obediently.
“This house trusts Appa more than me,” he muttered sadly.

Akira slowly carried Lisa near the balcony and softly rocked her beneath the cold night wind.

The crying gradually faded.

Then finally—
silence returned.
Yuki leaned softly against the doorframe while watching him.

And suddenly—
her chest hurt emotionally.
Because the man standing there beneath the moonlight...

still looked exactly like the person she fell in love with decades ago.

Gentle.
Calm.
Protective.
Safe.

Akira eventually turned toward her.
“What?”

Yuki smiled faintly.
“Nothing.”

But her eyes quietly said everything.

Days became filled with tiny moments.

Small moments.

But unforgettable ones.

Yuki feeding **Lisa** while softly singing old songs.

Venitha learning how to hold the baby properly.

Paari falling asleep while carrying Lisa against his chest.

Akira secretly taking photos of everyone during ordinary moments.

Family dinners becoming louder because of baby discussions.

And somewhere inside all of it—

Yuki kept smiling.

Even while hiding pain.

Some evenings, **Akira** intentionally took everyone outside just to create memories.

One evening, they all sat near the garden while cool wind moved through the trees.

Lisa rested asleep inside Venitha’s arms while Paari grilled food terribly nearby.

“This smells dangerous,” Venitha warned.

“This is called cooking skill.”

“This is called attempted murder.”

Akira laughed quietly while Yuki leaned against his shoulder comfortably.

The sunset painted the hills orange and gold once again.

And for a moment—

life looked unbelievably beautiful.

Yuki slowly looked around at everyone.

Her son laughing.

Her granddaughter sleeping peacefully.

Her husband beside her.

The home they built together.

And suddenly—

tears quietly reached her eyes.

Not from sadness.

From gratitude.

Akira noticed immediately.

Without speaking, he gently held her hand tighter beneath the evening light.

Yuki looked toward him silently.

And somehow—

they understood each other without words again.

Later that night, after everyone slept, Akira and Yuki sat together on the balcony once more.

Two cups of coffee rested near them while cold wind passed softly through the darkness.

The hills looked peaceful beneath moonlight.

For a while—

they simply watched the night quietly.

Then **Yuki** softly whispered,
“You’re trying too hard to make every day special.”

Akira smiled faintly without looking at her.
“Is it obvious?”

“Yes.”

A small silence followed.

Then Akira finally spoke honestly.
“I’m scared normal days will disappear.”

Yuki’s eyes softened immediately.

She slowly leaned against him again.
“Then let them disappear beautifully.”

Akira closed his eyes briefly.

And for the first time—

he realized something painful.

He was no longer afraid of death itself.

He was afraid of continuing life without her inside it.

The wind moved gently around them while the night deepened slowly.

And somewhere inside that peaceful darkness—

two hearts silently tried to hold onto time.

One week later—

Akira woke up at exactly **3:00 AM**.

The entire house remained silent beneath the cold darkness of early morning.

No voices.

No television sounds.

No movement.

Only the soft wind outside brushing against the trees near the hills.

Akira quietly walked toward the kitchen and began preparing coffee.

Not because he was sleepy.

But because today—

he wanted everyone to leave the house before sunrise.

A small trip.
Nothing grand.

Just family.
Just memories.

And after learning how little time truly mattered—

even ordinary trips had become priceless to him.

A few minutes later, **Akira** gently entered the bedroom again.

Yuki still slept peacefully beneath the blanket while moonlight rested softly across her face.

For a moment—

he simply stood there watching her.

Memorizing.

Then carefully, he sat beside her and brushed a few strands of hair away from her forehead.

“Yuki...”

His voice remained soft.

Yuki slowly opened her eyes sleepily.

“Hm...?”

“We’re going out.”

Her eyebrows frowned slightly.

“At this time?”

“Yes.”

“Are you kidnapping me?”

“Depends.”

Yuki laughed weakly beneath her blanket.

“You’re impossible.”

Akira smiled quietly.

“Get ready.”

By **3:40 AM**—

everyone was somehow inside the car.

Or *half asleep inside the car.*

Paari leaned against the window looking completely dead.

“I hate mornings.”

Venitha rested beside him carrying sleeping Lisa carefully.

“You said that yesterday too.”

“Because mornings continue existing.”

Akira sat proudly in the driver’s seat while Yuki laughed softly beside him.

The **BMW** slowly left the gate and disappeared into the quiet roads outside Dindigul.

The world looked completely different before sunrise.

Empty roads stretched endlessly beneath dark blue skies while mist drifted slowly across the hills.

Streetlights flickered quietly beside the highways.

Cold wind entered gently through the slightly opened windows.

And inside the car—

old melodies played softly through the speakers.

For a while—

nobody spoke much.

Not because they were unhappy.

But because moments like this naturally become peaceful.

Yuki quietly rested her head against the seat while watching the sleeping world outside.

Then softly—

she smiled.

“This feels nice.”

Akira glanced toward her briefly.

“Hmm?”

“Leaving the world behind for a while.”

Akira’s expression softened.

“If possible...”

he whispered quietly,

“I would keep you in moments like this forever.”

Yuki looked at him silently for a few seconds.

Then slowly—

she held his hand resting near the gearshift.

And for the rest of the drive—

neither of them let go.

Around **4:30 AM**—

the car finally stopped near a tiny roadside tea shop surrounded by fog.

The shop looked old.

Simple.

Peaceful.

Only one dim yellow bulb glowed above the entrance while steam rose from boiling tea near the stove.

An elderly tea master looked up in surprise as the family stepped out into the cold morning air.

“Tea, sir?” he asked warmly.

Akira smiled.

“Five teas.”

Paari immediately frowned.

“I wanted coffee.”

“You’re getting tea.”

“This family suppresses freedom.”

Venitha laughed quietly while adjusting Lisa’s blanket.

The tea master slowly prepared the drinks with calm movements practiced over decades.

Boiling milk.
Crushing ginger.
Pouring tea between steel tumblers with perfect rhythm.

The smell itself felt comforting.
The sky above the hills slowly began changing color now.
Dark blue becoming softer.

Morning quietly approaching.

Akira stood silently near the roadside watching the fog drift through the empty roads.

Then suddenly—
he felt **Yuki** move beside him.

She gently leaned against his shoulder while holding the warm tea cup carefully between both hands.
“It’s cold,” she whispered.

Without speaking, Akira quietly removed his jacket and wrapped it around her shoulders.

Yuki smiled faintly.
“You’ll get cold too.”

“That’s fine.”

The wind moved softly around them while the tea shop radio played an old Tamil melody quietly in the background.

And for one peaceful moment—
life felt unbelievably slow.

Beautifully slow.

Paari suddenly looked around the empty road dramatically.
“This feels like a movie scene.”

Venitha nodded immediately.
“Yes.”

Paari looked proud.
“I should become a hero.”

“You already struggle carrying diapers.”

“That’s temporary weakness.”

Even the tea master laughed softly hearing them.

Lisa slowly woke up inside Venitha’s arms and blinked sleepily at the cold world around her.

Akira immediately stepped closer.

“My little princess woke up?”

Lisa stared at him quietly for two seconds before smiling weakly.

Paari looked offended again.
“She likes Appa more than all of us.”

Akira sipped tea proudly.
“Correct child.”

After finishing tea, the family remained there longer than expected.

Nobody wanted to rush.

The fog.
The cold wind.
The peaceful silence.

Everything felt calming.

Yuki quietly watched everyone laughing near the roadside.

And suddenly—
her chest became painfully emotional again.

Because she knew something they didn’t.
These moments were becoming memories already.

Akira noticed her expression immediately.

He slowly stepped closer.
“You okay?”

Yuki looked toward him.

Then softly smiled.
“Yes.”

A pause.

Then quietly—
“I’m happy.”

And somehow—

those words alone made his chest hurt.

Because ***happiness had suddenly become fragile.***

As sunrise slowly painted the hills gold and orange—

the **BMW** finally returned to the road once again.

Music filled the car softly.

Lisa slept peacefully.

Paari argued with **Venitha** about directions even though neither of them knew the route.

And Yuki—

Yuki quietly leaned against the window while smiling at the rising sun.

Meanwhile—

Akira drove slowly beneath the morning sky.

Not trying to reach a destination quickly.

Because now—

he understood something deeply.

Some journeys become beautiful only when we stop rushing through them.

The trip that began before sunrise slowly turned into something longer.

Something freer.

By afternoon, they were no longer following plans.

They were simply following happiness.

And for the first time in many weeks—

Akira allowed himself to stop thinking about hospitals, medicines, and time.

At least for a little while.

The family finally reached a quiet hillside resort far away from the city noise.

Mist rolled gently through the mountains while tall trees surrounded the wooden cottages nearby.

The air itself felt cleaner there.

Cooler.

Peaceful.

Lisa remained asleep during most of the drive, completely unaware that four adults had already adjusted their entire world around her existence.

The moment **Venitha** stepped out carrying the baby—

she froze.

“This place is beautiful...”

Paari immediately stretched dramatically beside the car.

“I can finally breathe.”

“You were breathing the entire drive,” Venitha replied.

“Not emotionally.”

Akira laughed quietly while Yuki simply stood there silently watching the mountains.

The wind moved softly through her hair.

And for a brief moment—

she looked completely peaceful.

Healthy.

Alive.

Akira stared at her longer than usual again.

Because *every beautiful moment now carried fear hidden beneath it.*

Fear of losing it.

The cottage they stayed in overlooked the hills directly.

Large glass windows faced the mountains while soft clouds moved slowly below them.

The balcony outside looked perfect during evening.

And somehow—

Akira immediately knew this would become one of the memories he would never forget.

That evening, everyone decided to walk near the nearby market area.

Small roadside shops lined the streets while warm yellow lights glowed beneath the foggy evening sky.

The smell of roasted corn, tea, rainwater, and street food filled the cold air beautifully.

Lisa remained wrapped safely inside a blanket against Venitha’s chest while Paari continuously bought unnecessary snacks.

“You already bought food five minutes ago,” **Venitha** complained.

“That was emotional eating.”

“You’re emotionally eating every ten minutes.”

Akira quietly bought roasted peanuts from an old roadside vendor while listening to **Yuki** laugh softly beside him.

That laugh.

He kept listening to it carefully these days.

As if ***his heart feared forgetting the sound someday.***

At one point, Yuki suddenly stopped near a tiny handmade bracelet stall.

Colorful bracelets hung beneath soft lantern lights while cold wind moved gently through them.

Akira noticed her looking.

Without asking anything—
he quietly bought one.

A simple silver bracelet with tiny blue stones.

Yuki blinked in surprise when he placed it into her hand.

“You still do things like this?”

Akira smiled faintly.

“You still smile like this.”

Yuki lowered her eyes shyly while wearing the bracelet slowly.

And somehow—

***even after decades—
love still looked young between them.***

Later that night, rain began falling softly across the hills.

The family gathered together inside the cottage living room while old songs played quietly from the television.

Paari and Venitha argued over movie choices again.

Lisa slept peacefully nearby.

And Yuki—

Yuki rested comfortably beside Akira beneath a warm blanket while rain touched the windows gently outside.

The atmosphere felt unbelievably calm.

Then suddenly—
the electricity went out.

Darkness covered the cottage instantly.

Venitha gasped dramatically.

“Ghost scene.”

Paari immediately pointed toward the darkness.

“If I disappear first, investigate Appa.”

Akira looked offended.

“Why me?”

“You look emotionally suspicious.”

Yuki laughed harder than she had in days.

Real laughter.

Free laughter.

And hearing it—

Akira silently thanked life for giving him this moment at least once more.

A few minutes later, candles were lit around the room.

Warm golden light filled the cottage softly while rain continued outside.

Everything suddenly felt slower.

Closer.

More intimate.

Paari eventually sat near the floor beside **Lisa’s** small crib while **Venitha** leaned comfortably against his shoulder.

Yuki rested quietly against Akira while watching the candlelight move across the room.

Then softly—

she whispered near him.

“I don’t want this trip to end.”

Akira slowly looked toward her.

“Then let’s stay inside it a little longer.”

Yuki smiled faintly.

And beneath the candlelight—

their fingers quietly intertwined again.

Much later into the night, after everyone slept—

Akira stepped outside alone onto the balcony.

Rain had stopped.

Cold fog moved silently across the mountains while moonlight barely touched the hills beneath the clouds.

The world looked quiet.

Too quiet.

Akira slowly leaned against the railing.

Then closed his eyes briefly.

He wanted to stay strong.

For Yuki.

For the family.

But sometimes—

when nobody was watching—

fear still found him.

“What will I do without you...”

The question escaped softly into the cold wind.

And for the first time in weeks—

his breathing became unsteady again.

Then suddenly—

warm arms gently wrapped around him from behind.

Yuki.

“I knew you’d come out here,” she whispered softly.

Akira covered her hands carefully with his own.

“You should be sleeping.”

“I should be with you.”

Silence settled between them peacefully.

Then Yuki slowly rested her head against his back.

“Don’t stand alone inside sadness,” she whispered.

Akira lowered his eyes.

“I’m trying.”

“I know.”

A pause.

Then softly—

“But don’t lose yourself before I’m even gone.”

That sentence ***shattered him quietly.***

Because ***she understood him too well.***

Akira slowly turned toward her before holding her tightly beneath the cold mountain wind.

And there—

between fog, silence, and fading time—

they stood together without speaking.

Just feeling each other’s warmth.

As if ***both hearts were silently trying to stop the world from moving forward.***

The vacation lasted four days.

Four peaceful days.

Four unforgettable days.

And somehow—

those four days quietly became some of the most beautiful memories the family would ever carry.

They visited small hill stations covered in fog.

Walked through crowded evening streets holding hot tea beneath cold weather.

Stopped near roadside shops just because ***the smell of food felt comforting.***

Took photographs nobody realized would later become precious.

And for a short while—
life felt normal again.

Not fragile.
Not temporary.
Just alive.

On the third evening of the trip, the family visited a quiet lake hidden between the mountains.

The water reflected the orange sunset beautifully while small boats drifted slowly across the calm surface.

Lisa rested peacefully inside **Akira’s** arms while the others walked nearby taking pictures.

Venitha smiled while adjusting the baby blanket.
“You know something?”

Paari looked toward her.
“What?”

“She’ll probably grow up thinking your father raised her.”

Paari sighed dramatically.
“She already ignores me emotionally.”

Akira looked proud again.
“Correct child.”

Yuki laughed softly beside them.

The sound reached Akira immediately.

Every single time.

Always.

He turned toward her quietly.

And suddenly—
his smile faded slightly.

Just for a second.

Because even while smiling—
Yuki looked weaker now.

Her movements had slowed.

The tiredness in her eyes stayed longer.

Sometimes she quietly pressed her fingers against her head when nobody watched.

But the moment someone noticed—
she smiled again.

Pretended again.

Protected everyone again.

And ***that hurt Akira more than anything else.***

That night, after dinner, everyone gathered outside the cottage beneath the stars.

A small bonfire burned softly nearby while cold wind moved through the trees surrounding them.

The sky looked unbelievably clear.

Lisa slept peacefully near Venitha while Paari roasted marshmallows terribly.

“These are burnt.”

“This is artistic cooking.”

“This is carbon.”

Akira laughed quietly while Yuki rested against his shoulder beneath a thick blanket.

For a while—

everyone simply sat together peacefully.

Watching fire.

Watching stars.

Watching each other.

And somewhere deep inside Akira—

fear and gratitude continued fighting silently.

Suddenly, Paari looked toward his parents.

“Appa.”

Akira turned slightly.

“Hm?”

“What’s the secret?”

Akira frowned.

“To what?”

“To loving each other like this after thirty-four years.”

The fire crackled softly between them.

Yuki smiled faintly.

“You think too much.”

“No seriously,” Paari continued.

“You both still act like newly married people.”

Venitha nodded immediately.

“It’s honestly unfair.”

Akira looked toward Yuki for a few seconds before answering quietly.

“There’s no secret.”

Paari waited.

Akira slowly smiled.

“You just choose the same person every day.”

Silence fell around the fire.

Not because the answer was dramatic.

But because it was true.

Yuki slowly looked down while smiling softly to herself.

And somewhere inside her chest—

pain and love mixed together painfully.

Because she knew she would soon leave behind the man who still chose her every single day.

Later that night, after everyone went inside—

Akira and **Yuki** remained outside near the dying fire.

Cold wind moved gently around them while the mountains rested beneath moonlight.

Yuki quietly watched the flames becoming smaller.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“I’m scared too.”

Akira immediately looked toward her.

It was the first time she admitted it openly.

Yuki’s eyes stayed fixed on the fire.

“I keep pretending I’m strong because you’re already hurting.”

Her voice trembled slightly.

“But sometimes...”

She swallowed softly.

“I don’t want to leave yet.”

That sentence ***completely shattered the remaining strength inside him.***

Akira immediately pulled her close.

“No,” he whispered painfully.

“Don’t say things like that.”

Yuki buried her face against his chest while tears quietly escaped.

“I wanted more time...”

Akira closed his eyes tightly.

“So did I.”

The fire slowly faded lower beside them while silence wrapped around the cold night.

And for the first time since the diagnosis—

both of them cried together.

Not trying to stay strong.

Not pretending.

Just two people terrified of losing each other.

After a long time, Yuki slowly calmed down.

Then suddenly—

she lifted her head slightly and smiled weakly.

“Can I ask something selfish?”

“Anything.”

“If there’s another life after this...”

Her eyes slowly met his.

“Find me again.”

Akira stared at her silently.

Then gently held her face between both hands.

“In every life.”

His voice cracked.

“I’ll find you in every life.”

And beneath the fading firelight—

Yuki smiled through tears.

Because somehow—

that answer made her heart peaceful again.

The next morning, the family finally prepared to return home.

The car became noisy again.

Paari argued about luggage.

Venitha worried about **Lisa**.

Yuki quietly watched the mountains disappear slowly through the car window.

And Akira—

Akira drove carefully beneath the bright morning sky while secretly wishing the road would never end.

Because deep inside his heart—

he already knew something painful.

These days...

these beautiful ordinary days...

were becoming goodbye without anyone else realizing it yet.

Chapter 5 — The Secret Pain

The house near the hills welcomed them quietly when they returned from the vacation.

The evening wind still moved through the trees.

The balcony still waited peacefully.

The same warm lights still glowed near the entrance.

Everything looked exactly the same.

But for **Akira** and **Yuki**—

nothing felt the same anymore.

Because now, every corner of the house carried a ***silent countdown*** inside it.

The moment the car stopped, **Paari** stretched dramatically after getting out.

“I think my spine retired.”

Venitha rolled her eyes while carrying Lisa carefully.

“You slept for half the drive.”

“That was strategic recovery.”

Akira smiled faintly while unloading the bags from the trunk.

Meanwhile, Yuki simply stood near the entrance quietly watching the house.

Home.

Their home.

The place where almost every important memory of her life existed.

She looked at the balcony.

At the windows.

At the garden.

And suddenly—

her chest tightened emotionally.

Because somewhere inside her heart—

she knew.

She was looking at these things differently now.

As if ***memorizing them.***

Inside the house, the familiar warmth returned immediately.

Lisa’s small noises echoed through the rooms again.

Paari argued with Venitha about unpacking.

The television played softly in the background.

And for a brief moment—

everything felt normal.

Exactly the way Yuki wanted.

That night during dinner, **Paari** continuously spoke about the vacation.

“Appa almost got lost near the market.”

Akira looked offended immediately.

“I knew the route.”

“You walked into a dead end.”

“It was a shortcut.”

“To where? Another country?”

Venitha burst into laughter while Yuki quietly smiled beside Akira.

And honestly—

watching them laugh like this made the pain inside her easier to carry.

Just a little.

Later that night, after everyone slept—

Yuki stood alone near **Lisa’s** crib quietly watching the baby sleep.

The small night lamp painted soft light across Lisa’s tiny face.

Peaceful.

Innocent.

Completely unaware of how fragile life could become.

Yuki slowly touched Lisa’s tiny fingers.

And suddenly—

tears reached her eyes again.

Not because she feared death itself.

But because ***she feared leaving love behind.***

Akira silently entered the room a few moments later.

The moment he saw her crying quietly near the crib—

his heart broke again.

He walked toward her slowly before gently resting one hand on her shoulder.

Yuki immediately wiped her tears.

“I didn’t want her to grow up without memories of me.”

Akira closed his eyes briefly.

Then softly—

“She will know you through us.”

Yuki looked toward him silently.

“She’ll know your kindness.”

“Your laugh.”

“Your love.”

“She’ll know you in every story we tell.”

Yuki’s tears slowly fell again hearing that.

And this time—

Akira pulled her into his arms immediately.

Because sometimes—

love means holding someone together while both hearts are breaking.

The following days became strangely beautiful.

Akira started spending more time at home than ever before.

He canceled meetings.

Ignored unnecessary calls.

Stopped caring about work entirely.

Nothing felt more important now than time itself.

Every morning, he made coffee for **Yuki** personally.

Every evening, he sat beside her on the balcony longer than usual.

And every night—

he secretly watched her sleep.

As if *fear itself refused to let him close his eyes.*

One evening, rain began falling heavily outside while the family gathered together in the living room.

Lisa slept peacefully against **Venitha’s** shoulder while **Paari** searched endlessly for a movie nobody agreed on.

“This one?”

“No.”

“This?”

“No.”

“Then YOU choose.”

Venitha pointed toward Yuki dramatically.

“Amma chooses.”

Yuki looked surprised.

“Me?”

“Yes.”

Akira immediately nodded.

“Correct. Final authority.”

Yuki laughed softly before choosing an old romantic movie.

Paari groaned loudly.

“This house only supports romance.”

Akira looked proud.

“As it should.”

Everyone settled comfortably while rain touched the windows outside.

And somewhere during the movie—

Yuki quietly leaned against Akira again.

Just like always.

But this time—

Akira carefully held her hand beneath the blanket much tighter than usual.

Because deep inside—

he was terrified of losing warmth itself.

Halfway through the movie, Yuki suddenly became tired again.

The exhaustion reached her faster now.

Akira noticed immediately.

“You should rest.”

Yuki shook her head softly.

“I want to stay here.”

“But you’re tired.”

“I know.”

Then quietly—

she smiled.

“But I’m happy.”

That answer alone ***made his chest ache.***

Because ***she kept choosing happiness even while pain slowly consumed her body.***

Later that night, after everyone slept, Akira sat alone on the balcony.

Rain continued falling softly across the dark hills while cold wind moved through the night.

The bracelet he bought during the vacation rested around Yuki’s wrist inside the bedroom.

And somehow—

that small image stayed inside his mind.

He lowered his head slowly.

Then whispered into the rain—

“I’m not ready.”

For the first time in his life—

Akira truly felt helpless.

Not because he lacked strength.

But because ***love had finally brought him to something he could not protect.***

And somewhere inside the room behind him—

Yuki quietly watched him through the half-open balcony door.

Her eyes filled softly.

Because even now—

he still carried her pain as if it were his own.

Days continued moving forward.

Quietly.

Cruelly.

Beautifully.

Inside the house near the hills—

life still looked warm from the outside.

Coffee still filled the mornings.

Lisa’s laughter still echoed through the rooms.

Paari still argued dramatically over small things.

Venitha still chased him around the house with endless complaints.

And every evening—

the balcony still belonged to Akira and Yuki.

But now—

every happy moment carried invisible pain beneath it.

Like ***sunlight slowly fading without anyone noticing.***

One morning, **Yuki** woke up earlier than usual.

The house remained silent while dawn slowly touched the sky outside.

For a moment, she simply sat on the bed quietly watching Akira sleep beside her.

His breathing remained calm.

Peaceful.

One hand still rested near her unconsciously even during sleep.

As if ***his heart feared distance even in dreams.***

Yuki smiled faintly.

Then slowly—

her eyes filled again.

Because she realized something painful.

Soon...

this ***bed would become lonely.***

And the thought alone ***hurt more than death itself.***

She carefully stood up and walked toward the balcony.

Cold morning wind touched her face while the hills rested beneath soft blue light.

The world looked calm.

Too calm.

Yuki slowly held the railing and closed her eyes.

Trying to breathe normally.

Trying not to think too much.

But suddenly—

a wave of dizziness struck her hard.

Her body weakened instantly.

Before she could steady herself—

Akira’s arms caught her from behind.

“Yuki!”

Fear exploded across his voice immediately.

Yuki quickly tried smiling again.

“I’m okay...”

“No.”

His breathing had already become uneven.

“You almost fell.”

Akira carefully helped her sit down on the balcony chair while ***panic quietly spread across his face.***

Yuki gently held his hand.
 “Please don’t look so scared.”

“How can I not?”

His voice cracked immediately.
 “How can I pretend this is normal?”

Silence filled the balcony.

Cold wind moved softly around them while morning sunlight slowly reached the hills.

Yuki looked toward the sky quietly.

Then whispered softly—
 “I hate this.”

That sentence broke him instantly.

Because until now—

she had accepted everything with calmness.

But this...

this was the first time she sounded tired emotionally.

Akira immediately knelt beside her chair and held both her hands tightly.
 “We’ll keep fighting.”

Yuki slowly shook her head.
 “I’m not scared of dying.”

Akira’s eyes immediately became wet again.
 “Then what are you scared of?”

Yuki looked directly into his eyes.
 “Leaving you behind.”

And suddenly—
the world became unbearably quiet.

Later that afternoon, **Akira** secretly called the doctor again.

Not because he expected miracles anymore.

But because ***love refuses to stop searching for hope.***

Even tiny hope.

He stood alone near the garden while the call continued quietly.
 “Is there really nothing else?”

The doctor’s voice remained gentle.
 “I’m sorry.”

“What if we try another hospital?”

“The condition has already progressed too far.”

Akira closed his eyes tightly.

His breathing became heavier.
 “There has to be something...”

But deep inside—

even he already knew the answer.

Still—

he couldn't stop asking.

Because *loving someone deeply makes acceptance feel impossible.*

That evening, rain returned once again.

The house became colder beneath the cloudy sky while everyone gathered in the living room near **Lisa**.

Paari carried the baby proudly while making strange sounds trying to entertain her.

Lisa stared at him seriously for several seconds.

Then suddenly *sneezed directly on his face.*

The entire room burst into laughter.

“See?” **Venitha** shouted proudly.

“She also thinks you’re irritating.”

Paari looked betrayed beyond repair.

“This child attacks only me.”

Even Yuki laughed properly hearing that.

And for a brief moment—

Akira forgot fear again.

That was the dangerous thing about happiness.

It makes people believe painful things can wait longer than they actually do.

Later that night, Yuki became exhausted much faster than usual.

While climbing the stairs, she suddenly stopped halfway.

Akira immediately noticed.

“Tired?”

Yuki nodded weakly.

Without saying another word—

Akira gently lifted her into his arms.

Yuki looked surprised.

“Akira...”

“You walked enough.”

“I can still walk.”

“I know.”

Then softly—

“But let me carry you anyway.”

The hallway became silent.

Yuki quietly rested her head against his chest while he carried her slowly toward their room.

And somehow—

that moment felt painfully beautiful.

Because both of them understood something without speaking.

Soon...

he would only have memories left to hold.

Inside the bedroom, **Akira** carefully placed **Yuki** onto the bed before adjusting the blanket around her gently.

Yuki watched him silently.

Then suddenly—

she smiled faintly.
“What?”

“You still treat me like I’m young.”

Akira looked at her for a long moment.

Then quietly answered—
“You still are.”

Tears immediately reached Yuki’s eyes again.

Because *love like this...*
love that survives time, pain, fear, and helplessness...

was rare.
Painfully rare.

That night—

Akira didn’t sleep at all.

He sat beside Yuki while she rested peacefully against the pillow.

Outside, rain touched the windows softly.
Inside, silence filled the room.
And under the dim yellow light—

Akira simply watched the woman he loved more than life itself.

Trying to memorize everything.

The way she breathed.
The way she slept.
The way her fingers curled slightly beneath the blanket.

Because somewhere inside his heart—

he already understood something terrifying.

Time was no longer moving normally anymore.

Now—

every second mattered.

The rain continued for three straight days.

Soft.

Cold.

Endless.

Clouds covered the hills surrounding the house while the wind carried the smell of wet soil through the balcony every evening.

Inside the home—

warmth still existed.

But now...

it felt fragile.

Like everyone was unknowingly standing near the edge of something painful.

Yuki's condition slowly worsened.

Not dramatically.

Quietly.

That was the cruel part.

There were no loud signs.

No sudden collapse.

Only small changes.

She became tired after simple conversations.

Sometimes she forgot what she was saying halfway through sentences.

Sometimes headaches forced her to close her eyes for long periods.

And every single time—

Akira noticed first.

Always first.

One evening, Yuki sat near the balcony while **Lisa** slept peacefully against her chest.

The sunset painted the sky orange and grey beneath the rainy clouds.

For a few moments—

everything looked calm again.

Then suddenly—

Yuki winced softly in pain.

Akira immediately turned toward her.

“What happened?”

“Headache.”

“How bad?”

Yuki forced a smile instantly.

“Small one.”

But **Akira** already knew the truth.

The headaches were becoming stronger.

He quietly walked toward her and gently carried **Lisa** away first before helping Yuki stand slowly.

“You need rest.”

Yuki looked frustrated this time.

“I’m always resting.”

Akira stayed silent.

Because he understood something she was too tired to say aloud.

She wasn’t angry at resting.

She was angry at losing pieces of herself slowly.

That night during dinner, Yuki barely ate anything.

Venitha noticed first.

“Amma, you’re not eating properly.”

“I’m full.”

“You only ate three spoons.”

Paari immediately looked concerned too.

“Should we go to the doctor again?”

Before Yuki could answer—

Akira calmly stepped in.

“The medicines are making her tired. Doctor already said it’ll happen.”

The lie came naturally now.

And somehow—

that hurt him too.

Because ***every lie protected happiness...***

while ***slowly destroying him inside.***

Later that night, Lisa refused to sleep completely.

She cried endlessly while Paari walked around the room half awake carrying her like a confused ghost.

“Please,” he whispered dramatically,

“your father is dying.”

Venitha glared at him instantly.

“She’s the baby. YOU are not the victim.”

“I haven’t slept in days.”

Akira quietly entered the room smiling faintly before taking Lisa carefully into his arms.

The crying slowly softened almost immediately.

Paari looked emotionally attacked again.

“This child truly replaced me.”

Akira gently rocked **Lisa** near the balcony while moonlight touched the room softly.

Then quietly—
he looked toward the hallway.

Yuki stood there watching him silently.

And suddenly—
his chest tightened painfully.

Because *she looked weaker tonight.*

Much weaker.

After finally putting Lisa to sleep, Akira followed Yuki back toward their room.
The house had already fallen silent again.

Rain touched the windows softly outside while dim yellow light filled the bedroom.

Yuki sat near the edge of the bed quietly.
For a long moment—
neither of them spoke.

Then suddenly—
Yuki whispered,
“I think they’re starting to notice.”

Akira lowered his eyes slowly.
“Maybe.”

“Are you angry at me?”

He looked up immediately.
“For what?”

“For making you carry this alone.”

That sentence *shattered him quietly.*

Akira slowly walked toward her before kneeling in front of her.
“You never became a burden to me.”

Tears slowly filled Yuki’s eyes.
“But I’m leaving you alone.”

Akira immediately shook his head.
“No.”

His voice cracked painfully.
“You are not leaving me.”

Silence.

Then softly—
“I’m the one losing you.”

The room became *unbearably quiet* after that.

Rain continued touching the windows gently while both of them sat there *breaking silently together.*

After a while, **Yuki** slowly rested her forehead against his.

“Do you remember our first apartment?”

Akira blinked once.

Then smiled faintly through tears.

“The terrible yellow walls?”

“You said it looked luxurious.”

“I was trying to impress you.”

“It looked like a hospital.”

Akira laughed weakly for the first time that night.

“And you still married me.”

Yuki smiled softly.

“You made poor financial decisions too.”

For a few minutes—

they simply talked about old memories again.

College days.

First salaries.

Burnt cooking disasters.

Rainy bus rides.

The first sofa they bought together.

Tiny ordinary memories.

But somehow—

those became the most valuable things in life.

Then suddenly—

Yuki’s expression changed.

Pain crossed her face sharply.

Akira stood up immediately.

“Yuki?”

She pressed her fingers against her forehead tightly.

The headache hit harder this time.

Much harder.

Akira’s breathing instantly became uneven.

“I’m calling the doctor.”

“No—”

“I’m calling.”

Yuki slowly grabbed his wrist before he could move.

Then softly—

“Stay.”

Akira froze.

Yuki looked directly into his eyes.

“Please.”

The fear inside him became unbearable now.

Because for the first time—
he saw exhaustion inside her.

Real exhaustion.
Not physical.
Emotional.

Like her body was slowly becoming too tired to fight anymore.

Akira carefully sat beside her again while holding her hand tightly.

And for the rest of the night—

neither of them slept.

Yuki rested quietly against his shoulder while Akira stared into the darkness beyond the balcony.

Listening.

Waiting.

Praying silently for time to slow down.

But outside—

the rain continued falling without stopping.

Like *the sky itself already knew grief was coming.*

Chapter 6 — One Last Month

After that night—

something quietly changed inside Akira.

Not outside.

Outside, life still looked normal.

The house still carried laughter.

Lisa still cried during midnight.

Paari still rushed to office every morning half awake.

Venitha still filled the house with small conversations and endless care.

And every evening—

sunlight still touched the balcony the same way.

But inside Akira—

fear had become constant.

Silent.

Heavy.

Always present.

Like ***a shadow that refused to leave him alone.***

The next morning, Akira woke up before sunrise again.

He carefully looked toward Yuki beside him.

She was still sleeping peacefully.

At least...

it looked peaceful from the outside.

But even during sleep now, exhaustion remained visible across her face.

Akira slowly brushed a strand of hair away from her forehead.

Then quietly—

he kissed her there.

Not because it was a habit.

Because suddenly—

every kiss felt important.

Inside the kitchen, the smell of coffee slowly filled the house once again.

Akira moved calmly through the silence while preparing breakfast.

But today—

his movements felt slower.

More thoughtful.

Almost careful.

As if ***he was trying not to disturb time itself.***

A few minutes later, **Yuki** entered the kitchen quietly.

She looked tired.

But when she saw him—

she still smiled.

Always.

Akira immediately walked toward her.

“How’s your head?”

“Better.”

That was another lie.

And both of them knew it.

Still—

neither of them challenged it anymore.

Because sometimes people lie only to ***protect love from becoming heavier.***

While drinking coffee together near the balcony, Yuki suddenly asked softly—

“If you could stop time... would you?”

Akira looked toward her immediately.

“Yes.”

Without hesitation.

Without thinking.

Yuki smiled faintly.

“But then Lisa wouldn’t grow.”

Akira lowered his eyes slowly.

“And Paari wouldn’t become older.”

“And Venitha wouldn’t become stronger.”

The wind moved gently around them.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,

“Life only moves because time moves too.”

Akira looked at her silently.

“But I hate it.”

Yuki’s eyes softened immediately.

“I know.”

That afternoon, **Paari** left for office after nearly three months away from work.

Before leaving, he carefully carried **Lisa** near Yuki.

“Say bye to Paati.”

Lisa blinked sleepily.

Yuki smiled warmly and kissed the baby’s forehead gently.

“Come back early,” she told Paari softly.

Paari immediately frowned.

“You’re saying it like I’m leaving for another country.”

“You drive terribly. Anything is possible.”

Paari gasped dramatically.

“This house insults me daily.”

Even Yuki laughed softly hearing that.

And honestly—

that laugh alone made everyone feel lighter.

For a few seconds.

After Paari left, the house became quieter than usual.

Venitha went upstairs to put Lisa to sleep while Akira and Yuki remained near the balcony together.

Clouds slowly gathered above the hills again.

Rainy season had fully arrived now.

Yuki quietly rested her head against Akira’s shoulder.

Then suddenly—

she whispered softly,

“Can we go somewhere tonight?”

Akira looked down at her immediately.

“Where?”

“Anywhere.”

A pause.

“Just us.”

And hearing those words—

his chest tightened painfully.

Because deep inside—

he already knew why she asked.

She was trying to create memories before time disappeared.

That night, around 11:30 PM—

the BMW quietly left the house once again.

The roads outside Dindigul looked empty beneath the cold misty air while old songs played softly through the speakers.

Yuki sat beside him wrapped in his jacket while watching streetlights pass silently outside.

The atmosphere felt calm.

Almost dreamlike.

For a while—

they simply drove without destination.

No rush.

No purpose.

Only togetherness.

Around midnight, Akira stopped near another roadside tea shop far away from the city.

Unlike the earlier trip—

this place looked almost completely empty.

Only one old tea master stood near the stove while fog moved heavily through the dark roads.

Akira and **Yuki** stepped out slowly into the cold air.

The silence there felt peaceful.

Sacred almost.

They sat near a small wooden bench while hot tea cups warmed their hands gently.

The tea master quietly prepared tea beneath the dim yellow light while an old radio played a faint melody nearby.

Yuki smiled softly.

“I love places like this.”

Akira looked at her.

“Why?”

“Because nobody rushes here.”

The wind moved slowly through the fog.

Yuki looked toward the empty road.

“Sometimes I think people forget how to live peacefully.”

Akira quietly watched her while she spoke.

Every word.

Every expression.

Every small movement.

He was memorizing her without even realizing it anymore.

After a while, Yuki leaned gently against him.

“Promise me something.”

Akira immediately answered softly—

“Anything.”

“If one day...”

Her voice became quieter.

“When I’m gone...”

Akira’s expression broke instantly.

But Yuki continued gently.

“Don’t stop living.”

Silence crushed the space between them.

Akira lowered his head slowly.

“I don’t know how.”

Yuki looked at him carefully.

“You will.”

“No.”

His voice cracked painfully.

“You’re the reason this house feels alive.”

Tears slowly filled Yuki’s eyes again.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“No.”

A pause.

“You are.”

And somehow—

that answer hurt more than anything else.

Because *she truly believed it.*

Even now—

she still placed everyone before herself.

The fog became heavier around the roads while midnight slowly deepened.

Yuki quietly closed her eyes and rested fully against **Akira’s** shoulder.

For several minutes—

neither of them spoke.

Only silence.

Only cold wind.

Only two hearts trying desperately to hold onto each other while time quietly moved forward anyway.

And somewhere inside Akira—

a terrifying realization slowly formed.

No matter how deeply someone loves...

love alone cannot stop time from leaving.

After the midnight drive—

Akira began saying yes to everything.

Not because life had suddenly become easier.

But because *he no longer wanted to waste even a single moment.*

If Yuki wanted tea at midnight—

they went.

If she wanted to watch rain from the balcony—

he stayed beside her for hours.

If she wanted silence—

he gave silence.

And if she smiled—

he secretly thanked life for one more day.

The following week became filled with small journeys.

Not grand vacations.

Not expensive places.

Just moments.

Beautiful ordinary moments.

And somehow—

those became the most important ones.

One evening, **Akira** suddenly took everyone to a movie theatre.

Paari looked shocked while holding **Lisa** carefully.

“Appa... are we seriously bringing a baby to a movie?”

Akira looked completely calm.

“She deserves cinema culture.”

“She’s one month old.”

“Good age to start.”

Venitha laughed loudly while **Yuki** quietly smiled beside him.

The theatre itself looked nearly empty because of the late-night show.

Cold air filled the room while soft lights glowed near the seats.

Lisa somehow slept through almost the entire movie.

Meanwhile, Paari became emotional during one sad scene and secretly wiped his eyes.

Venitha immediately noticed.

“You’re crying?”

“No.”

“You literally are.”

“It’s dust.”

“In an air-conditioned theatre?”

“Emotionally dangerous dust.”

Even Yuki laughed harder than the movie itself.

And hearing *that laugh* echo through the theatre—

Akira smiled silently in the darkness.

Because *happiness still existed.*

Even now.

Another day, they drove toward the beach during evening.

The sea stretched endlessly beneath cloudy skies while strong wind moved through the air carrying the smell of saltwater.

Lisa remained wrapped safely inside a blanket while everyone walked slowly near the shore.

Yuki removed her slippers and allowed the cold water to touch her feet gently.

For a few moments—

she looked unbelievably peaceful there.

Like someone standing inside a memory before it even ended.

Akira walked beside her quietly.

Then suddenly—

Yuki held his hand tighter.
“Do you remember our first beach trip?”

Akira smiled faintly.
“You got angry because I buried your slippers in sand.”

“You lost them.”

“I was creating adventure.”

“You created suffering.”

Akira laughed softly while waves crashed gently nearby.

And for one beautiful moment—

they sounded young again.

Not old.
Not tired.
Not afraid.

Just two people still in love beside the sea.

At night, the family often sat together near the balcony after dinner.

The wind became colder during rainy season while warm coffee cups rested near their hands.

Sometimes they spoke for hours.
Sometimes nobody spoke at all.

And somehow—
both kinds of silence felt beautiful.

One night, **Paari** suddenly asked,

“Appa... were you scared when I was born?”

Akira looked thoughtful.

“Terrified.”

“Really?”

“I held you like a bomb.”

Venitha burst into laughter instantly.
“That explains your parenting.”

Paari looked offended.
“I’m a good father.”

Lisa immediately started crying.

The timing destroyed everyone.

Even Yuki laughed until tears reached her eyes.

And honestly—

those nights felt priceless.

But beneath every smile—

Akira quietly watched Yuki becoming weaker.

The changes were small.

But constant.

She became breathless faster.

Headaches lasted longer.

Sometimes she stared into space for a few seconds before returning to conversations.

And every single time—

Akira noticed.

Even when nobody else did.

Especially at night.

That was when fear became hardest to hide.

Some nights, after everyone slept—

Akira secretly sat beside Yuki just watching her breathe.

The room remained silent except for rain touching the windows softly outside.

One particular night, Yuki woke up suddenly and found him staring again.

“You’re doing it again.”

Akira looked guilty immediately.

“What?”

“Watching me like I’ll disappear.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

Akira whispered,

“I’m scared to blink.”

That answer alone broke her heart.

Yuki slowly reached toward him and touched his cheek gently.

“Come here.”

Akira quietly lay beside her while she rested against his chest this time.

The roles had slowly reversed now.

And both of them knew it.

Yuki listened to his heartbeat carefully for several seconds.

Then softly whispered—

“I wish I could stay longer.”

Akira immediately closed his eyes tightly.

Because ***hearing her say it aloud still destroyed him every time.***

A few days later, **Akira** secretly began taking more photographs.

Not professional photos.

Ordinary ones.

Yuki laughing near the kitchen.

Yuki holding **Lisa**.

Yuki sleeping near the balcony.

Yuki drinking coffee while morning sunlight touched her face.

Tiny moments.

Simple moments.

But to him—

they felt more valuable than anything in the world.

One afternoon, Yuki suddenly noticed him taking another picture secretly.

She narrowed her eyes.

“How many photos do you need?”

Akira lowered the phone slowly.

“Not enough.”

Yuki froze slightly hearing that.

Then quietly—

she smiled again.

But this time—

her eyes became wet too.

Because now—

both of them understood something painful.

These were no longer random memories.

Akira was trying to preserve pieces of her before time took them away.

That night, rain fell heavily again.

The house became cold while everyone slowly went to sleep one by one.

Later, near midnight—

Akira stood alone on the balcony once more.

The hills beyond the darkness had completely disappeared beneath fog and rain.

Everything looked distant tonight.

Unreachable.

Then suddenly—

warm hands gently wrapped around him from behind again.

Yuki.

Without speaking, she rested her head softly against his back.

Akira covered her hands carefully with his own.

And beneath the storm-filled sky—

both of them stood silently together.

Trying not to think about endings.

Trying not to think about time.

Trying only to feel warmth while it still existed.

Time no longer felt normal inside the house.

Days moved too quickly.
Nights disappeared too soon.

And every sunrise felt both beautiful...
and cruel.

Because each morning reminded **Akira** of one painful truth.

There were fewer tomorrows left now.

One evening, after dinner, Yuki quietly walked toward the balcony carrying two coffee cups carefully in her hands.

The rain had finally stopped after days of storms.
Cold wind moved peacefully through the hills while the night sky slowly revealed scattered stars again.

Akira looked up the moment she approached.
“You should’ve called me. I would’ve brought them.”

Yuki smiled softly while sitting beside him.
“You already do everything.”

Akira accepted the coffee silently.

For a while—
they simply watched the sky together.

Then suddenly—

Yuki whispered,
“Let’s go for one more drive.”

Akira turned toward her immediately.
“Now?”

“Mhm.”

“At this time?”

Yuki smiled faintly.
“You always ask that... but you always say yes.”

And honestly—

he would have followed her anywhere now.

A little later, the BMW quietly left the house once again beneath the midnight sky.

The roads outside Dindigul looked empty and silver beneath moonlight while soft old melodies played quietly through the speakers.

This time—
they drove without speaking much.

Not because they lacked words.

But because ***silence itself had become meaningful between them.***

The cold wind entered softly through the slightly opened window while Yuki rested peacefully against the seat beside him.

For long stretches of road—

only music existed.

Only headlights.
Only togetherness.

Eventually, they stopped near an isolated roadside viewpoint overlooking the sleeping city far below.

Fog drifted slowly through the hills while distant lights flickered softly like tiny stars beneath the darkness.

Akira turned off the engine.

And instantly—

the world became quiet.

Completely quiet.

No traffic.

No voices.

Only wind.

Yuki slowly stepped out of the car while wrapping his jacket tighter around herself.

The cold air touched her face gently.

Then softly—

she smiled.

“I love nights like this.”

Akira stood beside her quietly.

“Why?”

“Because the world becomes honest at night.”

He looked toward her silently.

Yuki slowly walked toward the roadside railing overlooking the city.

“No noise.”

“No pretending.”

“No rushing.”

A pause.

“Only thoughts.”

The wind moved softly through her hair while moonlight rested gently across her tired face.

And for one terrifying moment—

Akira’s chest tightened painfully.

Because ***she looked beautiful tonight.***

Painfully beautiful.

Like someone already becoming memory.

They eventually sat together on the hood of the car beneath the cold midnight sky.

Yuki rested her head gently against Akira’s shoulder while both of them watched clouds drift slowly above the hills.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“Are you angry at me?”

Akira frowned immediately.

“For what?”

“For leaving first.”

The question shattered him quietly.

Akira slowly closed his eyes.
“Don’t say it like that.”

“But it’s true.”

“No.”

His voice became rough.
“It’s cruel.”

Silence filled the night around them.

Then **Yuki** quietly held his hand tighter.
“I’m scared you’ll become lonely.”

Akira immediately looked away toward the distant city lights.

Because *that fear*—
that exact fear—
had already been destroying him every night.

After some time, Yuki suddenly laughed softly.
Akira blinked.
“What?”

“You know something funny?”

“What?”

“You still look handsome when you’re worried.”

Akira stared at her in disbelief.
“At a time like this, THAT is your thought?”

“Yes.”

“You are emotionally impossible.”

Yuki smiled proudly.
“That’s why you married me.”

And somehow—
they both laughed.

A real laugh.
Small.
Soft.
But real.

Because even near grief—
love still found ways to breathe.

The night became colder as hours passed.

Yuki slowly became quieter afterward.

Her energy faded faster now.

Akira noticed immediately.
“Tired?”

“A little.”

“Let’s go home.”

Yuki slowly shook her head before resting fully against his shoulder this time.

“Five more minutes.”

Akira wrapped one arm around her carefully.

“Okay.”

The wind moved peacefully around them while the city lights shimmered far below.

And somewhere during those quiet minutes—

Yuki slowly fell asleep against him.

Akira realized it only when her breathing became softer.

Steadier.

Peaceful.

He looked down carefully.

Her face rested calmly against his shoulder beneath the cold moonlight.

And suddenly—

his eyes filled again.

Because the image felt painfully beautiful.

Like life itself was quietly preparing goodbye.

Akira gently brushed her hair away from her face.

Then whispered softly—

“I’m not ready to lose you.”

Yuki remained asleep peacefully against him.

The night gave no answer.

Only silence.

After a long while, Akira carefully carried her back into the car.

Every movement became gentle.

Protective.

As if she were ***the most fragile thing in the universe.***

Because to him—

she was.

The drive back home felt slower than usual.

Old melodies continued playing softly while Yuki slept peacefully beside him throughout the journey.

Several times—

Akira glanced toward her quietly.

Just to make sure she was still there.

Still breathing.

Still beside him.

And somewhere between the dark roads and fading songs—

tears slowly escaped his eyes again.

This time silently.

He kept driving anyway.

Because *life cruelly continues moving forward...*

even while *hearts are breaking inside it.*

Chapter 7 — The Fear of Tomorrow

The next morning arrived quietly.

Soft sunlight slowly entered through the curtains while cold wind moved gently across the balcony outside.

But something felt different today.

Heavier.

As if the house itself had sensed something changing.

Akira woke up slowly and immediately turned toward Yuki beside him.

For one brief second—

his heart stopped.

Because she looked unbelievably still.

Too still.

Fear rushed through him instantly.

“Yuki...”

His voice came out softer than a whisper.

Then slowly—

she opened her eyes.

And only then did he breathe again.

Yuki smiled weakly seeing the panic on his face.

“You look terrified.”

Akira lowered his head quietly before holding her hand tightly against his chest.

“You scared me.”

Yuki’s expression softened immediately.

“I’m sorry.”

But honestly—

he knew this fear would never leave him now.

Every moment carried the same terror.

Every silence.

Every closed eye.

Every delayed breath.

Love had slowly turned him fragile too.

Downstairs, the smell of coffee and breakfast slowly filled the house again.

Paari sat half asleep near the dining table while holding **Lisa** carefully against his shoulder.

The baby quietly stared at his tired face.

“You know,” Paari whispered seriously,

“your grandfather emotionally kidnapped you from me.”

Lisa blinked once.

Venitha placed plates on the table while laughing softly.
“She prefers stable people.”

“I AM stable.”

“You cried during a diaper commercial yesterday.”

“That was emotional storytelling.”

Even **Akira** smiled faintly hearing them.

And beside him—
Yuki laughed softly too.

But this time—
the laugh ended with quiet pain hidden beneath it.

Akira noticed immediately.

Always immediately.

Throughout breakfast, Yuki spoke less than usual.

Sometimes she stared into space for a few seconds before returning to conversations again.

Paari frowned slightly once.
“Amma... are you okay?”

Before Yuki could answer—

Akira calmly replied,
“She didn’t sleep properly.”

Paari nodded slowly.
“Take rest today.”

Yuki smiled faintly.
“I will.”

Another lie accepted silently by everyone.

That afternoon, rain clouds gathered once again above the hills.
The house became darker earlier than usual while cold wind moved softly through the balcony curtains.

Yuki rested near the sofa holding **Lisa** carefully against her chest.

The baby had finally fallen asleep peacefully after nearly an hour of chaos.

Akira sat nearby quietly watching them both.

And suddenly—

his chest tightened painfully again.

Because the image looked too beautiful.

Too fragile.

Too temporary.

Yuki slowly noticed him staring.

“What?”

Akira smiled weakly.

“Nothing.”

“That’s another lie.”

Silence.

Then softly—

“You both look beautiful.”

Yuki’s eyes immediately softened.

And for a few seconds—

neither of them spoke.

Because sometimes ***love becomes too deep for language.***

Later that evening, Yuki suddenly asked for something unexpected.

“Can we eat on the terrace tonight?”

Paari looked surprised.

“In this cold weather?”

“Mhm.”

Venitha smiled immediately.

“Then terrace dinner it is.”

And somehow—

everyone became excited by the idea.

Within an hour, warm lights glowed across the terrace once again.

Soft music played quietly from a speaker near the wall while cold wind moved gently beneath the cloudy evening sky.

The atmosphere felt peaceful.

Comfortable.

Like one of those ordinary nights families remember forever later.

Dinner became filled with endless conversations again.

Paari complained about office stress.

Venitha teased him continuously.

Lisa randomly sneezed during emotional moments.

And Akira—

Akira quietly watched Yuki smiling beside him beneath the warm terrace lights.

Trying to memorize everything again.

Always memorizing now.

At one point, Paari suddenly looked toward his parents.

“Appa.”

“Hm?”

“If you could relive one day from your life...”

He smiled softly.

“What would you choose?”

The terrace became quieter.

Wind moved gently through the lights above them while Akira thought carefully.

Then slowly—

he looked toward Yuki.

“The day I first met her.”

Yuki immediately lowered her eyes shyly despite everything.

Paari groaned dramatically.

“This family never stops being romantic.”

Akira smiled faintly.

“Good love should stay embarrassing forever.”

Venitha laughed loudly.

“I’m writing that down.”

Even Yuki laughed again hearing that.

And honestly—

that moment felt warm enough to stop time itself.

But suddenly—

everything changed.

Yuki’s smile slowly faded.

Her fingers tightened slightly against the table.

Akira noticed instantly.

“Yuki?”

The pain hit harder this time.

Much harder.

Yuki pressed one hand against her forehead while breathing unevenly.

The terrace atmosphere froze immediately.

“Amma?”

Paari stood up fast.

Venitha quickly carried Lisa away from the tension while Akira moved beside Yuki instantly.

“What happened?”

Yuki tried speaking—

but another sharp wave of pain struck before words came out.

And for the first time—

fear became visible in front of everyone.

Not hidden anymore.

Not protected anymore.

Real fear.

Akira carefully held her shoulders.

“Look at me.”

Yuki’s breathing became shaky.

The headache had become unbearable now.

Paari looked completely panicked.

“Appa, we need to go to the hospital.”

Silence.

Heavy silence.

And suddenly—

Akira realized something terrifying.

***The secret they had protected for weeks...
was beginning to break apart.***

The terrace fell completely silent.

Only the sound of cold wind moved through the hanging lights while **Yuki** struggled to breathe through the pain gripping her head.
“Amma—”

Paari rushed toward her immediately.

Akira carefully held Yuki against him while trying to keep his own fear hidden.

But this time—

his hands were trembling.

Yuki closed her eyes tightly.

The pain had become unbearable now.

Venitha stood frozen near the entrance holding **Lisa** protectively against her chest while panic slowly spread across her face.

“Appa, what’s happening?” Paari asked again.

No answer came immediately.

Because Akira knew.

The moment had arrived.

The secret could no longer survive.

“Let’s go downstairs first,” Akira whispered softly to Yuki.

She slowly nodded weakly.

Together, they carefully helped her back inside while the warm terrace atmosphere disappeared behind them.

Everything felt different now.

Heavier.

Fear had finally entered the house openly.

Inside the living room, Yuki rested carefully against the sofa while Akira brought water quickly.

Paari paced restlessly nearby.

“What did the doctor actually say?”

Silence.

Akira froze for a brief second.

Venitha slowly looked toward him too.

And suddenly—

the entire room felt unbearably still.

Akira lowered his eyes quietly.

Yuki noticed immediately.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“Tell them.”

The words nearly destroyed him.

Because ***saying the truth aloud would make it real.***

Permanent.

Painfully real.

Paari frowned slowly.

“Appa...?”

Akira sat down beside **Yuki** carefully before speaking.

His voice came out quieter than usual.

“The hospital found something.”

The room remained frozen.

“A condition affecting the brain.”

Venitha’s expression slowly changed.

Paari stopped breathing for a moment.

Akira continued somehow—

even while his chest felt like it was collapsing.

“The doctors said...”

His voice cracked.

Then finally—

“She doesn’t have much time left.”

Silence.

Not normal silence.

The kind of silence that changes people forever.

Paari stared at him blankly.

As if his mind refused to understand the sentence.

“What...?”

Akira lowered his head.

“They said maybe one month.”

Venitha immediately covered her mouth while tears reached her eyes instantly.

And Paari—

Paari simply stood there motionless.

“No.”

The word escaped automatically.

“No.”

His breathing became uneven.

“That’s not possible.”

Nobody answered.

Because nobody could.

Paari slowly looked toward Yuki.

And seeing her crying quietly beside Akira—

completely shattered him.

“You knew?”

Yuki nodded weakly through tears.

The pain inside **Paari** exploded instantly.

“You BOTH knew?!”

His voice cracked loudly across the room.

“For weeks?!”

Akira stood up immediately.

“Paari—”

“You hid this from us?!”

Tears rushed down his face uncontrollably now.

“How could you do that?!”

Venitha herself had already begun crying silently nearby while holding **Lisa** tightly against her chest.

The baby looked around innocently—

completely unaware that the world inside the house had just broken apart.

Yuki tried speaking softly.

“I didn’t want you to suffer—”

“But we’re suffering NOW!”

Paari’s voice shattered completely.

He turned away while running both hands through his hair desperately.

“No...”

“No...”

He looked completely lost.

Like a child again.

And honestly—

that hurt Akira more than anything else.

Because for the first time since childhood—

Paari looked afraid of life itself.

After a few moments, Paari suddenly walked toward Yuki and knelt in front of her.

His tears refused to stop now.

“Amma...”

Yuki gently touched his face immediately despite her own pain.

“I’m sorry.”

Paari shook his head desperately.

“No...”

“You don’t apologize.”

His breathing became uneven again.

“You don’t leave.”

The room broke emotionally after that.

Venitha cried openly now while Akira turned away briefly trying to control himself.

But he couldn't anymore.

Not tonight.

Not after seeing his family collapse like this.

Then suddenly—

Lisa began crying loudly.

The sound echoed through the painful silence immediately.

Venitha tried calming her quickly while crying herself.

And somehow—

that small cry changed something inside the room.

Because ***life was still continuing.***

Even now.

Pain and life existing together cruelly at the same time.

Paari slowly lowered his head against Yuki's lap while crying silently like a child.

And Yuki—

even while dying—

still comforted him first.

She gently stroked his hair softly.

“Hey...”

Her voice remained unbelievably gentle.

“Look at me.”

Paari slowly lifted his tear-filled eyes.

Yuki smiled weakly through her own tears.

“You promised me something once.”

He frowned painfully.

“What?”

“You said you'd always protect this family.”

Silence.

Then softly—

“I need you to do that now.”

Paari completely broke after hearing that.

Because suddenly—

he understood.

She was already preparing to leave.

Akira quietly sat beside them again and gently held Yuki's hand tightly.

And for the first time—

the secret no longer existed between them.

Now ***everyone carried the pain together.***

The house that once overflowed only with warmth...

had finally learned grief.

And outside—

rain slowly began falling once again across the hills of Dindigul.

As if even the sky itself could no longer hold back tears.

After the truth came out—

the house changed completely.

Not physically.

The walls remained the same.

The balcony still faced the hills.

The kitchen still smelled like coffee every morning.

But emotionally—

everything became fragile.

As if every person inside the house had suddenly become afraid of tomorrow.

That night, nobody slept.

Rain continued falling softly outside while silence filled the living room.

Yuki rested quietly near the sofa beneath a blanket while Akira remained beside her without moving even once.

Paari sat near the balcony with both hands covering his face.

And Venitha silently rocked Lisa to sleep while tears continued falling down her cheeks.

Nobody knew what to say anymore.

Because there are moments in life where ***words become useless.***

Around 2:00 AM, Paari suddenly stood up.

“I’m taking Amma to another hospital.”

Akira looked toward him quietly.

“We already checked.”

“I don’t care.”

His voice cracked sharply.

“We’ll go to Chennai.”

“Bangalore.”

“Anywhere.”

“There HAS to be something.”

Yuki slowly looked toward him.

“Paari—”

“No.”

He shook his head desperately.

“You’re not giving up.”

Tears rolled endlessly down his face now.

“You can’t.”

Yuki’s expression softened painfully.

Because hearing ***her son break apart like this hurt more than her illness itself.***

Akira quietly stood up and walked toward **Paari** slowly.

Then gently placed one hand on his shoulder.

“I tried.”

Silence.

Paari slowly looked toward him.

And for the first time—

he saw it clearly.

The exhaustion.

The sleeplessness.

The silent destruction Akira had been carrying alone for weeks.

His father looked older now.

Much older.

Not because of age.

Because grief had already started changing him.

Akira lowered his eyes quietly.

“I searched everywhere.”

His voice became weaker.

“I begged for hope.”

The room became silent again.

Then softly—

“There wasn’t any.”

Paari’s anger collapsed instantly after hearing that.

Because suddenly—

he realized something painful.

His father had already been suffering alone this entire time.

Without another word, Paari hugged Akira tightly.

And for several seconds—

both of them simply stood there holding each other while tears silently fell.

No pride.

No strength.

Only pain.

Only love.

Yuki quietly watched them together from the sofa.

And honestly—

her heart shattered seeing them like this.

Not because she feared death anymore.

But because she hated being the reason they were hurting.

Venitha slowly sat beside her.

Then gently held her hand.

“Amma...”

Yuki turned toward **Venitha** slowly.

Venitha’s voice trembled immediately.

“You should’ve told us.”

Yuki smiled weakly.

“I wanted you happy.”

Venitha broke down crying again

“We would’ve stayed beside you anyway.”

And hearing that—

Yuki’s own tears returned too.

Because ***this family loved deeply.***

Painfully deeply.

The rain became heavier outside while cold wind touched the windows softly.

Lisa suddenly woke up again and began crying loudly from the tension filling the room.

Venitha immediately carried her carefully while trying to calm her.

But the baby continued crying stubbornly.

Then quietly—

Yuki stretched out her arms.

“Give her to me.”

Venitha hesitated for a moment.

Then slowly placed Lisa into Yuki’s arms.

And almost instantly—

the baby became calm.

The entire room fell silent watching them.

Lisa blinked slowly while resting peacefully against Yuki’s chest.

And suddenly—

Akira’s eyes filled again.

Because ***the image hurt too much.***

A grandmother holding her granddaughter gently...

while secretly running out of time.

Yuki softly kissed Lisa’s forehead.

Then whispered quietly—

“You won’t remember me...”

The sentence nearly destroyed everyone inside the room.

Paari immediately turned away again while Akira closed his eyes tightly.

But then Yuki smiled faintly.

“That’s okay.”

She gently touched Lisa’s tiny fingers.

“Because I’ll still love you anyway.”

The room broke emotionally after that.

Even **Venitha** could no longer stop crying.

And **Akira**—

Akira finally walked toward **Yuki** again before kneeling beside her.

Then carefully—

he rested his forehead against hers.

“I’m sorry,” he whispered painfully.

Yuki immediately shook her head weakly.

“No.”

Tears slowly rolled down her cheeks.

“You gave me the happiest life.”

Silence.

Then softly—

“And that was enough.”

But to Akira—

it would never feel enough.

Never.

Because no amount of years could prepare someone to lose the person who became their entire world.

Hours later, near dawn—

the rain finally slowed.

The house had grown quiet again.

Exhausted quiet.

The kind that arrives after hearts have cried too much.

Paari eventually fell asleep near the balcony sofa while sitting upright.

Venitha slept nearby holding Lisa protectively against her chest.

And in the middle of that silent living room—

Akira still sat beside Yuki holding her hand tightly.

Neither of them slept.

Neither wanted to.

Because now—

every remaining moment together felt unbearably precious.

Outside, the first light of morning slowly touched the hills of Dindigul.

But inside the house—

the night still remained inside everyone’s hearts.

Chapter 8 — The Days That Hurt the Most

Morning arrived quietly after the longest night the family had ever lived through.

The rain had finally stopped.

Soft mist rested across the hills outside while pale sunlight slowly entered through the windows of the silent house.

But nobody inside felt rested.

Not physically.
Not emotionally.

It felt as if grief itself had stayed awake beside them all night.

Akira still sat near **Yuki** when morning fully arrived.

Their hands remained intertwined exactly the same way they had been hours earlier.

Neither had slept.

At some point during the night, Yuki had quietly leaned against his shoulder while listening to the rain.

And Akira—

Akira had simply stayed there holding her like he feared time would steal her the moment he moved.

Now the world outside had become brighter again.

But inside him—
everything still felt dark.

Near the balcony sofa, **Paari** slowly woke up first.

For a few confused seconds, he stared blankly at the ceiling.

Then suddenly—
everything returned.

The hospital.

The truth.

The word “*one month.*”

His chest tightened instantly.

He slowly looked toward Yuki sitting beside Akira.

And the pain returned all over again.

Real.

Permanent.

Cruel.

Venitha woke up next while still holding **Lisa** carefully against her chest.

The baby blinked sleepily before making soft noises completely unaware of the emotional storm surrounding the house.

And honestly—
that innocence hurt everyone too.

Because life continued normally for **Lisa**.

While everyone else silently felt their world collapsing.
Nobody spoke much during breakfast.

The dining table felt quieter than ever before.
Even **Paari**, who usually filled every silence with random conversations, remained still.
Yuki noticed it immediately.

And somehow—
that hurt her more than her illness.

Because this was exactly what she feared.

The warmth inside the house had begun fading.

Finally, Yuki softly placed her spoon down and looked around at everyone.
“Can all of you stop looking at me like I already disappeared?”

Silence.

Nobody knew how to answer.

Yuki smiled weakly.
“I’m still here.”

Paari immediately lowered his eyes.

Because hearing those words made his chest ache unbearably.

Akira quietly looked toward her too.

And honestly—
that sentence terrified him.

Because now every moment felt temporary enough to count.

Then suddenly—
Yuki did something unexpected.

She smiled softly and spoke with gentle firmness.
“Today we’re going outside.”

Paari blinked in confusion.
“What?”

“Outside.”

“Where?”

“I don’t care.”

Venitha frowned slightly.
“Amma, you should rest.”

Yuki shook her head slowly.
“No.”

Her eyes moved toward all of them one by one.
“We already wasted enough time crying.”

The room became silent again.

Then softly—

“I don’t want my remaining days to become only sadness.”

That sentence completely broke the atmosphere.

Because suddenly—

everyone realized something painful.

She had already accepted it.

Far more than any of them had.

A few hours later, the family slowly prepared to leave the house together.

No destination.

No plan.

Just driving.

Just staying together.

And somehow—

that alone felt important now.

The BMW moved quietly through the roads outside Dindigul while soft music played in the background.

This time—

nobody argued.

Nobody joked loudly.

Even **Paari** remained unusually quiet while looking out the window beside **Venitha** and **Lisa**.

Yuki noticed immediately.

Then softly—

she reached back and hit his knee lightly.

Paari looked confused.

“What?”

“You’re too silent.”

“I’m thinking.”

“Dangerous activity.”

For the first time since last night—

a tiny smile appeared on his face.

And honestly—

that small smile felt like sunlight returning after storms.

Eventually, they stopped near a quiet flower garden outside the city.

The place looked peaceful beneath the cloudy sky.

Children ran between flower paths laughing loudly while old couples walked slowly holding hands beneath the trees.

Life continued normally there.

Unaffected.

Beautifully ordinary.

Yuki quietly stepped out first and slowly looked around.

Then softly—

she smiled again.

“This place feels alive.”

Akira walked beside her carefully while the others followed behind.

And for a brief moment—

the family almost looked normal again.

Almost.

Lisa suddenly became excited seeing colorful flowers moving in the wind.

Tiny sounds escaped her while she reached her hands forward happily.

Paari immediately looked emotional.

“She likes flowers...”

Venitha laughed softly.

“She likes literally everything.”

Akira quietly watched Yuki kneel slowly near a row of white flowers.

The wind moved gently through her hair while soft sunlight touched her face.

And suddenly—

his chest hurt so badly he could barely breathe.

Because ***she looked beautiful.***

Not sick.

Not weak.

Just beautiful.

And that somehow made losing her feel even crueler.

Yuki noticed him staring again.

“You’re doing it again.”

Akira slowly walked toward her.

“What?”

“Looking at me like I’ll disappear.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

“I’m trying to memorize you.”

The honesty in his voice completely shattered her.

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled with tears again.

But this time—

she smiled through them.

Then softly whispered—

“Then remember me smiling.”

And beneath the cloudy afternoon sky—

Akira gently held her hand tighter.

Trying desperately to memorize everything exactly the way she asked.

The flower garden slowly became quieter as evening approached.

Soft wind moved through the colorful rows of flowers while clouds drifted lazily across the fading sky. Somewhere nearby, children continued laughing while chasing each other between the pathways.

And for a brief moment—
Yuki simply stood there watching them.

Peacefully.

Silently.

Then softly—

she whispered,
“I love sounds like that.”

Akira looked toward her.
“What sounds?”

“Children laughing.”

Her eyes slowly moved toward Lisa resting in Venitha’s arms nearby.
“It makes the world feel alive.”

Akira’s chest tightened again.
Because even now—
even while standing near the edge of goodbye—
she still noticed beauty first.

The family slowly walked deeper into the garden together.

Paari pushed Lisa’s stroller carefully while Venitha walked beside him pointing excitedly at different flowers.
“This one is beautiful.”

“That one looks expensive.”

“You judge flowers financially?”

“Everything has budget.”

Even Yuki laughed softly hearing them.

And honestly—
every laugh felt precious now.

Not ordinary anymore.

Precious.

At one point, they reached a quiet pond near the far side of the garden.

White lotus flowers floated peacefully across the water while evening sunlight reflected gently through the trees.

The atmosphere there felt calm.

Almost unreal.

Yuki slowly sat down near the wooden bench facing the pond while Akira remained beside her.

Paari and Venitha wandered slightly ahead with Lisa.

For the first time that day—

Akira and **Yuki** were briefly alone again.
The silence between them felt softer now.

Less fearful.

Then quietly—
Yuki leaned against his shoulder.
“You know something?”

Akira looked down at her.
“What?”

“I’m glad it was you.”

His brows slowly frowned.
“What?”

“My life.”

Silence.

Yuki smiled faintly while staring at the pond.

“I’m glad I spent it with you.”

Akira immediately looked away toward the water.
Because *tears had already reached his eyes again.*

He tried controlling them.

But honestly—
he was losing that battle more and more each day.

Yuki slowly noticed his trembling hand resting beside her.

Then gently—

she held it tightly.

“Hey...”

Akira closed his eyes briefly.
“I’m trying.”

“I know.”

“No matter how hard I try...”

His voice cracked softly.
“I still can’t imagine this house without you.”

The evening wind moved gently around them.

Yuki lowered her eyes slowly.
“Then don’t imagine it yet.”

Silence.

Then softly—
“Stay with me now.”

And somehow—
those simple words brought him back again.

Back to the moment.

Back to her.

Because ***grief had already begun pulling him toward a future he wasn't ready to face.***

Nearby, **Lisa** suddenly started laughing loudly at something **Paari** was doing.

Both **Akira** and **Yuki** turned immediately.

Paari was spinning slowly near the stroller while making ridiculous expressions.

Venitha stood nearby laughing so hard she could barely breathe.

Lisa's tiny laughter echoed beautifully across the garden.

Pure.

Innocent.

Alive.

Yuki's eyes instantly filled with tears again watching them.

And this time—

Akira understood exactly why.

Because somewhere deep inside her heart—

she was trying to memorize them too.

As sunset slowly painted the sky orange and gold, the family finally prepared to leave the garden.

But before getting into the car—

Yuki suddenly stopped walking.

Akira immediately turned.

“What happened?”

Instead of answering—

Yuki quietly looked toward the sky.

The sunset spread beautifully across the hills beyond the trees while wind moved softly through the flowers around them.

Then slowly—

she smiled.

“This is enough.”

Akira's expression immediately changed.

“What is?”

Yuki looked toward him gently.

“This life.”

Silence crushed his chest instantly.

“No,” he whispered softly.

But Yuki stepped closer and carefully touched his face.

“I mean it.”

Her eyes became emotional again.
“I was loved properly.”

The tears finally escaped his eyes completely now.

Because hearing someone speak about their life like a farewell...

felt unbearable.

Yuki smiled weakly through her own tears.
“And honestly...”

She looked toward **Paari**, **Venitha**, and **Lisa** waiting near the car.
“I think that’s the luckiest thing a person can ask for.”

Akira immediately pulled her into his arms tightly.

Too tightly.

Like his heart was begging time not to take her away yet.

And beneath the fading evening sky—

Yuki quietly closed her eyes against his chest.

Listening to his heartbeat.
Memorizing it too.

Because somewhere deep inside both of them—

they already understood something painful.

The end was slowly getting closer now.

The drive back home felt quieter than usual.

Outside the car windows, the evening sky slowly faded into darkness while streetlights passed one by one across the wet roads.

Inside the BMW—
soft music played quietly.

Lisa had already fallen asleep inside Venitha’s arms.
Paari stared silently outside the window.
And Yuki rested peacefully beside Akira while holding his hand gently near the gearshift.

Nobody wanted the day to end.

Because somehow—
every beautiful day now felt dangerous.
Like it could become the last beautiful memory without warning.

When they finally reached home, cold wind moved softly through the trees surrounding the house.

The balcony lights glowed warmly against the dark hills while distant thunder echoed somewhere far away.

Yuki paused near the entrance for a brief moment.

Then quietly—
she looked at the house again.

The walls.
The windows.
The balcony.
Her home.

And suddenly—
her eyes became emotional once more.

Akira noticed immediately.

He always noticed.

Without speaking, he gently placed one hand around her shoulders and guided her inside slowly.

No words.

Only understanding.

That night, nobody had energy for loud conversations anymore.

Dinner became soft.

Peaceful.

Heavy.

Still—

they tried.

Paari forced himself to joke occasionally.

Venitha smiled even while her eyes remained red from crying earlier.

And Yuki—

Yuki kept trying to make everyone comfortable instead of herself.

Even now.

Even like this.

After dinner, **Lisa** somehow became unusually energetic.

The baby refused to sleep completely and instead kept making tiny noises while grabbing everyone’s fingers one by one.

At one point, she grabbed Yuki’s finger tightly and refused to let go.

The room immediately became quieter.

Yuki looked down at the tiny hand holding her finger.

And suddenly—

her breathing became uneven for a second.

Because the moment felt too emotional.

Too beautiful.

Too painful.

Akira slowly looked away.

Because ***he understood exactly what she was thinking.***

One day—

Lisa would grow older.

And Yuki would no longer be there to hold her hand back.

Later that night, rain began falling once again.

Soft at first.

Then heavier.

The familiar sound filled the house while cold wind moved gently through the balcony curtains.

Paari and Venitha eventually carried sleeping Lisa upstairs.

And once again—

only Akira and Yuki remained awake.

The living room looked dim beneath the warm yellow lights while rain touched the windows endlessly outside.

Yuki quietly rested against the sofa while **Akira** made fresh coffee for both of them.

When he returned, she smiled softly.

“You’re making too much coffee these days.”

Akira sat beside her slowly.

“I need it.”

“To stay awake?”

“To stay calm.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

Yuki leaned against him again.

The same way she always did.

Like ***his shoulder had become home itself.***

For a long time—

they simply listened to the rain together.

No television.

No music.

Only silence and weather.

Then suddenly—

Yuki whispered softly,

“Promise me something else.”

Akira immediately looked down at her.

“What?”

“If one day you feel lonely...”

Her voice became gentler.

“Don’t sit inside darkness alone.”

Akira lowered his eyes quietly.

“Yuki...”

“No, listen.”

She slowly held his hand tighter.

“Talk to Paari.”

“Play with Lisa.”

“Fight with Venitha about food.”

A faint smile appeared on her face.

“Live loudly.”

The tears returned instantly.

Because ***she was already trying to prepare life after herself.***

And that reality felt unbearable.

Akira suddenly stood up and walked toward the balcony.

The rain hit harder outside now while fog slowly swallowed the distant hills completely.

For several seconds—

Akira simply stood there breathing heavily.

Trying not to break again.

But footsteps quietly approached behind him.

Yuki.

She gently wrapped both arms around him from behind despite her weakening body.

And softly—

she whispered near his back,

“You don’t have to be strong every second.”

That sentence destroyed the last wall inside him.

Akira turned immediately and held her tightly.

Then finally—

he cried openly against her shoulder.

Not quietly anymore.

Not hiding anymore.

Years of strength...

fear...

love...

and helplessness collapsed together inside him at once.

“I don’t know how to lose you,” he whispered painfully.

Yuki closed her eyes tightly hearing that.

Because honestly—

she didn’t know how to leave him either.

The rainstorm continued outside while both of them stood together near the balcony in silence afterward.

No more words came.

Only warmth.

Only trembling hands holding each other tighter.

And somewhere inside that cold storm-filled night—

both hearts silently understood something terrifying.

Time was no longer slowing down anymore.

Now—

it was running.

Chapter 9 — The Time That Refused to Stop

The storm lasted the entire night.

Rain crashed endlessly against the windows while cold wind moved through the hills surrounding the house.

And inside the balcony—

Akira and **Yuki** remained together until dawn.

Neither wanted to let go.

Not anymore.

Because now—

every embrace felt like something they might never get back.

Morning arrived slowly beneath grey clouds.

The house remained unusually quiet.

Even the world outside seemed softer after the storm.

Akira woke up first again.

But this time—

he didn’t move immediately.

Yuki still slept peacefully against his chest while one of her hands remained tightly holding his shirt even during sleep.

As if somewhere inside her dreams—

she was also afraid of distance now.

Akira slowly looked down at her.

And for several long seconds—

he simply watched her breathe.

That had become his habit recently.

Watching.

Checking.

Making sure she was still beside him.

Still alive.

Still his.

Then suddenly—

Yuki opened her eyes slightly.

And immediately smiled seeing him staring again.

“You’re doing it again.”

Akira lowered his head faintly.

“I know.”

“Did you sleep at all?”

“A little.”

“That’s another lie.”

Akira smiled weakly for the first time that morning.

Yuki slowly touched his face gently.

“You look tired.”

Akira closed his eyes briefly against her hand.
“I’m scared to rest.”

Silence filled the room softly.

Then quietly—

Yuki whispered,
“I’m still here.”

But now—

those words hurt more than comforted him.

Because every time she said them...
he remembered one terrifying truth.

Not forever.

Downstairs, the smell of breakfast slowly filled the house again.

Venitha stood near the kitchen preparing food while **Lisa** sat inside a baby chair making random sounds at absolutely nothing.
Paari entered half asleep carrying coffee.

Then froze.

Because for the first time in days—

he heard Yuki laughing upstairs.

A real laugh.
Soft.
Warm.
Alive.

Paari’s eyes immediately became emotional.

Venitha noticed instantly.
“You okay?”

Paari nodded slowly.

Then quietly whispered—
“I don’t want to forget that sound.”

The sentence stayed inside the kitchen heavily.

Because everyone understood exactly what he meant.

A little later, everyone gathered for breakfast together.

The atmosphere felt strangely calmer today.

Not happy.

Not sad.

Just...

gentle.

Like the family had finally stopped fighting reality and simply chosen to stay beside each other instead.

Lisa randomly dropped her spoon on the floor three different times.

Paari sighed dramatically each time while picking it up.
“This child enjoys violence.”

Venitha looked proud.
“She inherited intelligence.”

Even **Yuki** laughed softly again.

And hearing it—

***Akira secretly thanked life once more.
Just for one more morning.***
After breakfast, Yuki suddenly stood near the family photo wall inside the living room.

Frames covered nearly the entire wall now.
Old vacations.
Birthday celebrations.
Graduation pictures.
Anniversary dinners.
Small ordinary moments frozen forever.

Yuki slowly touched one photograph gently.

A younger Akira holding little Paari near the beach.

Another picture showed all three of them during a rainy road trip years ago.

Then—
her eyes stopped at the newest photo.

The one from Akira’s birthday terrace celebration.

All of them smiling together beneath warm lights.

***Perfect.
Beautiful.
Complete.***

Yuki quietly smiled through tears.
“I love this one.”

Akira walked beside her slowly.
“So do I.”

And honestly—

that photo already felt like memory now.

Then suddenly—

Yuki turned toward everyone.
“Let’s take another picture today.”

Paari looked confused.
“Now?”

“Yes.”

“In house clothes?”

“Yes.”

Venitha laughed softly.
“Amma wants natural photos.”

Yuki nodded.
“Real ones.”

And somehow—
everyone agreed immediately.

Because now—
no one wanted to reject anything that might later become precious.

The family gathered together near the balcony where soft morning light entered beautifully through the windows.
Lisa sat in **Akira’s** arms while Yuki rested beside him.
Paari stood behind them with one arm around **Venitha**.

The timer began counting down.

3...
2...
1...

And in that tiny frozen second—

everyone smiled.

Not fake smiles.
Not forced ones.

Real smiles.

The kind born from *love trying desperately to stay stronger than fear.*

Click.

The photo captured forever.

And none of them realized yet—
that picture would later become one of the most important things inside the house.

Later that afternoon, Yuki became tired again.

Much faster this time.

While sitting near the balcony, she suddenly leaned heavily against Akira’s shoulder.

His heart instantly tightened.
“You okay?”

Yuki nodded weakly.
“Just sleepy.”
But her voice sounded distant now.

Exhausted.

Akira carefully held her closer.

And for the first time—
real panic quietly returned inside him again.

Because deep inside—
he felt something terrifying.

Time was changing faster now.

Too fast.

And somewhere beyond the hills of Dindigul—
dark clouds slowly began gathering once more.

By evening—
the sky had turned dark once more.

Heavy clouds covered the hills surrounding the house while cold wind moved endlessly through the trees outside.

Inside the balcony, the family photo from the morning still rested on the table beside **Akira’s** coffee cup.

Fresh.
Warm.
Alive.

And somehow—
that alone terrified him now.

Because beautiful moments were beginning to feel *too temporary.*

Yuki slept for nearly three hours that afternoon.

Something she never usually did.

Even during sickness.

Akira remained beside her the entire time.

Not reading.

Not using his phone.

Not watching television.

Just sitting there quietly.

Watching her breathe.

At one point, Yuki slowly opened her eyes and noticed him immediately.

“You’re still here?”

Akira smiled faintly.

“Where else would I go?”

Yuki’s expression softened painfully.

Then quietly—

she whispered,

“You look more tired than me now.”

Akira looked away slightly.

Because honestly—

he probably was.

Grief had already begun exhausting him before loss itself even arrived.

Downstairs, **Paari** sat silently near the living room holding **Lisa** against his chest.

The baby rested peacefully while small evening lights glowed softly around the house.

Venitha slowly sat beside **Paari**.

“You didn’t go to office today.”

Paari shook his head.

“I couldn’t.”

Silence followed.

Then softly—

“I feel guilty for every normal thing I do now.”

Venitha’s eyes slowly became emotional too.

Paari lowered his head.

“When I laugh...”

His voice cracked quietly.

“I suddenly feel bad because Amma is suffering.”

Venitha gently held his hand.

“She wants us to smile.”

“I know.”

Tears reached his eyes again.

“But it hurts.”

And honestly—

everyone inside the house had begun learning the same painful truth.

Sometimes ***love and pain grow together.***

Later that night, thunder echoed across the hills again.

Rain slowly began falling while everyone gathered inside the living room.

This time—

nobody turned on the television.

Nobody searched for movies.

Nobody pretended things were normal anymore.

Instead—

they simply stayed together.

Lisa slept near **Yuki** while **Akira** quietly massaged Yuki’s fingers because the pain in her body had slowly started increasing.

Even small movements exhausted her now.

Paari watched silently from across the room.

And suddenly—

his chest hurt unbearably.

Because his mother looked smaller somehow.

Fragile.

Like life itself was slowly pulling her away piece by piece.

Then suddenly—

Yuki softly looked toward him.

“Paari.”

He immediately moved closer.

“Hm?”

Yuki smiled weakly.

“Can you do something for me?”

“Anything.”

“Play that old song.”

Paari frowned slightly.

“Which one?”

“The one Appa used to sing terribly.”

Akira immediately looked offended.

“I sing very well.”

“No,” everyone answered together.

For the first time in days—

real laughter returned again.

Small.

But real.

Paari eventually played the old melody through the speaker near the shelf.

Soft music slowly filled the room while rain touched the windows outside.

And quietly—

Akira began singing along badly on purpose.

Yuki laughed so hard tears reached her eyes again.

Even **Lisa** woke up slightly because of the noise.

Paari covered his ears dramatically.

“This is emotional torture.”

Venitha nearly fell laughing beside him.

And for a brief moment—

the house became alive again.

Not with fear.

Not with grief.

But with warmth.

Exactly the way Yuki wanted.

Much later into the night, Lisa finally fell asleep again.

Paari and Venitha slowly went upstairs.

And once again—

only Akira and Yuki remained awake near the balcony.

Rain continued outside endlessly while dim yellow light filled the room softly.

Yuki rested quietly against him beneath the blanket.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“Thank you.”

Akira looked down immediately.

“For what?”

“For trying so hard.”

Silence.

Yuki slowly closed her eyes.

“You keep holding everyone together even while breaking yourself.”

That sentence hit him painfully hard.

Because it was true.

Every day now felt like carrying invisible weight across his chest.

Still—

he continued smiling for everyone.

Because if he collapsed—

the whole house would collapse with him.

Akira gently kissed her forehead.

“I would carry everything for you if I could.”

Yuki’s breathing softened.

“I know.”

Then quietly—

“That’s why I’m scared to leave you.”

The room became silent again.

Rain.

Wind.

Heartbeats.

Everything else disappeared.

Akira slowly held her closer.

And for the first time—

his voice completely broke.

“I’m begging time every day now.”

Yuki looked up at him softly.

“For what?”

His eyes filled again.

“One more year.”

Silence.

“Even one more month.”

Another pause.

“Even one more day.”

And suddenly—

Yuki began crying too.

Because ***no love in the world feels enough when time starts ending.***

Near midnight, Yuki finally became exhausted again.

Akira carefully carried her upstairs in his arms despite her weak protests.

“You’ll hurt your back.”

“You’re lighter than my regrets.”

Yuki laughed softly through tears.

Even now—

he still tried making her smile first.

Inside the bedroom, Akira gently placed her onto the bed before covering her carefully with the blanket.

Yuki slowly reached for his hand before he could move away.

“Stay.”

Akira immediately sat beside her again.

And under the soft yellow light—

Yuki slowly fell asleep while holding his hand tightly.

As if somewhere deep inside—

even her heart feared separation now.

Outside—

rain continued falling endlessly across the dark hills of Dindigul.

And somewhere inside that sleeping house—

time quietly kept moving forward anyway.

The days after that became quieter.

Not peaceful quiet.

Fragile quiet.

The kind where everyone inside the house tried speaking gently... as if louder voices might somehow break the remaining time apart.

Even **Lisa** seemed calmer these days.

Sometimes she sat silently inside Akira’s arms staring at Yuki with wide curious eyes.

And every single time—

Yuki smiled at her like she was looking at an entire future she would never fully see.

One evening, cold fog covered the hills earlier than usual.

The balcony disappeared beneath pale mist while distant thunder rolled quietly somewhere beyond the mountains.

Inside the house, warm yellow lights glowed softly against the rainy darkness outside.

Yuki sat near the sofa wrapped in a blanket while Akira prepared coffee once again.

The smell slowly filled the room.

Comforting.

Familiar.

Home.

Paari entered the living room carrying Lisa carefully against his shoulder.

“She refuses to sleep.”

Venitha walked behind **Paari** completely exhausted.

“She inherited your drama.”

“I was peaceful as a child.”

Akira looked up immediately.

“That is the biggest lie ever spoken.”

Even **Yuki** laughed softly hearing that.

And honestly—

those tiny laughs had become precious enough to hurt.

Because everyone had started noticing the same terrifying thing.

Yuki’s laughter was becoming weaker now.

Shorter.

Softer.

Like even joy itself exhausted her body.

That night, dinner happened downstairs instead of the terrace because of heavy rain.

Still—

the family stayed together longer than usual afterward.

Nobody wanted to leave the room.

Nobody wanted to sleep.

Because sleep now carried fear with it.

Fear of tomorrow.

Fear of change.

Fear of losing normal life forever.

At one point, Lisa suddenly crawled clumsily toward Yuki and grabbed her blanket tightly.

The room immediately softened.

Yuki slowly lifted the baby carefully into her lap while smiling weakly.

“My little princess...”

Lisa touched Yuki’s face curiously with tiny fingers.

And suddenly—

Yuki’s eyes filled again.

Akira quietly looked away.

Because some moments became ***too painful to watch directly.***

Then softly—

Yuki whispered to Lisa,

“You have to trouble your father properly when you grow up, okay?”

Paari immediately looked offended.

“Why only me?”

“Because your mother already suffered enough.”

Even Venitha laughed hearing that.

And for a brief second—

the room became warm again.

Hours later, near midnight, everyone finally began moving upstairs.

But before leaving, **Paari** suddenly stopped near the staircase and turned back toward **Akira**.
 “Appa...”

Akira looked up slowly.

Paari hesitated.

Then quietly asked—
 “Are you okay?”

The question stayed heavily inside the room.

Because nobody had asked Akira that directly yet.

Everyone had been too busy worrying about Yuki.

Akira smiled faintly.
 “I’m managing.”

Paari slowly walked back toward him.

And for the first time since childhood—
he hugged his father first.

Not as a son asking for protection.
 But as a man realizing ***his father was hurting too.***

Akira quietly closed his eyes during the hug.

And honestly—
that nearly broke him more than anything else.

Later that night, rain hit harder against the windows.

The storm outside became violent again while cold wind shook the trees surrounding the house.

Inside the bedroom—
Yuki looked exhausted.

More exhausted than ever before.
 Akira helped her lie down carefully before sitting beside her quietly.

For several minutes—
neither spoke.

Then softly—
 Yuki whispered,
 “I think my body is getting tired.”

The sentence shattered the remaining calm inside him instantly.

Akira grabbed her hand tightly.
 “Don’t say that.”

Yuki smiled weakly.
 “I can feel it.”

Tears immediately reached his eyes again.
 “No.”

Yuki slowly touched his cheek gently.
 “Hey...”

Her voice remained unbelievably soft.

“It’s okay.”

But to Akira—

nothing about this would ever feel okay.

The storm outside became louder.

Thunder echoed across the hills while rain crashed endlessly against the balcony glass.

Yuki slowly leaned closer against him.

Then whispered quietly—

“Can you hold me?”

Akira immediately wrapped both arms around her carefully.

As if protecting her from the world itself.

Yuki closed her eyes against his chest peacefully.

Listening to his heartbeat again.

And somewhere during that silent storm-filled night—

Akira realized something terrifying.

He had started memorizing everything unconsciously now.

Her warmth.

Her breathing.

The weight of her against him.

The sound of her voice.

Because deep inside—

his heart already feared the emptiness that would come after.

Near 3:00 AM, Yuki finally fell asleep in his arms.

But Akira stayed awake.

Completely awake.

The storm outside slowly continued while moonlight occasionally flashed through the rain clouds.

And in the middle of that cold sleepless night—

Akira quietly lowered his head against Yuki’s hair.

Then whispered the truth he could never say while she was awake.

“I don’t know how to survive after you.”

The storm gave no answer.

Only rain.

Only darkness.

Only time moving forward without mercy.

Chapter 10 — The Night Time Became Cruel

Around **4:12 AM**—
the storm suddenly became silent.

Not outside.

Inside the room.

Akira slowly realized something was wrong when **Yuki’s** breathing changed against his chest.

Weak.

Uneven.

Painfully uneven.

He immediately looked down.
 “Yuki?”

No response.

Only a soft wince crossed her face.

Fear exploded inside him instantly.
 “Yuki.”

This time his voice shook badly.

Yuki slowly opened her eyes halfway.

And for the first time since all of this began—

Akira saw real pain in them.

Not hidden.
 Not controlled.

Real.

Another sharp wave of pain hit her body suddenly.

Yuki gasped softly while gripping his shirt tightly.

Akira stood up immediately.
 “Paari!”

His voice echoed through the house loudly.

Within seconds—
 lights turned on upstairs.

Footsteps rushed across the hallway.

Paari burst into the room first.
 “What happened?!”

Akira’s breathing had already become uneven.
 “We’re going to the hospital. NOW.”

Venitha immediately grabbed **Lisa** while panic filled her face too.

The storm outside still raged violently while the family rushed downstairs in fear.

Everything happened too fast afterward.

Car keys.
Blankets.
Medicines.
Phones.
Trembling hands.

Broken breathing.

And in the middle of it—
Akira carefully carried **Yuki** into his arms.

She looked so weak now.
Too weak.

And honestly—
it terrified him beyond words.

The BMW tore through the rain-filled roads of Dindigul.

Thunder cracked across the sky while headlights blurred against endless water falling from above.

Paari sat in the backseat holding Yuki carefully while Venitha continuously tried calming her.
“Amma... breathe slowly...”

Yuki tried.

But pain kept stealing her strength.

Meanwhile—

Akira drove faster than he ever had before.

His fingers gripped the steering wheel so tightly they hurt.

But he didn’t feel it.

All he could hear was *Yuki’s weak breathing behind him.*

All he could think was one terrifying sentence repeating endlessly inside his head.

Not yet.

Please not yet.

The hospital finally appeared through the storm around **4:37 AM.**

Doctors and nurses rushed immediately the moment they saw Yuki’s condition.

Everything became chaos afterward.

Stretchers.
Emergency lights.
Voices.
Machines.

Running footsteps.

And suddenly—
the doors closed between them.

Akira froze outside the emergency room.

For one brief second—
his entire body stopped moving.

Because **Akira** hated those doors now.

He hated hospitals.
He hated white lights.
He hated the smell of medicine.

Because every time life pulled Yuki away from him—
it *happened behind doors like these.*

Paari stood beside him breathing heavily.
Venitha cried quietly while holding Lisa close against her chest.

And for the first time—
nobody tried staying strong anymore.

Fear had become too real now.

Minutes passed.
Then more.

Time moved painfully slow beneath the cold hospital lights.

Akira sat motionless near the wall while staring at the emergency room doors without blinking.

Nobody spoke to him.
Because *his face already said everything.*

He looked terrified.
Not emotionally terrified.

Completely shattered terrified.

Then suddenly—
the doors opened.

A doctor stepped outside quickly.

Akira stood immediately.
“How is she?”

The doctor’s expression alone destroyed whatever hope remained inside him.
“We need to prepare you.”

Silence.

The storm outside continued roaring beyond the hospital windows.

Akira slowly shook his head.
“No.”

The doctor lowered his voice gently.
“The condition is worsening rapidly.”

“No.”

“She may not have much—”

“NO.”

Akira’s voice cracked loudly through the hallway.
Everyone froze.

Because this was the first time they had ever heard him break like this.

Completely.

“I said no.”

His breathing became uneven now.

His eyes filled instantly.

“You fix her.”

The doctor remained silent.

And that silence alone became unbearable.

Paari immediately held his father before he collapsed completely.

Akira grabbed his son’s shirt tightly like a drowning man searching for something to hold onto.

“I can’t lose her.”

His voice broke violently.

“I can’t...”

Paari himself was already crying uncontrollably too.

But hearing his father sound this destroyed...

that hurt differently.

Because **Akira** had always been the strongest person inside the family.

Always calm.

Always steady.

Always safe.

And now—

he looked broken beyond repair.

A nurse finally approached quietly.

“She’s asking for him.”

Akira immediately looked up.

Without hesitation—

he rushed toward the room.

The moment he entered—

his entire heart shattered.

Yuki lay weakly beneath pale hospital light while machines quietly monitored every fragile heartbeat beside her.

She looked exhausted.

Fragile.

Painfully fragile.

But when she saw him—

she still smiled.

Still smiled.

Even now.

Akira immediately walked toward her and held her hand tightly.

And suddenly—

tears escaped both of them at the same time.

No words came first.

Only silence.

Only trembling hands.

Only fear.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,

“You came.”

Akira completely broke hearing that.

“I’ll always come.”

His voice barely worked anymore.

Yuki slowly touched his face weakly.

“You’re crying too much these days.”

Akira laughed painfully through tears.

“You’re causing problems.”

A tiny smile reached her lips again.

And somehow—

even inside that cold hospital room—

they still tried making each other smile first.

Because *that was who they were.*

Always.

The hospital room felt unbearably quiet.

Machines beeped softly beside the bed while rain continued crashing against the windows outside.

Cold white light filled the room.

But somehow—

the only thing Akira could focus on...

was *Yuki’s hand inside his.*

Still warm.

Still there.

And yet—

he felt terrified it could disappear at any second.

Yuki looked weaker than he had ever seen before.

Even speaking seemed to exhaust her now.

But despite everything—

her eyes still searched only for him.

Akira carefully sat beside the bed without letting go of her hand for even one moment.

He couldn't.

Not anymore.

For several minutes—
neither of them spoke.

Because both hearts already understood the fear filling the room.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,
“Did I scare you?”

Akira laughed weakly through tears.
“You almost killed me.”

A tiny smile appeared on her lips.
“Sorry.”

“Don’t apologize.”

His voice broke immediately.
“Just... don’t leave.”

The silence after that hurt more than words.

Because both of them knew ***love could not control what was coming anymore.***

Outside the room, **Paari** sat near the hallway with his head lowered while **Venitha** quietly cried beside him.

Lisa slept peacefully against her chest, completely unaware that the adults around her were slowly falling apart.

Paari suddenly looked toward the hospital room door.

Then whispered softly—
“I’m scared to go inside.”

Venitha looked at him silently.
“What if she looks weaker?”

His voice cracked again.
“What if I can’t handle it?”

Venitha gently held his hand.
“She’s still your Amma.”

And somehow—
that sentence gave him enough strength to stand.

Inside the room, Akira quietly adjusted Yuki’s blanket again even though it was already perfectly arranged.

He just needed something to do.
Something other than crying.

Yuki noticed immediately.
“You always fix blankets when you’re scared.”

Akira froze slightly.

Then smiled painfully.
“You remember that?”

“You forget...”

Her voice became softer.
“I watched you for thirty-four years.”

Tears immediately returned to his eyes again.

Because even now—
even here—
she still sounded like home.

Then suddenly—
Yuki’s expression changed slightly.

Fear crossed her eyes for the first time openly.

Akira noticed immediately.
“What happened?”

Yuki slowly tightened her fingers around his hand.
“I don’t want to die in a hospital.”

The sentence completely shattered him.
“No.”

His voice trembled badly.
“Don’t say that.”

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled with tears too.
“I’m scared.”

That was the first time she admitted it directly.

And hearing those words from her—
finally broke something permanent inside Akira.

Because until now—
she had always stayed calm for everyone else.

But now—
she sounded human.

Fragile.
Terrified.

And honestly—
that hurt more than anything.

Akira immediately moved closer and rested his forehead gently against hers.
“You’re not alone.”

Yuki closed her eyes tightly while tears escaped slowly down her cheeks.
“I know.”

The rain outside softened slightly.
Only heartbeats and machine sounds filled the room now.

Then quietly—
Yuki whispered something so softly he almost didn’t hear it.
“I don’t want to forget your face.”

Akira completely lost control after that.

He held her carefully while crying openly beside her hospital bed.

And for the first time in his life—
he felt truly helpless.

Not because he lacked strength.

But because *love had finally brought him to something he could neither fix nor protect.*

A few moments later, the doctor quietly entered the room.

His expression remained gentle.

Careful.

Professional.

But the sadness in his eyes remained impossible to hide.

“We stabilized her for now,” he explained softly.

Akira immediately looked up.

“For now?”

The doctor hesitated slightly.

Then nodded.

“The condition is progressing faster now.”

Silence.

Then softly—

“You should stay close to her.”

That sentence alone felt like a knife through the chest.

Because it sounded less like medical advice...

and more like goodbye.

After the doctor left, Yuki slowly looked toward the rain-covered window.

Then quietly—

she smiled weakly.

“You know something funny?”

Akira wiped his eyes quickly.

“What?”

“I always hated hospitals.”

Despite everything—

he laughed softly through tears.

“You yelled at a nurse once.”

“She stabbed me.”

“She gave you an injection.”

“She attacked me medically.”

For one tiny moment—

they both smiled again.

And honestly—

that small smile felt more heartbreaking than sadness itself.

Because it proved something painful.

Even near the edge of loss—

their love still refused to disappear.

A little later, **Paari** finally entered the room slowly.

The moment **Paari** saw **Yuki** lying there weakly beneath hospital lights—

his eyes immediately filled again.

But this time—

he forced himself to smile.

“Amma.”

Yuki smiled softly seeing him.

“There’s my dramatic son.”

Paari laughed weakly while tears escaped anyway.

“You caused all this drama.”

“Sorry.”

“No.”

He carefully held her hand too.

“You’re not allowed to apologize anymore.”

The room became emotional again instantly.

But this time—

nobody tried hiding tears.

Because the truth had already stripped all pretending away.

Now—

only love remained.

Raw.

Painful.

And desperately holding on to every remaining second together.

The rain finally slowed near dawn.

Only soft droplets touched the hospital windows now while pale morning light slowly entered the silent room.

But nobody inside felt morning.

Time itself had become meaningless there.

The hospital room only carried:

fear,

love,

and the quiet sound of machines measuring fragile life second by second.

Yuki had finally fallen asleep again after the medicines reduced the pain slightly.

Akira still sat beside her bed without moving.

One hand remained wrapped around hers carefully.

As if letting go even briefly might somehow pull her farther away.

Paari stood silently near the window while Venitha rested outside the room with Lisa asleep against her chest.

Nobody wanted to leave.

Nobody wanted distance anymore.

At one point, Paari quietly looked toward his father.

And suddenly—

Paari’s chest tightened painfully.

Because **Akira** looked exhausted beyond recognition now.

His eyes were swollen from crying.

His shoulders looked heavier.

And somehow—

he no longer looked like the calm unshakable man Paari had known his entire life.

He looked like ***a husband slowly losing the center of his world.***

Paari slowly walked toward him.

“Appa...”

Akira looked up weakly.

“You should rest a little.”

Akira immediately shook his head.

“No.”

“You haven’t slept.”

“I’m fine.”

“That’s a lie.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

Paari knelt beside him.

And softly whispered—

“She wouldn’t want you destroying yourself too.”

That sentence stayed heavily inside the room.

Because deep down—

everyone knew it was true.

Akira slowly looked toward Yuki sleeping beneath the pale hospital light.

Then finally—

his voice cracked softly.

“I don’t know how to breathe normally anymore.”

Paari’s eyes immediately filled again.

Because hearing his father sound this broken...

felt unbearable.

Akira lowered his head slowly.

“For thirty-four years...”

His fingers tightened around Yuki’s hand.

“She was every peaceful thing in my life.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

“And now time is stealing her while I sit here doing nothing.”

The helplessness inside those words destroyed Paari completely.

Without another word—

Paari hugged his father tightly again.

And for a long moment—

both men simply cried together quietly beside Yuki’s hospital bed.

Not trying to stay strong anymore.

Just grieving while love still existed.

A little later, Yuki slowly opened her eyes again.

The first thing she searched for—

was Akira.

Always Akira.

The moment she saw him beside her—

her breathing softened slightly.

“Hey...”

Akira immediately wiped his tears quickly.

“I’m here.”

Yuki noticed his red eyes instantly.

“You cried again.”

“You’re causing problems.”

A weak smile reached her lips.

Then softly—

“Come closer.”

Akira immediately leaned near her.

Yuki gently touched his forehead weakly against hers.

And for several seconds—

neither of them spoke.

Because honestly—

words had already become too small for what they were feeling now.

Then quietly—

Yuki whispered,

“If I become memory...”

Akira instantly shook his head.

“No.”

But Yuki continued softly anyway.

“Promise me something.”

His breathing became uneven again.

“Anything.”

“Don’t remember only my ending.”

Silence crushed the room.

Tears slowly rolled down her cheeks.

“Remember how much we laughed too.”

And hearing that—

Akira completely broke again.

Because even now—

Yuki feared becoming only pain inside their memories.

Akira gently kissed her trembling hands.

Then softly—

“I remember everything.”

His voice cracked badly.

“The balcony coffees.”

“Our terrible first apartment.”

“The road trips.”

“The way you laughed during movies.”

“The way you got angry over nothing.”

A tiny smile appeared on Yuki’s face again.

Akira continued through tears—

“The way you made every place feel like home.”

The room became unbearably emotional after that.

Even **Paari** turned away again trying to hide his tears.

Because watching ***love this deep...***

felt beautiful and heartbreaking at the same time.

Then suddenly—

Yuki quietly looked toward Paari.

“Come here.”

Paari immediately moved closer.

Yuki gently touched his face the same way she had when he was little.

“You have to take care of Appa after me.”

Paari instantly shook his head desperately.

“No.”

“Paari...”

“No.”

His voice cracked violently.

“You’re talking like you’re leaving tomorrow.”

Silence.

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled again.

Then softly—

“I just need to know you’ll stay beside him.”

That destroyed him completely.

Paari lowered his head against the bed while crying openly.

“I can’t do this without you...”

Yuki gently stroked his hair weakly.

“Yes you can.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

Her voice became softer.

“Because you carry my heart too.”

Outside the hospital room—

morning slowly arrived across Dindigul.

Rain clouds drifted away slowly while sunlight quietly touched the distant hills again.

The world outside continued moving normally.

Cars drove.

People laughed.

Shops opened.

Life moved forward.

But inside that hospital room—

time felt frozen.

Because four people sat together silently trying to hold onto someone they loved...

while knowing deep inside—

they were slowly losing her anyway.

Chapter 11 — The Morning They Tried to Hold Onto

The hospital room slowly filled with soft morning light.

Rain clouds had finally begun drifting away from the sky outside while sunlight touched the distant hills of Dindigul once again.

But inside the room—
nobody felt relief.

Because the fear remained.
Heavy.
Silent.
Waiting.

Yuki looked weaker after sunrise.

Not dramatically.
But enough for everyone to notice.

Her face had become paler.
Even lifting her hand seemed exhausting now.

Still—
every time someone looked worried—
she smiled first.

As if she still wanted to comfort everyone instead of herself.

Around **8:00 AM**, a nurse quietly entered the room carrying medicines.
“Only one person should stay while she rests,” she explained gently.

The words immediately made the room tense again.
Nobody wanted to leave.
Especially **Akira**.

The moment the nurse finished speaking—
his fingers tightened around Yuki’s hand unconsciously.

Yuki noticed immediately.
Then softly—
“Go drink coffee at least.”

Akira shook his head instantly.
“No.”

“You haven’t eaten.”

“I’m not hungry.”

“That’s because your brain stopped functioning.”

Even now—
even inside pain—
she still tried making him smile.

And somehow—
that hurt him more.

Finally, **Paari** stepped forward quietly.
“Appa... I’ll stay for a little while.”

Akira looked toward him silently.

The hesitation in his eyes alone showed how impossible leaving felt.

But slowly—

Yuki gently squeezed his hand weakly.
“Go.”

Her voice remained soft.

“I’ll still be here when you come back.”

Those words nearly shattered him again.

Because now—
every promise sounded fragile.

Still—
after several painful seconds—

Akira finally stood up slowly.

But before leaving—
he leaned down and kissed Yuki’s forehead gently.

The same way he always did.

Then quietly whispered—
“Don’t sleep too deeply.”

Yuki smiled faintly.
“Come back quickly.”

Outside the room, the hospital hallway felt colder than ever before.
Akira walked silently beside Venitha toward the cafeteria while Paari remained inside with Yuki.

For several moments—
nobody spoke.

Then suddenly—
Venitha softly asked,
“Appa... how are you still standing?”

Akira stopped walking for a brief second.

The question stayed inside him heavily.

Then quietly—
he answered honestly.
“I’m not.”

Venitha’s eyes instantly filled again.
Because that answer carried too much truth inside it.

Inside the room, Paari quietly sat beside Yuki while soft machine sounds filled the silence.
For a while—
neither of them spoke.

Then suddenly—
Yuki smiled weakly.
“You’ve been crying too much lately.”

Paari laughed painfully through tears.
“Whose fault is that?”

Yuki slowly looked toward him.

And suddenly—
her eyes became emotional again.

Because no matter how old **Paari** became—
when he sat beside **Yuki** like this...

he still looked like her little boy.

Paari lowered his eyes quietly.
“I’m angry at life.”

Yuki stayed silent.
“I know people die.”

His voice cracked softly.
“I know it happens to everyone.”

Tears slowly rolled down his face again.
“But why you?”

The question destroyed the room emotionally.

Because honestly—
everyone had asked the same thing silently inside their hearts.

Why her?
Why the person who loved everyone the most?
Why the woman who held the family together so gently?
Why now?

Yuki slowly reached toward him weakly.

Paari immediately held her hand carefully.

Then softly—
she whispered,
“Don’t become angry at life because of me.”

Paari closed his eyes tightly.
“How?”

“Because life also gave us beautiful things.”

Silence.

Then quietly—
“It gave me you.”

That sentence completely shattered him again.

Paari lowered his head while crying silently beside the hospital bed.

And Yuki—
even now—

still comforted him first.

Meanwhile, downstairs near the cafeteria, **Akira** sat motionless holding untouched coffee.

The cup had already gone cold.

But he never drank it.

Venitha quietly sat beside him while **Lisa** slept peacefully inside the stroller nearby.

The baby looked so calm.

So safe.

And somehow—
that innocence made everything feel even crueler.

Then suddenly—

Akira quietly whispered something without looking up.
“I still remember the first time I saw her.”

Venitha slowly turned toward him.

Akira’s eyes looked distant now.

Lost somewhere inside old memories.
“She wore a blue dress.”

A faint broken smile reached his lips.
“And she yelled at me within ten minutes.”

Venitha laughed softly through tears.
“That sounds like Amma.”

Akira nodded quietly.
“She never spoke gently when she was angry.”

For the first time in hours—
his smile became real for one tiny second.

Then slowly disappeared again.
Because memories had started becoming painful now too.
Not comforting.
Painful.
Upstairs, **Yuki** slowly became sleepy again.

Her energy faded quickly after conversations now.

Paari carefully adjusted her blanket gently.
Then softly whispered—
“I’m here.”

Yuki looked at him weakly.
“I know.”

And somewhere beneath the pale hospital lights—
mother and son sat together silently while time continued moving forward without mercy.

Every second now felt louder.
Heavier.
Closer to something nobody was ready for yet.

The hospital slowly became busier as the morning continued.

Footsteps echoed through the hallways.

Doctors moved between rooms.

Phones rang softly in distant corridors.

Life continued normally for everyone else.

But for Akira’s family—

time had become trapped inside one room.

One bed.

One fragile heartbeat.

Around noon, the doctor returned again.

Akira immediately stood up the moment he saw him approaching.
“How is she?”

The doctor’s expression remained careful.

Gentle.
Too gentle.
“She’s stable for now.”

For now.

Everyone had started fearing those words.
Because now they understood what they truly meant.

Not safe.
Not healed.
Only temporary.

The doctor quietly explained a few things afterward.
The illness was progressing faster than expected.

Stress and physical weakness were worsening the condition.
“She needs peace,” he said softly.

“Emotionally and physically.”

Akira nodded silently.

But inside—
he felt helpless again.
Because how could any of them feel peaceful while slowly losing her?

Inside the room, **Yuki** had fallen asleep once more.

The medicines made her drowsy now.
Akira slowly walked back inside and sat beside her carefully.

The moment his fingers touched hers—
even in sleep—
she held his hand back weakly.

And somehow—
that nearly destroyed him again.

Because even unconscious—
her heart still searched for him first.

Paari quietly stepped outside afterward to give them space.

But the moment the door closed behind him—
his composure finally broke completely again.

He leaned against the hospital wall and covered his face with both hands.

His breathing became uneven.

Heavy.

Broken.

Venitha immediately walked toward him.

Without speaking—
Venitha simply hugged **Paari** tightly.

And for several seconds—
Paari cried against her shoulder silently like a child who no longer knew how to stay strong.
“I can’t accept this,” he whispered painfully.

Venitha closed her eyes tightly too.
“I know.”

“She was fine...”

His voice cracked harder.
“She was laughing with us.”

“That’s what hurts the most.”

Paari lowered his head again.
“I thought parents stayed forever.”

That sentence shattered Venitha completely.

Because somewhere deep inside—
every child believes that.

No matter how old they become.

Inside the room, **Akira** slowly brushed **Yuki’s** hair away from her forehead carefully.

The hospital light made her look pale.

Too pale.

And honestly—

he hated seeing her here.

Yuki slowly opened her eyes again after a few moments.

The first thing she noticed—

was the sadness inside his face.

So softly—

she whispered,
“You’re thinking too loudly again.”

Akira laughed weakly through exhaustion.
“You can hear thoughts now?”

“I married you.”

A faint smile appeared on her lips.
“I know your silence too.”

And somehow—

that sentence carried thirty-four years of love inside it.

Akira lowered his eyes quietly.

Then finally—
Akira whispered the fear that had been destroying him for days.
 “I’m scared the house will feel empty.”

Yuki’s expression softened instantly.
 “The house won’t become empty.”

“Yes it will.”

“No.”

She slowly touched his hand weakly.
 “Because I lived there.”

Silence.

Then softly—
 “My laughter will stay.”

“The balcony coffees will stay.”

“The memories will stay.”

Tears slowly escaped Akira’s eyes again.
 “But you won’t.”

The room became silent after that.

Painfully silent.

Because there was no comforting answer to give anymore.

Only truth.

Yuki slowly looked toward the hospital window where sunlight barely pushed through grey clouds outside.

Then quietly—
 she whispered,
 “I wanted to grow old with you properly.”

Akira immediately held her hand tighter.
 “We already did.”

Yuki smiled faintly through tears.
 “No...”

A pause.
 “I wanted more.”

That sentence completely shattered him again.

Because ***he wanted more too.***

More mornings.
 More road trips.
 More balcony nights.
 More arguments over coffee.
 More ordinary life.

But time—
time had become cruel.

Suddenly, **Lisa’s** tiny crying sound echoed softly from outside the room.

Both of them immediately looked toward the door.

A few seconds later, Venitha entered carrying the baby carefully.

“She woke up.”

Yuki’s tired eyes immediately softened seeing her granddaughter.

“Come here...”

Venitha gently placed Lisa beside her carefully.

The baby blinked curiously before grabbing Yuki’s finger again.

And instantly—

Yuki smiled.

A real smile.

Soft.

Warm.

Alive.

Akira quietly watched them together.

And suddenly—

he realized something terrifying.

This was what made losing her impossible.

Not grand moments.

Not dramatic memories.

These tiny ordinary scenes.

The way she smiled at Lisa.

The way she touched people gently.

The way she made love feel safe.

How could a world continue normally after losing someone like that?

Then softly—

Yuki looked toward Lisa and whispered,

“You have to remember them for me.”

Venitha’s eyes immediately filled again.

Akira turned away briefly because he could no longer control his tears.

And somewhere inside that quiet hospital room—

everyone silently realized the same painful truth.

They were no longer fighting the illness anymore.

Now—

they were simply trying to hold onto Yuki for as long as life allowed.

Evening slowly returned outside the hospital.

Grey clouds covered the sky once again while fading sunlight disappeared behind the hills of Dindigul.

Inside the room—

time continued moving differently.

Slower.

Heavier.

Every minute felt precious enough to fear losing.

Yuki had become quieter throughout the afternoon.

Not because she wanted silence.

Because speaking itself exhausted her now.

Still—

every time someone entered the room—

she smiled first.

Always first.

As if she still wanted everyone else to feel comfortable around her pain.

Around 6:00 PM, Paari entered carrying fresh coffee for Akira.

“You didn’t eat properly again.”

Akira accepted the cup quietly.

But even now—

his hands trembled slightly while holding it.

Paari noticed immediately.

And suddenly—

something painful hit him hard.

His father looked fragile too now.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

Like grief had already begun draining life out of him slowly.

For several seconds—

father and son simply sat beside Yuki together in silence.

Then softly—

Paari whispered,

“Appa...”

Akira looked up weakly.

“What if...”

His voice broke before finishing.

“What if she gets better?”

Silence filled the room instantly.

Because all of them still secretly held onto that impossible hope.

Even now.

Even after everything.

Akira slowly lowered his eyes.

Then quietly answered—
“If miracles exist...”

His fingers tightened around Yuki’s hand.
“I’ve already begged for one.”

That sentence crushed the remaining hope inside Paari’s chest.
Not because it sounded hopeless.
Because it sounded ***exhausted.***

Yuki slowly opened her eyes hearing their voices.

The moment she saw both of them sitting together—

her expression softened.
“My favorite people look miserable.”

Paari laughed weakly through tears.
“Whose fault is that?”

“Life’s.”

Even now—
she answered honestly.

And somehow—
that honesty hurt more than lies ever could.

Then softly—
Yuki looked toward Akira.
“Can we go home tomorrow?”

The question froze the room.

Akira immediately leaned closer.
“You want to go home?”

Yuki nodded weakly.
“I don’t want hospital walls anymore.”

Silence.

Then quietly—
“I want my balcony.”

Tears instantly filled Akira’s eyes again.
Because he understood exactly what she meant.

She didn’t want machines.

Or white lights.
Or fear-filled hallways.

She wanted home.

The place where love lived naturally.

Later that evening, the doctor returned once more.

After checking **Yuki** carefully, he finally spoke softly near the doorway with **Akira** and **Paari**.
“We can discharge her tomorrow.”

Both of them looked surprised.

The doctor continued gently.
“There’s nothing more the hospital can do now except manage pain.”

Silence.
Heavy silence.

Then softly—
“She’ll be more peaceful at home.”

That sentence felt like a quiet goodbye.
And everyone understood it.

That night, the hospital room became strangely calm.
The storm outside had finally stopped completely.

Only cold wind touched the windows softly while distant city lights shimmered beyond the darkness.

Venitha sat near the couch holding sleeping Lisa carefully.
Paari rested silently near the window.

And Akira—
Akira still sat beside Yuki without moving away even once.

At some point, Yuki slowly reached toward him weakly.
“Come closer.”

He immediately leaned near her.

Then softly—

she whispered,
“I’m tired.”

The words nearly stopped his heart.
“Tired how?”

Yuki looked at him quietly.

Not answering immediately.

And somehow—
that silence terrified him more than anything else.

Finally, she smiled faintly.
“Tired of fighting.”

Akira instantly grabbed her hand tighter.
“No.”

His voice cracked badly.
“You don’t stop.”

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled again.
“I’m trying...”

And hearing her sound this exhausted—
finally broke something permanent inside him.

Akira lowered his forehead gently against her hand while tears fell silently onto the hospital blanket.
“I would give my life for yours if I could.”

The room became painfully still.

Even **Paari** turned away immediately because hearing those words hurt too much.

Yuki slowly touched **Akira's** hair weakly.

And softly whispered—

“I know.”

That was the cruelest part.

She knew he meant it completely.

A little later, after everyone else slowly fell asleep from exhaustion—

only Akira remained awake again.

The hospital room looked dim beneath pale yellow light while machines quietly continued measuring fragile time beside the bed.

Yuki slept peacefully now.

At least physically.

Akira quietly watched her for a long moment.

Then slowly—

he stood up and walked toward the window alone.

The city outside looked distant tonight.

Cold.

Unreachable.

And for the first time—

Akira finally admitted something terrifying to himself.

He had started counting moments now.

Not days.

Not hours.

Moments.

Because deep inside his heart—

he already felt it.

The goodbye they feared...

was slowly getting closer.

Chapter 12 — The Home She Wanted

Morning arrived quietly once again.

But this morning felt different.

Not hopeful.

Not peaceful.

Just... fragile.

The kind of morning where everyone moved carefully, as if louder sounds might somehow disturb the little time they still had left.

Soft sunlight entered through the hospital curtains while nurses quietly moved through the hallway outside.

Inside the room—

Yuki remained asleep peacefully for the first time in hours.

Akira sat beside her exactly the same way he had all night.

One hand still holding hers.

Still refusing distance.

At some point during the night—

his head had leaned against the side of the bed from exhaustion.

But even in sleep—

his ***fingers never let go of her hand.***

Around **7:30 AM**, Yuki slowly opened her eyes.

The first thing she saw—

was Akira sleeping beside her like a man who had finally collapsed after carrying too much pain alone.

For several seconds—

she simply watched him quietly.

Then slowly—

her eyes filled with tears again.

Because even now...

he stayed beside her like losing sight of her for even one second terrified him.

Yuki gently brushed her fingers through his hair weakly.

“Akira...”

He woke up immediately.

Not slowly.

Immediately.

Fear still lived inside him now.

The moment he saw her awake—

he breathed again.

“You okay?”

Yuki smiled faintly.

“You ask that every five minutes.”

“I’ll ask forever.”

The sentence escaped naturally.

And honestly—

that hurt both of them.

Because forever no longer felt guaranteed anymore.

A little later, the doctor completed the discharge formalities quietly.

Medicines.

Instructions.

Pain management.

Emergency numbers.

Words nobody truly wanted to hear.

Akira listened carefully to every detail without missing a single sentence.

Because now—

protecting Yuki had become the only thing his heart knew how to do.

Meanwhile, **Paari** quietly packed their things from the room while **Venitha** dressed Lisa warmly against the cold morning weather outside.

The atmosphere remained soft.

Heavy.

Nobody joked much anymore.

Even silence sounded emotional now.

Before leaving, **Yuki** slowly looked around the hospital room one last time.

The white walls.

The machines.

The pale lights.

And honestly—

she ***looked relieved to leave it behind.***

Akira noticed immediately.

“You happy?”

Yuki nodded weakly.

“I want home.”

That one word carried so much longing inside it.

Home.

The balcony.

The coffee smell.

The laughter downstairs.

The warmth of ordinary life.

The place where she was loved naturally.

Akira carefully lifted her into his arms despite her quiet protests.

“I can still walk.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you carrying me?”

Akira looked directly into her eyes.

“Because I want to.”

Silence.

Then softly—

Yuki rested her head against his chest without arguing anymore.

And honestly—

Paari had to look away briefly after seeing them.

Because even after thirty-four years...

their love still looked painfully beautiful.

Outside the hospital, cold wind moved softly beneath cloudy skies.

The storm had finally passed during the night.

Only wet roads remained behind.

Akira carefully helped Yuki into the car before covering her properly with a blanket.

Then quietly—

he closed the door gently.

As if even the smallest harsh movement toward her now felt wrong.

The drive home remained silent at first.

Soft music played faintly while morning sunlight slowly touched the hills outside Dindigul again.

Yuki rested against the seat peacefully while watching the world pass outside the window.

And for the first time in days—

her expression looked calmer.

Not because the fear disappeared.

But because ***she was going home.***

At one point during the drive—

Yuki suddenly whispered softly,

“Can we stop for tea?”

Paari immediately looked shocked from the backseat.

“Now?”

“Yes.”

“You just got discharged from the hospital.”

“I survived. That deserves tea.”

Even Akira laughed softly hearing that.

And honestly—

that tiny normal conversation felt precious.

So precious.

A few minutes later, the BMW stopped near the same roadside tea shop they had visited during one of their midnight drives.

The old tea master immediately recognized them.

“Sir!”

Akira smiled faintly.

“Four teas.”

The old man nodded warmly before preparing tea beneath the soft morning mist.

The atmosphere there felt exactly the same.

Cold air.

Fog.

The smell of ginger tea.

Quiet roads stretching endlessly beneath cloudy skies.

And somehow—

being there again made **Akira’s** chest ache deeply.

Because this place carried memories now.

Beautiful memories.

Painful memories.

Yuki slowly held the warm tea cup between both hands while looking toward the empty road.

Then softly—

she smiled.

“This feels nice.”

Akira quietly watched her.

Memorizing again.

Always memorizing now.

Then suddenly—

Yuki looked toward him.

“What?”

Akira smiled weakly through tired eyes.

“Nothing.”

“That’s a lie.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

“I’m trying to remember this moment forever.”

Yuki’s eyes immediately softened again.

And beneath the cold morning fog—

their fingers slowly intertwined once more.

As if both hearts already understood something painful.

Some moments become unforgettable...

because deep inside—

we already know they cannot last forever.

When the BMW finally entered the gate—

the house looked exactly the same.

Warm lights near the entrance.

Wind moving softly through the trees.

The balcony waiting silently above.

But somehow—
everything felt more emotional now.

Because this time—
they were bringing **Yuki** home not as someone recovering...

but as someone everyone was afraid to lose.

Akira carefully stepped out first before opening Yuki’s door slowly.

The cold breeze touched her face immediately.

And for one brief second—
she closed her eyes.

Breathing it in.

Home.

Not hospitals.
Not medicine smell.
Not white walls.

Home.

When she opened her eyes again—

she smiled softly.
“I missed this air.”

Akira’s chest tightened instantly hearing that.

Because suddenly—
even ordinary things sounded like farewell.

Before Yuki could stand properly—

Akira lifted her into his arms again.
“Akira...”

“You’re tired.”

“You’ll spoil me.”

“You’ve been spoiling me for thirty-four years.”

A faint laugh escaped her lips.

And honestly—
everyone nearby silently broke a little watching them.

Because *love like this felt beautiful enough to hurt.*

The moment they entered the house—
Lisa immediately became excited hearing voices.

Tiny sounds escaped her while **Venitha** carried her toward Yuki carefully.

The baby stretched both hands forward instantly.

Yuki’s tired face softened immediately.
“There’s my princess...”

Akira carefully helped her sit near the sofa before placing Lisa gently into her lap.

And just like that—

the house felt alive again.

Not fully.

But enough.

Paari quietly stood nearby watching everything.

And suddenly—

his chest became unbearably heavy.

Because the scene looked so normal.

So peaceful.

But now he understood how fragile normal life truly was.

One illness.

One sentence from a doctor.

And suddenly every ordinary moment became precious enough to fear losing.

That evening, nobody left Yuki alone for even a second.

Venitha prepared soft food carefully.

Paari adjusted pillows constantly.

Akira brought water before anyone even asked.

And through all of it—

Yuki kept smiling at everyone like she was the one comforting them.

At one point, she softly sighed while looking around.

“You all are treating me like glass.”

Paari immediately answered,

“You’re expensive.”

Even Akira laughed quietly hearing that.

And for one tiny second—

the atmosphere felt warm again.

Later that evening, rain began falling lightly outside once more.

Soft rain.

Gentle rain.

The kind that made the house feel quieter.

Safer.

The family gathered together in the living room while yellow lights glowed warmly around them.

Lisa rested asleep against Venitha’s shoulder.

Paari sat on the floor near the sofa absentmindedly scrolling through old family photos on his phone.

And Akira—

Akira simply sat beside Yuki holding her hand silently.

As if even now—

distance still terrified him.

Then suddenly—
Paari stopped scrolling.

His expression changed slightly.
“What happened?” **Venitha** asked softly.

Without answering immediately—
Paari slowly turned the phone toward everyone.

It was the photo they took just before leaving for the hospital weeks ago.
The terrace lights.
The smiles.

Lisa in **Akira’s** arms.
Yuki laughing naturally beside him.

The picture looked so alive.

So complete.

The room quietly fell silent.

Yuki slowly smiled seeing it.
“That’s a beautiful photo.”

Akira looked at it for several seconds without speaking.

Then quietly whispered—
“You looked happy.”

Yuki turned toward him slowly.
“I was.”

Silence filled the room afterward.

Because somehow—
that answer hurt everyone deeply.

She wasn’t pretending.

Even while dying—
she still truly felt grateful for her life.

The rain outside became heavier as night slowly deepened.
At some point, Venitha carried sleeping Lisa upstairs while Paari quietly cleaned the empty coffee cups from the table.

Eventually—
only Akira and Yuki remained awake again.
Like always.

The balcony door remained slightly open while cold wind moved softly through the curtains.

Yuki rested against his shoulder beneath a blanket.
Then quietly—
she whispered,
“Can we sit outside for a little while?”

Akira immediately frowned slightly.
“It’s cold.”

“Please.”

And honestly—

he would never refuse her now.
Never.

A few minutes later, they sat together on the balcony once again.

The hills beyond the darkness were barely visible beneath mist and rain.

Only distant lights shimmered faintly far away.

For a while—

neither of them spoke.

Only the sound of rain existed between them.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,

“I’m happy I came home.”

Akira slowly closed his eyes briefly.

Because hearing those words made his heart ache unbearably.

Not because they were sad.

Because ***they sounded final.***

Yuki slowly rested her head against his shoulder more comfortably.

Then quietly—

“Do you remember the first coffee we drank here?”

Akira smiled faintly.

“You complained it was bitter.”

“It WAS bitter.”

“You still drank two cups.”

“Because you made it.”

That small answer completely melted him again.

Because even now—

she still found ways to love him gently.

The rain continued falling softly around the balcony while cold wind touched their faces.

And somewhere inside that quiet night—

Akira silently prayed again.

Not for miracles anymore.

Not for impossible cures.

Just for more time.

One more morning.

One more laugh.

One more ordinary night beside her.

Because now—

ordinary moments had become the most precious things in the world.

The rain continued through the night.

Soft at first.

Then steady.

Cold wind moved through the balcony while distant thunder echoed somewhere far beyond the hills.

And beneath the dim yellow balcony light—
Akira and **Yuki** remained together in silence.

Not uncomfortable silence.

The kind built from years of love.
The kind where even breathing beside each other felt meaningful.

Yuki slowly wrapped the blanket tighter around herself while leaning against Akira’s shoulder.

For a long moment—
she simply listened to the rain.

Then softly—
she whispered,
“I used to think life had to be big to become meaningful.”

Akira looked toward her quietly.
“What changed?”

Yuki smiled faintly.
“You.”

Silence.

Then softly—
“You made ordinary things feel beautiful.”

The rain touched the balcony railing gently while Akira lowered his eyes.

Because honestly—
he had never tried to give her extraordinary things.

Only love.
Only comfort.
Only home.

And somehow—

that became enough.

Yuki slowly looked toward the dark hills ahead.
“Do you know my favorite memory?”

Akira smiled weakly.
“You have too many.”

“No.”

She shook her head softly.
“One.”

Akira waited quietly.

Yuki’s eyes became distant.
“The night electricity went out after our marriage.”

A faint laugh escaped her lips.
“You tried cooking with candles.”

Akira immediately groaned.

“That disaster again?”

“You burned the pan.”

“You distracted me.”

“You almost burned the kitchen.”

Akira finally laughed softly too.

And hearing his laugh—

Yuki’s heart softened painfully.

Because even now—

after all the fear and pain—

they still found each other inside small memories.

Then slowly—

Yuki’s smile faded slightly.

“Akira...”

The way she said his name immediately changed something inside him.

He turned fully toward her.

“What happened?”

Yuki hesitated.

Then quietly—

“I’m scared to sleep.”

Silence crushed the balcony.

Because he understood instantly.

She wasn’t talking about nightmares.

She was afraid of not waking up again.

Akira immediately held her hand tighter.

“You’ll wake up.”

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled with tears.

“You don’t know that.”

Neither of them spoke after that.

Because there was nothing left to argue against anymore.

Only fear.

Only truth.

Akira gently pulled her closer against him.

Then softly whispered—

“If you’re scared...”

His voice cracked slightly.

“Then stay awake with me.”

Yuki looked up at him.

And for one painful moment—

both hearts broke quietly together again.

Hours passed slowly afterward.

The rain never stopped.

The wind grew colder.

But neither of them moved from the balcony.

Because tonight—

the world felt fragile.

And somehow—

sleep felt dangerous.

Around **2:00 AM, Yuki** suddenly became tired again.

Much more tired.

Her breathing slowed slightly while exhaustion rested heavily across her face.

Akira noticed immediately.

“Let’s go inside.”

Yuki nodded weakly this time.

No argument.

No teasing.

Only exhaustion.

And honestly—

that terrified him more than anything else.

Inside the bedroom, warm dim light filled the room softly while rain touched the windows endlessly outside.

Akira carefully helped Yuki sit on the bed before covering her gently with the blanket.

Then quietly—

he sat beside her again.

Still close.

Still refusing distance.

Yuki slowly looked at him.

“You really won’t leave me alone for even one second, huh?”

Akira answered instantly.

“No.”

A tiny smile appeared on her tired face.

Then softly—

“Good.”

That one word nearly destroyed him.

Because she sounded relieved.

Like even she feared separation now.

A few minutes later, Yuki slowly rested against his chest while he held her carefully.

The room became silent except for rain and breathing.

Then suddenly—

she whispered something so softly he almost missed it.

“If I forget things later...”

Akira’s entire body froze.

Yuki closed her eyes weakly.

“Will you remember for me?”

The tears returned instantly.

Because suddenly—

he realized she was afraid of disappearing piece by piece before actually leaving.

Akira gently kissed her forehead.

“I’ll remember everything.”

His voice trembled badly.

“Every smile.”

“Every fight.”

“Every coffee.”

“Every road trip.”

“Every time you laughed at me.”

A faint smile touched Yuki’s lips again.

Akira held her tighter.

“I’ll remember enough for both of us.”

And finally—

for the first time in many nights—

Yuki slowly fell asleep peacefully against him.

But Akira remained awake.

Still listening to her breathing.

Still counting every heartbeat silently.

Because somewhere deep inside his soul—

he already knew something terrifying.

The time they had left together...

was becoming painfully small now.

Chapter 13 — The Beginning of Goodbye

Akira never slept that night.
Not truly.

He remained sitting against the headboard while Yuki slept peacefully on his chest beneath the dim yellow light.

Rain continued touching the windows softly outside while cold wind moved through the balcony curtains.

And through all of it—
he listened only to one thing.

Her breathing.

Slow.
Soft.
Fragile.
Every few seconds—
his eyes lowered toward her automatically.

Checking.

Making sure she was still there.
Still warm.
Still breathing.
Still his.

Around **5:00 AM**—
the rain finally stopped.

The silence afterward felt strangely loud.

Yuki shifted slightly against him before slowly opening her eyes.
For one brief moment—
she looked confused.

Then she realized where she was.
Inside his arms.
At home.
Beside him.

And softly—

she smiled.
“You stayed awake again.”

Akira looked down at her quietly.
“You noticed?”

“You breathe differently when you’re pretending to sleep.”

Even now—
even exhausted—
she still knew him too well.
Yuki slowly touched his face gently.

Her fingers felt colder this morning.

Akira noticed immediately.
And fear quietly returned to his chest again.
“You okay?”

Yuki nodded weakly.
“Just tired.”

But this time—

the tiredness looked deeper.

Not normal exhaustion.

The kind that comes when the body itself begins giving up slowly.

Akira immediately looked away for one second.

Because panic had already started rising inside him again.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,

“Take me to the balcony.”

Akira looked back at her immediately.

“It’s still cold outside.”

“Please.”

The way she said it—

gentle,

small,

almost childlike—

made refusing impossible.

A few minutes later, Akira carefully carried her toward the balcony wrapped inside a thick blanket.

The sky above the hills looked pale blue now while soft morning mist rested across the trees surrounding the house.

Everything felt unbelievably quiet.

Peaceful almost.

Yuki slowly leaned against him while watching dawn arrive.

Then quietly—

she smiled.

“I love mornings.”

Akira closed his eyes briefly hearing that.

Because suddenly—

even simple sentences sounded painfully emotional.

Downstairs, the house still slept silently.

No coffee smell yet.

No conversations.

No footsteps.

Only the distant sound of birds slowly returning after the stormy night.

Yuki listened carefully for a moment.

Then softly whispered—

“This house sounds happy.”

Akira’s chest tightened instantly.

Because she spoke about the house like someone preparing to leave it behind.

After a while—
Yuki suddenly asked quietly,
“Will you do something for me today?”

Akira immediately nodded.
“Anything.”

“Can we eat together downstairs?”

He frowned slightly.
“We always do.”

“No...”

She smiled faintly.
“I mean properly.”

Silence.

Then softly—
“All of us.”

And suddenly—

Akira understood.

She wanted one more normal family day.
One more ordinary memory.
One more moment where nobody cried.

By **8:00 AM**, the house slowly woke up.

Paari entered the kitchen half asleep before freezing completely after seeing **Akira** cooking breakfast himself.
“You’re cooking?”

Akira calmly flipped dosa without looking up.
“Yes.”

Paari stared in horror.
“Should I call emergency services first?”

Even Yuki laughed softly from the dining chair nearby.

And honestly—
hearing that laugh first thing in the morning made the entire house feel lighter again.

Soon, everyone gathered around the dining table together.

Warm food.
Soft sunlight.
Coffee smell.

Lisa making random sounds from her baby chair.

For a brief moment—
everything looked painfully normal again.

Yuki quietly looked around at all of them one by one.

Akira arguing with Paari over cooking.

Venitha fixing Lisa’s tiny socks carefully.

Morning light filling the room warmly.

And suddenly—
her eyes slowly became emotional again.

Because this...
this was all she ever truly wanted.

Not wealth.
Not grand dreams.

Just this.
Family.
Love.
Home.

Then suddenly—

Lisa began throwing tiny pieces of idli onto the floor proudly.

Paari looked personally attacked.
“She’s wasting food already.”

“She’s a baby,” **Venitha** laughed.

“She has criminal energy.”

Even **Akira** laughed quietly.

And for one small beautiful moment—
everyone forgot fear again.

But while smiling—
Yuki suddenly became dizzy.

The room tilted slightly around her.

Akira noticed immediately.
“Yuki?”

Her hand gripped the edge of the table weakly.

Paari stood up instantly.
“Amma?”

Yuki forced a smile again.
“I’m okay.”

But her voice sounded distant.

Too distant.

And suddenly—
the warmth inside the dining room cracked again beneath silent fear.

Akira immediately moved beside her.

And deep inside his chest—
terror returned stronger than ever.

Because now—
every small moment felt dangerous.

The dining room became silent instantly.

Only the small clinking sound of Lisa hitting her spoon against the baby chair continued softly through the tension.

Akira carefully held **Yuki’s** shoulders while fear exploded inside his chest again.

“Yuki... look at me.”

Yuki slowly blinked.

The dizziness passed after a few seconds.

But the weakness remained.

And honestly—

that scared everyone more.

Because now the illness no longer arrived quietly.

It interrupted moments openly.

Even happiness.

“I’m fine,” Yuki whispered softly again.

But this time—

nobody believed it.

Paari immediately moved closer.

“We’re calling the doctor.”

“No.”

Yuki slowly shook her head weakly.

“I just stood up too fast.”

Akira’s voice became firmer than usual.

“You almost fainted.”

Silence.

Then softly—

“I’m not risking anything anymore.”

That sentence carried so much fear inside it that the room became emotional again immediately.

Because everyone heard it.

The panic.

The helplessness.

The desperation hidden beneath his calm voice.

Venitha quietly carried Lisa away from the tense atmosphere while Akira slowly helped Yuki toward the sofa.

The morning sunlight still filled the house warmly.

Coffee still smelled fresh.

Everything outside the moment still looked ordinary.

But inside the family—

fear had already returned completely.

Yuki rested against the cushions while Akira knelt beside her carefully.

His fingers gently checked her forehead instinctively.

Then her hands.

Then her breathing.

Yuki quietly watched him.

And suddenly—

her chest hurt emotionally again.

Because the man beside her no longer looked peaceful even for one second now.

Love had turned into constant fear inside him.

Then softly—

she touched his face.

“Hey...”

Akira looked up immediately.

“I’m here.”

Yuki smiled faintly.

“You always say that.”

“Because I always will.”

The tears instantly reached her eyes again.

Because somewhere deep inside—

she knew.

Even after she was gone...

his heart would still be sitting beside her.

Paari stood near the balcony silently watching them.

Then suddenly—

he walked outside alone.

Cold morning wind touched his face while clouds slowly moved above the hills.

He gripped the balcony railing tightly.

Trying to breathe properly.

Trying not to break again.

But honestly—

he was tired too.

Tired of fear.

Tired of pretending normal life still existed.

Tired of watching his mother become weaker day by day while being unable to do anything.

A few seconds later—

Akira quietly stepped beside him.

Neither spoke immediately.

Father and son simply stood there listening to the wind together.

Then softly—

Paari whispered,

“I hate feeling useless.”

Akira lowered his eyes slowly.

“I know.”

“I keep thinking maybe we missed something.”

“We didn’t.”

“What if another doctor—”

“Paari.”

Akira’s voice cracked softly.

“I searched everywhere.”

Silence.

Then quietly—

“Sometimes love still loses.”

The sentence shattered whatever strength remained inside Paari.

Because hearing his father admit that...

made everything feel terrifyingly real again.

Inside the living room, **Yuki** quietly watched them both through the balcony door.

And honestly—

that hurt her more than her illness.

Watching the people she loved slowly drown in pain because of her.

She never wanted that.

Never.

A little later, Venitha sat beside her carefully while Lisa rested asleep against her shoulder again.

For several moments—

neither woman spoke.

Then softly—

Venitha whispered,

“I’m scared too.”

Yuki slowly looked toward her.

Venitha’s eyes immediately filled with tears.

“I keep pretending I’m strong because of Paari...”

Her voice trembled badly.

“But every time I look at you...”

She broke completely.

Yuki immediately held her hand weakly.

“Hey...”

Venitha lowered her head while crying silently.

“You’re the reason this house feels warm.”

That sentence destroyed Yuki quietly.

Because she realized something painful.

They weren't only afraid of losing her.

They were afraid of losing the feeling of home itself.

Outside, clouds slowly darkened again.

Rainy season refused to leave the hills peacefully this year.

And somewhere inside that heavy grey sky—

Akira silently prayed again.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Just one exhausted desperate prayer repeating inside his chest.

Please.

Not yet.

That evening, **Yuki** became slightly better after resting.

Enough to smile again.

Enough to sit near the balcony with everyone during sunset.

And because of that—

the family tried once more to act normal.

Paari complained about office calls.

Venitha argued with him over useless things.

Lisa laughed randomly at absolutely nothing.

And Akira—

Akira quietly sat beside Yuki listening to her laugh softly again while evening light touched her face.

Trying to hold onto the moment.

Trying to believe it would last longer.

But somewhere deep inside him—

fear never left anymore.

Because now he understood something cruel.

The happiest moments had become the scariest ones.

Because every beautiful second carried one terrifying thought beneath it.

What if this is the last time?

Evening slowly covered the hills of Dindigul once again.

Clouds drifted quietly across the sky while orange sunlight spread softly through the balcony.

The rain had stopped for now.

Only cold wind remained.

And somehow—

the silence inside the house felt gentler tonight.

Not because fear disappeared.

But because everyone had become tired of crying.

Yuki rested comfortably near the balcony wrapped inside a warm shawl while Lisa sat carefully in her lap making tiny sounds at the sunset.

Akira sat beside her so closely their shoulders never separated.

Not even slightly.

As if distance itself had become unbearable now.

Paari and Venitha quietly arranged tea and snacks near the small balcony table while soft old songs played from the speaker nearby.

And for a few moments—

life looked almost peaceful again.

Almost normal.

Lisa suddenly grabbed **Yuki’s** chain and laughed proudly.

“Ayyo,” **Venitha** sighed dramatically.

“She attacks jewelry now.”

“She inherited Appa’s criminal behavior,” **Paari** replied immediately.

“I was a peaceful child.”

Akira looked offended.

“You once broke my television.”

“That was scientific curiosity.”

Even Yuki laughed softly hearing that.

And honestly—

everyone inside the balcony relaxed hearing her laugh again.

Because now—

that sound felt more precious than anything else.

The evening sky slowly deepened into orange and gold.

The hills beyond the balcony looked beautiful beneath the fading light.

Yuki quietly stared at them for a long moment.

Then softly—

she whispered,

“I don’t want anyone to cry after I’m gone.”

Silence instantly swallowed the balcony.

Akira’s fingers tightened around his coffee cup painfully.

Paari immediately looked away.

Venitha lowered her eyes.

Even the wind somehow felt heavier after those words.

Akira slowly turned toward her.

“Don’t talk like that.”

Yuki smiled weakly.

“We can’t keep pretending forever.”

Her voice remained gentle.

Calm.

And somehow—

that calmness hurt more than fear.

Because she had accepted the truth more peacefully than any of them.

Then softly—

she looked toward Paari.

“You know what makes me happiest?”

Paari tried speaking normally.

“What?”

“You.”

His eyes immediately became wet again.

Yuki continued quietly—
 “The way you love your family.”

“The way you panic over small things.”

“The way you still become emotional like a child.”

A tiny smile appeared on her face.
 “You became a good man.”

Paari completely broke after hearing that.
 “Amma...”

His voice cracked violently.

Yuki smiled through her own tears now.
 “No matter what happens...”

She slowly pointed toward Lisa.
 “You make sure she grows up inside love.”

Paari immediately nodded while crying silently.

Because he couldn’t trust his voice anymore.

Then Yuki slowly turned toward Venitha.
 “You...”

Venitha instantly shook her head emotionally.
 “No...”

But Yuki gently held her hand weakly.
 “You entered this house and filled it with warmth.”

Tears rolled endlessly down Venitha’s face now.
 “You take care of everyone quietly.”

A pause.

“Especially my idiot son.”

Even through tears—
a tiny laugh escaped everyone.

Because somehow—
Yuki still found ways to lighten pain.

Finally—
 her eyes slowly moved toward Akira.

And suddenly—
the entire world inside the balcony became still.

Because everyone understood.

There were no words big enough for thirty-four years of love.

Yuki looked at him silently for several seconds.

Then softly whispered—
 “You loved me too much.”

Akira immediately broke.
 “No.”

His voice trembled badly.

“There’s no such thing.”

Tears escaped down Yuki’s cheeks again.

“I never felt alone with you.”

The balcony became painfully silent afterward.

Even the evening wind felt emotional now.

Akira slowly moved closer before gently holding both her hands inside his.

His eyes remained locked on hers.

Then quietly—

“You made my life worth living.”

The tears no longer stopped for anyone after that.

Because these no longer sounded like conversations.

They sounded like goodbye.

The sun slowly disappeared behind the hills.

Darkness quietly replaced the warm evening light.

And one by one—

small balcony lights turned on around the house.

Soft golden light surrounded them gently.

Yuki quietly leaned against Akira’s shoulder again while Lisa slowly fell asleep in her arms.

For a few long moments—

nobody spoke.

Nobody moved.

Everyone simply stayed there together beneath the night sky.

Trying desperately to hold onto the moment.

Because somewhere deep inside every heart on that balcony—

the same terrifying feeling had already begun growing stronger.

Time was running out.

Chapter 14 — The Night Before the Silence

The balcony remained quiet long after sunset disappeared.

Cold wind moved softly through the night while distant lights shimmered beneath the hills of Dindigul.
Nobody wanted to leave.

Because somewhere deep inside—
everyone felt it.

This night mattered.
More than usual.
More than they wanted to admit.

Lisa slept peacefully against **Yuki’s** chest while soft old melodies continued playing quietly from the speaker nearby.

The small balcony lights painted warm golden shadows across everyone’s faces.

And in the middle of that soft peaceful atmosphere—
fear silently sat beside all of them.

Akira gently adjusted the shawl around Yuki’s shoulders again.

The movement had become automatic now.

Protective.
Careful.
Almost sacred.

Yuki quietly watched him for a few seconds.

Then softly smiled.
“You still act like I’ll disappear if cold air touches me.”

Akira looked directly into her eyes.
“It might.”

The answer came too quickly.
Too honestly.

And instantly—
the balcony became silent again.

Because everyone heard the fear inside those two words.

Yuki slowly held his hand tighter.

Then softly whispered—
“I’m still here.”

But this time—
Akira couldn’t answer immediately.

Because now those words hurt too much.

Still here.
Not forever.

Paari suddenly stood up from his chair abruptly.
“I’m making tea.”

Venitha looked at him knowingly.
“You just want to cry privately.”

Paari froze for one second.

Then sighed dramatically.

“This house exposes me too much.”

Even Yuki laughed softly again hearing that.

And honestly—

the sound alone made everyone breathe easier for a moment.

A few minutes later, Paari returned carrying tea carefully for everyone.

The warm smell filled the cold balcony air beautifully.

Lisa stirred slightly in her sleep while Yuki gently patted her back automatically.

The movement looked so natural.

So maternal.

So full of quiet love.

And suddenly—

Akira’s chest hurt unbearably again.

Because he realized something terrifying.

One day—

this balcony would still exist.

The wind would still blow.

Tea would still smell the same.

But she wouldn’t be sitting there anymore.

Then softly—

Yuki looked toward the sky.

“Do you know what I’m grateful for?”

Nobody answered immediately.

So she continued quietly.

“That I got time.”

Silence.

“I got enough time to love all of you properly.”

Venitha instantly lowered her head while tears filled her eyes again.

Paari stared silently into his tea cup.

And Akira—

Akira simply looked at Yuki like his heart was breaking and healing at the same time.

Then suddenly—

Yuki softly laughed again.

“I sound like an old grandmother giving speeches.”

“You ARE a grandmother,” Paari replied weakly.

“Rude child.”

“A truthful child.”

Even now—

they still found ways to smile together.

And honestly—

that made everything even more painful.

Because love remained alive everywhere inside the house.

Later that night, after Lisa finally woke up crying for milk, **Venitha** carried her downstairs quietly.

Paari followed behind after a few minutes too.

Before leaving, he softly looked toward **Akira** and **Yuki** sitting together beneath the balcony light.

And suddenly—
his chest tightened painfully.

Because they looked exactly the same way they always had.

Close.
Comfortable.
Peaceful together.

Like two people who had built an entire world around each other.

And he realized something terrifying.

He had never once imagined one existing without the other.

Now only Akira and Yuki remained on the balcony once again.

Like always.

The wind had become colder now.

But neither of them moved inside.

Yuki slowly rested fully against him while he wrapped one arm protectively around her.

Then softly—
she whispered,
“If there’s another life...”

Akira immediately closed his eyes tightly.

Because he already knew this conversation.

Still—
he listened.

Yuki smiled faintly against his shoulder.
“I hope we find each other early.”

His breathing became uneven instantly.
“So we get more time.”

That sentence nearly destroyed him.

Because no amount of time would have ever felt enough.

Not for him.
Not with her.

Akira slowly kissed the top of her head gently.

Then quietly whispered—
“I would choose you every single time.”

Yuki closed her eyes peacefully hearing that.

And for a few moments—

they simply stayed like that together beneath the cold night sky.

Two people holding onto love while time quietly slipped through their fingers.

Around midnight, **Yuki** suddenly became very tired again.

Her breathing slowed slightly while exhaustion rested heavily across her face.

Akira immediately noticed.

“Let’s sleep.”

Yuki nodded weakly this time without arguing.

And somehow—

that frightened him deeply.

Because she no longer had strength even for playful protests.

Inside the bedroom, the warm dim light felt softer than usual tonight.

Rain clouds slowly gathered again beyond the windows while cold wind touched the curtains gently.

Akira carefully helped Yuki lie down before covering her properly with the blanket.

Then quietly—

he lay beside her while she immediately moved closer against his chest.

Almost instinctively.

Like home.

Yuki slowly looked up at him through tired eyes.

Then softly whispered—

“Don’t forget me.”

The sentence shattered him completely.

Akira immediately held her tighter.

“Impossible.”

Tears escaped both of them silently now.

Because somewhere deep inside—

both hearts already understood.

The goodbye they feared...

was no longer far away anymore.

The night grew quieter after that.

Even the wind outside seemed softer now.

As if the world itself had slowed down around the house.

Inside the bedroom, dim yellow light rested gently across the walls while rain clouds gathered silently beyond the balcony.

Akira still held Yuki close against his chest beneath the blanket.

Neither of them slept.

Not really.

Because sleep no longer felt peaceful.

Now—

every closed eye carried fear.

For a long time—

they simply listened to each other breathe.

The silence between them wasn’t empty.

It carried thirty-four years of memories.

Road trips.

Fights.

Coffee.

Rainy evenings.

Late-night conversations.

A lifetime quietly resting between heartbeats.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,
“Are you cold?”

Akira looked down at her immediately.
“No.”

“You’re lying again.”

A faint tired smile reached his lips.
“You stole the blanket.”

“That sounds like your problem.”

Even now—
even exhausted—
she still found ways to tease him gently.

And honestly—
that nearly broke him more than tears did.

Because she still sounded like herself.

Still sounded like home.

Akira slowly brushed his fingers through her hair.

The movement felt automatic now.

Like breathing.

Then quietly—
he whispered,
“You know what scares me the most?”

Yuki looked at him softly.
“What?”

“That one day...”

His voice cracked slightly.
“I’ll wake up and instinctively search for you beside me.”

Silence.

Then softly—
“And you won’t be there.”

The room became unbearably quiet after that.

Because there was no comfort for fears like this anymore.
Only pain.
Only truth.

Yuki slowly touched his face weakly.

Then whispered—
“You’ll still talk to me.”

Akira immediately shook his head.

“No.”

“Yes.”

A tiny smile appeared on her lips.

“You talk too much anyway.”

A weak laugh escaped him through tears.

“You married me willingly.”

“I made poor decisions.”

And somehow—

they both laughed softly again.

Small.

Fragile.

But real.

Outside, thunder rolled quietly somewhere beyond the hills.

The storm had not arrived yet.

But the sky already carried its weight.

Just like the house.

Everything felt like it was waiting for something painful.

After a while, Yuki slowly became more serious again.

“Akira...”

“Hm?”

“If things become difficult later...”

He immediately frowned.

“What things?”

Yuki lowered her eyes weakly.

“If I forget names...”

“If I stop recognizing things...”

The fear inside her voice quietly shattered him.

Because now—

she wasn’t only afraid of dying.

She was afraid of disappearing before death itself arrived.

Akira immediately held her face gently between both hands.

“You look at me.”

His voice trembled badly.

“You hear me?”

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled again.

“I’m here.”

A pause.

“And even if you forget everything else...”

He leaned his forehead against hers.

“I’ll remind you who you are every single day.”

The tears finally escaped her eyes completely after that.

Because no fear hurts more than the fear of losing yourself.

Meanwhile downstairs, **Paari** quietly sat alone near the living room after **Venitha** and Lisa had fallen asleep.

The entire house felt different tonight.

Too silent.

Too emotional.

He slowly looked toward the staircase leading upstairs.

And suddenly—

his chest tightened painfully.

Because deep inside—

he already felt it too.

Something was changing.

Too fast.

A few minutes later, **Akira** quietly came downstairs to bring water.

The moment Paari saw his face—

he stood up immediately.

“You okay?”

Akira froze slightly.

Then smiled faintly.

“That question follows me everywhere now.”

Paari’s eyes became emotional instantly.

Because his father looked exhausted beyond words tonight.

Not physically.

Spiritually.

Like his heart had been carrying too much grief for too long.

For several seconds—

both men stood silently inside the dim living room.

Then suddenly—

Paari softly whispered,

“I’m not ready.”

Akira closed his eyes briefly.

Neither am I.

But the words never came out loud.

Instead—

he quietly placed one hand on Paari’s shoulder.

And for the first time—

both of them silently understood something terrifying together.

Love does not prepare people for goodbye.

It only makes goodbye hurt more.

Upstairs, **Yuki** remained awake alone for a few minutes.

Cold wind touched the curtains softly while distant thunder echoed again outside.

She slowly looked around the bedroom.

The bookshelf.

The balcony door.

The warm yellow light.

Their room.

And suddenly—

her eyes became emotional again.

Because every ordinary object now looked precious.

Like something she was trying to memorize before losing sight of it forever.

When **Akira** finally returned, Yuki immediately relaxed again seeing him.

As if her heart itself calmed only after confirming he was still near.

Akira quietly lay beside her once more.

And without speaking—

Yuki moved closer into his arms again.

The same place she had rested for decades.

The same heartbeat she trusted more than anything else in the world.

Outside—

the first drops of rain slowly began falling again across the dark hills of Dindigul.

And somewhere deep inside both their hearts—

fear quietly waited for morning.

Chapter 15 — The Rain That Felt Like a Goodbye

Rain continued through the early morning hours.

Soft.
Steady.
Endless.

The sound filled the bedroom quietly while pale dawn slowly tried pushing through the dark clouds outside.

But inside the room—
morning never truly arrived.

Not emotionally.
Because both **Akira** and **Yuki** had stayed awake almost the entire night.

Holding each other.
Listening to rain.
Pretending time wasn’t slipping away.

Around **6:15 AM**—
Yuki slowly woke first this time.

For several seconds—
she simply lay there quietly against Akira’s chest listening to his heartbeat.

Slow.
Heavy.
Tired.

Then softly—
her eyes filled with tears again.

Because she realized something painful.

Even now—
he was holding her tightly in his sleep.

As if somewhere deep inside—
his heart refused to risk losing her even for a second.

Yuki gently touched his face weakly.
“Akira...”

He woke up immediately again.

Fear had trained him to wake instantly now.

The moment he saw her—

his expression softened.
“You okay?”

Yuki smiled faintly through tired eyes.
“You always ask me that first.”

“Because you matter first.”

The answer came naturally.

Without hesitation.
Without thought.

And honestly—

that hurt her beautifully.

Outside, thunder rolled softly again.

The storm clouds had returned heavier this morning.

Cold wind moved through the slightly open balcony door while the curtains swayed gently.

Yuki slowly looked toward the rain outside.

Then quietly whispered—

“It’s beautiful.”

Akira followed her gaze toward the grey sky.

“The rain?”

“Mhm.”

Silence.

Then softly—

“It sounds peaceful.”

And somehow—

that sentence terrified him.

Because lately—

everything she loved sounded like farewell.

A few minutes later, Akira carefully helped her sit up slowly.

But the moment Yuki tried standing—

her body weakened suddenly.

Akira caught her immediately.

“Yuki!”

Her breathing became uneven for a moment while dizziness hit harder than before.

Fear exploded across his face instantly.

“Sit down.”

Yuki tried smiling weakly again.

“I’m okay...”

“No.”

His voice cracked sharply.

“You’re not.”

The room became silent immediately afterward.

Because now—

even small movements frightened him.

Downstairs, **Paari** and **Venitha** had already woken up because of the storm.

The moment Akira called from upstairs—

both rushed toward the room instantly.

“What happened?”

Akira carefully held **Yuki** against him while panic quietly spread through the atmosphere again.
“She almost collapsed.”

Paari’s face immediately paled.
“We’re going back to the hospital.”

Yuki softly shook her head weakly.
“No...”

“Amma—”

“I don’t want hospitals anymore.”

Her voice trembled slightly.

And hearing that—
everyone froze.

Because the exhaustion inside her voice sounded deeper today.

Much deeper.
Akira slowly knelt beside her.

His hands trembled while holding hers.
“Then tell me what to do.”

That sentence alone shattered the room emotionally.

Because for the first time—
Akira sounded lost.

Completely lost.

The man who always knew how to protect everyone...
no longer knew how to save the person he loved most.

Yuki slowly touched his face gently again.

Then softly whispered—
“Just stay.”

The tears instantly reached his eyes again.

Because suddenly—
he understood.

She wasn’t asking for cures anymore.
Or hospitals.
Or miracles.

She only wanted love beside her until the end.

The rain outside became heavier.
Dark clouds covered the hills completely now while the entire house slowly filled with quiet fear again.
Venitha carefully carried **Lisa** into the room after the baby began crying downstairs.

The moment Yuki saw her granddaughter—
her tired face softened again.
“Come here...”

Venitha gently placed Lisa beside her carefully.

And somehow—
the room became calmer for a few moments.

Lisa touched Yuki’s fingers curiously while making tiny happy sounds completely unaware of the pain surrounding everyone.

Yuki smiled weakly.
 “There’s my sunshine...”

Akira quietly looked away again.

Because scenes like this had become unbearable now.

Too beautiful.
 Too temporary.
 After some time, Yuki slowly rested back against the pillows exhausted.

Her breathing looked heavier now.

Slower.

Akira sat beside her immediately while holding one hand gently against her forehead.

And for several long seconds—
nobody spoke.

Only rain existed.
 Only fear.
 Only love sitting helplessly inside the room.

Then quietly—

Yuki whispered something so softly everyone almost missed it.
 “I think my time is becoming small.”

The world inside the bedroom shattered after that.

Paari immediately turned away.

Venitha covered her mouth while tears escaped instantly.

And Akira—
Akira completely froze.

Because hearing her say it aloud...

made everything real in a way nothing else had before.

Slowly—
 Akira leaned down and pressed his forehead against hers.

His entire body trembled now.

Then brokenly—

he whispered,
 “Please don’t leave me yet.”

Outside—

rain crashed endlessly against the windows.

But inside that bedroom—

every heart silently understood something terrifying.

The goodbye they feared...

was no longer approaching slowly anymore.

After Yuki whispered those words—

the entire room changed.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But something inside everyone silently broke.

Because until now—

they had still been fighting reality somewhere deep inside their hearts.

Still hoping.

Still pretending maybe time would slow down.

But hearing Yuki herself say it aloud...

destroyed the final illusion.

Rain continued crashing against the windows while cold wind moved through the curtains softly.

Lisa had fallen asleep again against Venitha’s shoulder.

Paari stood near the balcony unable to look directly toward the bed anymore.

And Akira—

Akira still sat beside Yuki holding her hand so tightly it almost looked painful.

As if loosening his grip even slightly might allow life to take her away.

Yuki slowly looked around the room quietly.

Her room.

Their room.

The bookshelf near the wall.

The family photo resting beside the lamp.

The balcony where countless coffees and conversations had lived.

And suddenly—

tears quietly reached her eyes again.

Because now every ordinary object looked precious enough to hurt.

Akira noticed immediately.

“What happened?”

Yuki smiled weakly through tears.

“I’m trying to remember everything.”

The sentence shattered him completely.

“No.”

His voice cracked sharply.

“You’re not going anywhere.”

But even while saying it—

he sounded afraid of his own words.

Because deep inside—

he already knew.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,

“Come closer.”

Yuki gently touched his hair weakly.

“You already are.”

Paari immediately shook his head while tears fell again.

“No.”

“Yes.”

Her voice became softer.

“You’re staying.”

Silence.

“You’re loving me.”

Another pause.

“That’s all I ever wanted.”

Paari lowered his head against the bed crying silently again.

And honestly—

Akira could barely breathe watching them.

Because he realized something painful.

Love makes goodbye unbearable...

but it also makes goodbye beautiful.

Outside, thunder shook the sky violently again.

The storm had fully returned now.

Darkness covered the hills even though it was still daytime.

The whole world outside looked grey.

Heavy.

Like nature itself mourned quietly with them.

A little later, Yuki slowly became exhausted again.

Even speaking seemed difficult now.

Akira carefully adjusted her pillows while Venitha prepared medicines nearby.

Every movement inside the room had become gentle.

Soft.

Like everyone feared breaking something fragile.

Then suddenly—

Yuki looked toward Venitha quietly.

“Can you bring me my blue shawl?”

Venitha immediately nodded and walked toward the cupboard.

The moment she opened it—

the smell of Yuki’s perfume quietly escaped into the room.

And unexpectedly—

Venitha completely broke down.

Because suddenly—

she imagined a future where these clothes would remain untouched.

Where the perfume smell would stay...

but Yuki wouldn't.

Akira closed his eyes tightly hearing Venitha cry softly behind him.

Because now—

grief had started entering every small ordinary thing.

When Venitha finally returned with the shawl, Akira carefully wrapped it around Yuki himself.

Yuki smiled weakly.

“You always fix it too properly.”

“You always wear it incorrectly.”

A faint laugh escaped her lips.

And for one brief beautiful second—

they looked exactly like the couple they had always been.

Normal.

Comfortable.

In love.

The rain outside softened slightly by evening.

The room grew quieter again.

Exhausted quiet.

At some point, Lisa woke up and began softly crying.

Yuki immediately looked toward the sound despite her exhaustion.

Akira noticed.

Then gently placed the baby beside her once more.

Lisa immediately calmed down after touching Yuki's hand.

The entire room silently watched them together.

And suddenly—

Akira's chest hurt so deeply he thought it might physically break.

Because somewhere inside his heart—

he already knew.

These moments...

these tiny peaceful ordinary moments...

were becoming memories now.

Evening slowly disappeared beneath the storm.

Rain continued falling endlessly outside while darkness covered the hills surrounding the house much earlier than usual.

Inside the bedroom—

only warm yellow light remained.

Soft.

Dim.

Fragile.

Just like everyone inside it.

Yuki had become quieter as the hours passed.

Not asleep.

Just tired.

Deeply tired.

The kind of exhaustion that no amount of rest could fix anymore.

Akira stayed beside her without moving even once.

Sometimes he adjusted her blanket.

Sometimes he brushed her hair gently away from her face.

Sometimes he simply stared at her silently.

Memorizing.

Always memorizing now.

Paari quietly entered the room carrying tea for everyone again.

But tonight—

nobody really drank it.

The cups slowly became cold untouched beside the bedside table.

Because fear had stolen everyone’s appetite long ago.

Lisa suddenly began laughing downstairs at something Venitha was doing.

The sound reached the bedroom faintly.

And instantly—

Yuki smiled again.

That small beautiful smile.

Weak.

But real.

“She sounds happy...”

Akira nodded quietly.

“She likes when Venitha sings.”

“Even badly?”

“Especially badly.”

A faint laugh escaped Yuki’s lips again.

And hearing it—

Akira immediately lowered his eyes.

Because now even her laughter sounded tired.

Like her body no longer had strength to carry joy properly.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,
“Can we open the balcony door a little more?”

Akira frowned immediately.
“The air is cold.”

“I want to hear the rain.”

Silence.

Then quietly—
“Please.”

He could never refuse that voice anymore.

Never.

A few moments later, the balcony doors opened slightly wider.

Cold wind entered the room carrying the smell of rain and wet earth.

The sound of rainfall immediately became clearer.
Peaceful.
Endless.

Yuki slowly closed her eyes listening to it.

And for a brief moment—
her face looked calm again.

Almost free from pain.

Then suddenly—

she whispered something so softly the room nearly missed it.
“I think rain sounds like memory.”

Akira looked toward her immediately.
“What do you mean?”

Yuki slowly opened her eyes again.
“It comes back suddenly.”

Silence.

“Even after disappearing for a while.”

The sentence quietly settled inside everyone’s chest.

Because somehow—
it felt true.

Love was like that too.

Even after people leave—

they return through sounds,
places,
songs,
coffee smells,
balconies,
rain.

Paari slowly sat near the foot of the bed while listening silently.

Then softly—

he asked the question he had been afraid to ask.
“Amma...”

Yuki turned toward him weakly.
“Are you in pain?”

The room froze completely.

Because nobody had asked directly yet.

Yuki stayed quiet for several seconds.

Then finally—

she answered honestly.
“A little.”

Akira instantly closed his eyes tightly.

Because hearing her admit pain felt unbearable.

Paari’s voice trembled immediately.
“I hate this.”

Yuki smiled weakly.
“I know.”

“No...”

His tears returned again.
“I really hate this.”

The helplessness inside his voice broke everyone emotionally again.

Because there truly was nothing left to fight anymore.

Only time.
Only waiting.
Only love trying desperately to stay strong while slowly breaking apart.

Akira suddenly leaned down and kissed Yuki’s forehead gently.

Then softly whispered—
“I’m here.”

Yuki looked at him through tired eyes.
“I know.”

A pause.

“That’s why I’m not scared all the time.”

That sentence shattered him more than anything else tonight.

Because suddenly—
he realized something painful.

Even now—
even while dying—

she still felt safest beside him.

Outside, thunder rolled deeply across the sky again.

The storm looked endless tonight.

And inside the room—
the atmosphere slowly became heavier.

Quieter.

Almost sacred.

Like everyone unconsciously understood they were standing near something irreversible.

Later that night, **Venitha** carefully took **Lisa** upstairs after the baby finally fell asleep.

Paari remained downstairs alone for a while unable to enter the bedroom again immediately.

He sat near the dark living room listening to rain while silently crying into his hands.

Because no matter how hard he tried—

he still couldn't accept it.

Couldn't accept that one day this house would continue existing...

without hearing his mother's voice inside it.

Upstairs, **Akira** still held **Yuki** close while she rested weakly against him.

Then suddenly—
 Yuki looked up slowly.
 “Akira...”

“Hm?”

“If I fall asleep...”

His heart instantly tightened.

Yuki's eyes slowly filled with tears again.

“Don't let go of my hand.”

The sentence completely destroyed him.

Akira immediately intertwined his fingers tightly with hers.

Then brokenly whispered—
 “Never.”

Outside—
 rain crashed endlessly against the dark windows of the house.

And somewhere deep inside the storm-filled night—

time quietly moved one step closer to goodbye.

Chapter 16 — The Night They Tried to Stop Time

The storm did not stop that night.

Rain continued crashing endlessly against the windows while thunder rolled across the dark hills of Dindigul like distant heartbreak.

Inside the bedroom—
time itself felt fragile.

Slow.
 Heavy.

Painfully aware of every second passing.

Yuki rested weakly against **Akira’s** chest while his fingers remained tightly intertwined with hers beneath the blanket.

Neither of them slept.
 Not anymore.
 Because sleep now felt terrifying.

Like something precious could disappear between one breath and the next.

The warm yellow light beside the bed glowed softly across the room.
 The bookshelf.
 The curtains moving gently from the cold wind.
 The family photo near the lamp.

Everything looked ordinary.

And somehow—
that made everything hurt even more.
 Because the world inside the room still looked alive...

while everyone inside silently feared goodbye.

Akira slowly looked down at Yuki again.

Her breathing had become softer now.

Weaker.

Every inhale felt careful.
 Every exhale felt fragile.

And honestly—
he was terrified to blink.

Then softly—

Yuki whispered,
 “Are you awake?”

Akira immediately answered,
 “Yes.”

A tiny tired smile reached her lips.
 “You always answer too quickly.”

“I’m scared not to.”

Silence.

Then quietly—
 “I don’t want you calling my name without hearing me answer.”

The tears instantly reached her eyes again.

Because she understood.

Every small fear inside him now carried unbearable love beneath it.

Outside the room, the house remained completely silent.

Paari sat awake downstairs near the balcony holding untouched coffee while listening to the storm.

Venitha slept lightly beside **Lisa** on the sofa nearby.

Nobody trusted sleep anymore.

Not fully.

Paari slowly looked toward the staircase leading upstairs.

And suddenly—

his chest tightened painfully again.

Because deep inside—

he already felt something changing tonight.

The atmosphere inside the house felt different.

Like the world itself had started preparing for something heartbreaking.

Upstairs, Yuki slowly shifted slightly closer against **Akira**.

Then quietly whispered—

“Can you talk to me?”

Akira gently brushed her hair back.

“About what?”

“Anything.”

His throat tightened instantly.

Because suddenly—

he realized she probably didn’t want silence tonight either.

So softly—

he began speaking.

Small memories.

Tiny moments.

The day they first met.

The terrible yellow apartment.

Her obsession with rearranging furniture every month.

The time she burned rice and blamed the cooker.

And slowly—

Yuki began smiling again between exhaustion.

“You were impossible,” **Akira** whispered softly.

“You still married me.”

“I was trapped emotionally.”

A weak laugh escaped her lips.

And hearing that tiny laugh—

he closed his eyes briefly.

Trying to memorize it forever.

Then suddenly—

Yuki became quiet again.

Too quiet.

Akira immediately looked down.

“Yuki?”

She slowly opened her eyes again.

But tears had already gathered there.

“I don’t want you to watch me disappear.”

The sentence shattered him completely.

“No.”

His voice broke instantly.

“You’re not disappearing.”

“But I am.”

Silence crushed the room.

Yuki’s breathing trembled slightly now.

“I can feel it.”

Akira immediately pulled her closer into his arms.

Almost desperately.

“Then stay.”

The words escaped him brokenly.

“Please stay.”

And honestly—

that was no longer a husband speaking calmly.

That was a heart begging against time itself.

Downstairs, thunder shook the windows violently.

Venitha woke up suddenly from the sound while **Lisa** stirred softly beside her.

The atmosphere inside the house felt unbearably heavy now.

Like grief itself had already entered quietly and sat among them.

Back upstairs, **Yuki** slowly lifted one trembling hand toward **Akira’s** face again.

Then softly whispered—
“You loved me beautifully.”

Akira immediately shook his head while tears fell freely now.
“No.”

“Yes.”

A weak smile appeared on her lips.
“You made my whole life feel safe.”

That sentence completely destroyed him.

Because suddenly—
nothing else mattered anymore.

Not fear.
Not pain.
Not even death.

Only this.
Only her voice.
Only her love.

Akira gently kissed her forehead again and again while holding her tightly.

Then quietly whispered against her hair—
“You are my home.”

Yuki closed her eyes hearing that.

And for several long seconds—

only rain existed.

Only heartbeats.
Only two souls holding each other while time quietly slipped away around them.

Then softly—
almost like a frightened child—

Yuki whispered one final thing into the storm-filled darkness.
“Don’t forget the sound of my voice.”

Akira broke completely after hearing that.

He held her hand tighter than ever before.

And through tears—
through fear—
through the unbearable weight of love—

he whispered back,
“Never.”

After that—

the room became completely silent.

Not empty silence.

The kind filled with too many emotions for words to survive inside it.

Rain continued crashing outside.

Thunder rolled across the hills.

Cold wind touched the curtains softly.

But inside the bedroom—

Akira heard only one thing.

Yuki’s breathing.

Slow.

Fragile.

Fading little by little.

And every second—

fear tightened harder around his chest.

Yuki remained curled weakly against him while his arms held her like he was trying to protect her from time itself.

Neither moved.

Neither wanted to disturb the moment.

Because somewhere deep inside—

both of them understood.

This night felt different.

Too different.

Akira gently brushed his fingers through her hair again.

Then softly whispered

“Do you remember our first fight?”

A faint smile touched Yuki’s tired face.

“You deserved it.”

“I bought the wrong curtains.”

“You bought bright orange curtains.”

“They were artistic.”

“They looked radioactive.”

Even now—

a weak laugh escaped her lips again.

And hearing it—

Akira immediately closed his eyes.

Memorizing.

Always memorizing.

Then suddenly—
Yuki became quieter again.

Her breathing slowed further.

Akira instantly looked down in fear.
“Yuki?”

She slowly opened her eyes halfway.
“I’m here...”

But even speaking seemed difficult now.

And honestly—
that terrified him beyond words.

Downstairs, **Paari** quietly stood near the staircase unable to sit still anymore.

Something inside him felt wrong.

The storm.
The silence upstairs.
The unbearable heaviness inside the house.

Everything felt like the world was holding its breath.

Venitha slowly walked toward him carrying sleepy Lisa against her shoulder.
“You should rest a little.”

Paari shook his head immediately.
“I can’t.”

His eyes moved toward upstairs again.
“I feel scared.”

Venitha’s own eyes filled instantly.

Because she felt it too.

Everyone did.

Upstairs, Akira slowly pressed his forehead against Yuki’s again.

His tears no longer stopped now.

They simply kept falling silently onto the blanket between them.
“I’m sorry,” he whispered brokenly.

Yuki frowned weakly.
“For what?”

“For not saving you.”

The sentence shattered the room completely.

Because this—
this was the wound destroying him most.

Not helplessness.

Guilt.

The unbearable guilt of loving someone with everything you have...

and still being unable to stop pain from taking them away.

Yuki immediately used the little strength she had left to touch his face.

“No.”

Her voice barely existed now.

“You gave me everything.”

Akira shook his head desperately.

“It wasn’t enough.”

“It was.”

Tears slowly rolled from the corners of her eyes.

“You were enough.”

And honestly—

those words would stay inside his heart forever.

The storm outside suddenly grew louder again.

Lightning flashed brightly through the balcony for one brief second.

And in that moment—

Akira saw her clearly.

The tired eyes.

The weak breathing.

The trembling fingers still holding his hand.

And suddenly—

real terror finally entered him completely.

Because somewhere inside his soul—

he felt it.

Time was no longer slowing down anymore.

Now—

it was almost gone.

Yuki slowly looked toward the balcony where rain blurred the dark hills outside.

Then quietly whispered—

“Can you hear it?”

Akira looked confused for a second.

“Hear what?”

“The rain.”

Silence.

Yuki smiled faintly.

“It sounds peaceful now.”

The tears escaped him harder after that.

Because she no longer sounded afraid.

And somehow—

that frightened him most of all.

A few minutes later, **Yuki** suddenly whispered again—

very softly.

“So sleepy...”

Akira’s entire body tensed instantly.

“No.”

His voice trembled badly.

“Stay awake with me.”

Yuki slowly blinked.

“Tired...”

Akira immediately held her face carefully.

“Yuki.”

Fear completely filled his voice now.

“Look at me.”

Her eyes slowly met his again.

And seeing how weak they looked—

finally shattered the last remaining strength inside him.

Downstairs, Paari suddenly heard something.

Not loud.

Just silence.

Too much silence.

He immediately looked upstairs again.

Then without another word—

he started running toward the bedroom.

Venitha followed instantly behind him carrying Lisa tightly.

Upstairs, Akira held Yuki closer desperately while tears fell uncontrollably now.

“You promised me.”

His voice cracked violently.

“You said you’d stay.”

Yuki weakly tried smiling again.

But now—

even smiling looked difficult.

Then softly—

almost like a whisper carried by rain—

she said,

“I’m trying...”

And hearing those two words—

Akira finally understood something unbearable.

Love could hold hands.

Love could stay beside someone.

Love could even carry pain together.

But love alone...

could not stop goodbye.

The bedroom door burst open.
“Appa—”

Paari stopped the moment he saw them.

Akira sat on the bed holding **Yuki** tightly against his chest while tears streamed endlessly down his face.

And Yuki—
Yuki looked impossibly weak now.

Her breathing had become shallow.

Slow.

Fragile enough to break everyone watching.

Venitha froze near the doorway holding Lisa protectively while fear instantly swallowed the entire room.
“Amma...”

Paari rushed toward the bed immediately.

His voice trembled violently now.

Yuki slowly turned her eyes toward him.

And somehow—
she still smiled.
Still smiled.

Even now.

That alone shattered him completely.

Akira kept holding her face carefully.
“Stay with me.”

His voice sounded broken beyond recognition.
“Please...”

Yuki’s trembling fingers slowly tightened around his hand again.

A tiny movement.

But enough to make him hold her even tighter.

Rain crashed violently outside.

Thunder shook the windows.
The storm sounded endless now.

Like the entire night itself was grieving with them.

Paari knelt beside the bed while tears fell uncontrollably down his face.
“Amma...”

His breathing became uneven.
“I’m here.”

Yuki slowly looked at him weakly.

Then softly whispered—
“I know.”

Even speaking those two words exhausted her now.

And honestly—

that terrified everyone more than anything else.

Venitha slowly walked closer carrying Lisa carefully.

The baby looked around sleepily, unaware that the world inside the room was collapsing.

Yuki’s tired eyes immediately softened seeing her granddaughter.

“Princess...”

Venitha carefully sat beside the bed while Lisa reached tiny fingers toward Yuki instinctively.

And somehow—

even now—

Yuki smiled again.

Like love still reached her through pain.

Then suddenly—

Yuki’s breathing faltered slightly.

Akira’s entire body froze.

“Yuki.”

Fear completely consumed his voice now.

“Look at me.”

Yuki slowly blinked again.

Trying.

Always trying.

But exhaustion had already wrapped itself around her completely.

Paari immediately grabbed his phone.

“I’m calling the ambulance.”

“No!”

The word escaped Akira instantly.

Everyone froze.

Akira’s breathing shook violently now.

“She said she doesn’t want hospitals.”

Silence crushed the room.

Because suddenly—

everyone understood.

This wasn’t about saving her anymore.

This was about staying with her.

Where she felt loved.

Where she felt home.

Yuki slowly turned toward Akira again.

Then softly whispered—
“You remembered...”

Akira immediately broke harder after hearing that.
“Of course I remembered.”

His forehead rested against hers again while tears fell endlessly between them.
“I remember everything.”

Outside—
lightning flashed across the hills.

For one brief second, the entire room glowed white.

And in that moment—
everyone saw it clearly.

The goodbye approaching silently between breaths.

Yuki slowly looked around the room one last time.

Paari crying beside the bed.

Venitha holding Lisa with trembling hands.

The warm yellow light.
The balcony curtains moving gently in the wind.

And finally—
Akira.
Always Akira.

Her eyes rested on him longest.

Like her soul itself could not bear leaving his face behind.

Then quietly—
with almost no strength left—

Yuki whispered,
“Come closer...”

Akira immediately leaned down beside her.

Her trembling fingers slowly touched his cheek.

And through weak breaths—
through pain—
through tears—

she whispered the words that shattered every heart inside the room forever.
“You gave me a beautiful life.”

Akira completely collapsed emotionally after that.
“No...”

His voice broke violently.
“No no no...”

Yuki’s eyes slowly filled again too.
Then softly—
“Thank you... for loving me.”

The storm outside roared louder.

But inside the bedroom—

everything became silent.

Because no one knew how to survive words like those.

Paari lowered his head against the bed crying openly now.

Venitha could barely stand anymore.

Even Lisa began crying softly from the overwhelming emotion filling the room.

And Akira—

Akira held Yuki’s hand against his lips desperately like prayer itself.

Then brokenly whispered through endless tears—

“You are my whole life.”

Yuki smiled one final soft smile hearing that.

Small.

Weak.

Beautiful.

The same smile he fell in love with decades ago.

And somewhere beneath the sound of endless rain—

time quietly continued moving forward.

Closer.

Closer.

Closer to goodbye.

Chapter 17 — The Goodbye They Couldn't Stop

The storm outside became violent.

Rain crashed endlessly against the windows while thunder shook the hills of Dindigul like the sky itself was breaking apart.

But inside the bedroom—
everything had become terrifyingly quiet.

Only Yuki's fragile breathing remained.

Slow.
Weak.
Fading little by little.

Akira still held her hand tightly against his lips while tears fell endlessly down his face.

Nobody in the room tried hiding their pain anymore.
Not now.
Not when goodbye stood silently between every heartbeat.

Yuki slowly looked at Akira again.

And even through exhaustion—
even through unbearable weakness—
her eyes still carried the same love they always had.

Soft.
Safe.
Home.

Then quietly—
she whispered,
“Don't cry...”

Akira immediately shook his head desperately.
“How?”

His voice shattered completely.
“How do I not cry?”

Yuki's trembling fingers weakly brushed against his cheek.

And somehow—
even now—
she still tried comforting him first.

Paari covered his face while crying openly near the bed.

Venitha stood beside him trembling while Lisa cried softly against her shoulder from the overwhelming emotion filling the room.

The whole family was breaking together now.

And Yuki—
Yuki looked at all of them with heartbreaking tenderness.

As if she was trying to carry their pain even while leaving.

Then suddenly—
Yuki's breathing weakened again.

Akira instantly panicked.
“Yuki.”

He held her face carefully.
“Stay with me.”

Her eyes slowly struggled to focus again.

And for one unbearable moment—

fear completely swallowed the room.
“Amma...”

Paari crawled closer desperately beside the bed.
“Please...”

His voice cracked violently now.
“Please don’t go.”

That sentence alone shattered the soul of the room.

Because suddenly—
everyone sounded like children again.

Not adults.
Not parents.

Just people terrified of losing someone they loved too much.

Yuki slowly looked toward her son.

Tears rested in her eyes again.

Then softly—
“You’ll be okay.”

Paari immediately shook his head harder.
“No.”

“Yes.”

Her voice barely existed now.
“You’ll love them well.”

A weak breath.
“You’ll keep this house warm.”

Paari lowered his head against the bed sobbing uncontrollably.

Because he understood.

She was trusting him with the family now.

With the home.
With the love she was leaving behind.

Akira could barely breathe anymore.

His chest physically hurt from trying not to collapse.

He held Yuki’s hand tighter.

Almost desperately.

As if his heart still believed love could somehow keep her here.

Then brokenly—

he whispered,
“I can’t do this without you.”

The tears escaped Yuki’s eyes again hearing that.

Because honestly—
she didn’t know how to leave him either.

The rain outside roared louder.

Lightning flashed across the dark room again.

And beneath that brief white light—
Yuki slowly looked at Akira one final time.

Really looked at him.

Memorizing him too.

The tired eyes.
The trembling lips.
The man who loved her with his entire soul.

Then softly—
through fading breath—
she whispered her final words to him.
“You were my happiest place.”

Akira completely broke apart after hearing that.

A sound escaped him that no one inside the room had ever heard before.
Not crying.
Not shouting.
Pure heartbreak.

The kind that comes only when love loses something it cannot survive without.

Yuki’s fingers slowly tightened around his hand one last time.

Tiny.
Weak.
Still loving him even now.

Then slowly—
her breathing softened.
Slower.
Quieter.

Fragile enough to disappear.
“Yuki?”

Akira’s voice trembled violently.
No answer.

Fear exploded instantly.
“Yuki.”

He held her face carefully again.
“Look at me.”

Paari stood up suddenly.
“Amma—”

Venitha immediately began crying harder.

Lisa cried loudly now too.

The storm outside sounded endless.

And inside the room—

time finally stopped.

Yuki slowly exhaled one final trembling breath against **Akira’s** hand.

Then—

silence.

Complete silence.

The kind that destroys worlds.

Akira froze.

Completely froze.

“No...”

The word escaped him weakly.

Disbelievingly.

“No...”

His hands trembled violently while holding her face.

“Yuki.”

Nothing.

No response.

No movement.

Only silence.

And in that unbearable moment—

the house lost its heartbeat.

Paari collapsed beside the bed crying uncontrollably.

Venitha covered her mouth while sobbing into Lisa’s hair.

The storm outside roared like grief itself.

But Akira—

Akira still held Yuki close against his chest.

Still waiting.

Still hoping.

Still refusing to believe a world could exist where she no longer answered him back.

Then finally—

he lowered his forehead against hers and broke completely.

Because the love of his life...

the woman who made every ordinary moment beautiful...

was gone.

The storm continued outside.

Relentless.

Violent.

As if the sky itself refused to accept what had just happened.

But inside the bedroom—

everything had become unbearably still.

No more fragile breathing.

No more weak smiles.

No more soft whispers calling ***Akira’s name.***

Only silence.

Akira still held **Yuki** against his chest.

Motionless.

Broken.

His trembling fingers gently brushed through her hair again and again like his heart still believed she would wake up if he loved her hard enough.

“Yuki...”

His voice barely existed anymore.

Soft.

Shattered.

“Hey...”

Nothing.

No answer.

And that silence destroyed him over and over again every second.

Paari sat on the floor beside the bed crying uncontrollably with both hands covering his face.

The sound of his grief filled the room painfully.

Not loud.

Not dramatic.

The kind of crying that comes from somewhere deep inside the soul.

The kind that changes a person forever.

Venitha stood near the wall holding Lisa tightly against her chest while tears fell endlessly down her face.

The baby had stopped crying now.

As if even she somehow felt the heaviness swallowing the house.

And honestly—

that hurt even more.

Because the world had become too quiet.

Too empty.

Too wrong.

Akira slowly lowered his forehead against Yuki’s one last time.

Her skin had already begun feeling colder.

And suddenly—

panic exploded through him again.

“No...”

He held her tighter instantly.

“No no no...”

Paari immediately looked up through tears hearing his father’s voice break apart again.

Akira’s breathing became uneven violently now.

“She’s cold...”

That sentence shattered the room completely.

Because until that moment—

some small part of all of them had still been waiting for her to wake up.

Then suddenly—

Akira buried his face against her shoulder and cried.

Not the quiet tears he had been hiding for weeks.

Not controlled grief.

This was devastation.

Pure heartbreak.

Thirty-four years of love collapsing inside one human heart at once.

“I’m here...”

His voice cracked against her softly.

“I’m still here...”

And honestly—

that was the cruelest part.

He still had so much love left to give her.

But nowhere left to place it.

Outside the bedroom, the rest of the house remained dark and silent.

The balcony lights still glowed softly against the rain.

Coffee cups still rested downstairs untouched.

Her blue shawl still hung near the chair.

Everything inside the home still carried her presence.

And somehow—

that made losing her feel impossible to understand.

How could someone disappear...

while their love still existed everywhere?

Hours passed without anyone noticing.

Time no longer felt real.

Eventually, the storm outside softened into quiet rain again.

But inside the room—

grief only deepened.

At some point near dawn, Akira finally allowed Paari to gently help him lay Yuki down properly beneath the blanket.

But even then—

he never let go of her hand.

Not once.

Because letting go felt too final.

Too cruel.

Too real.

Paari quietly sat beside his father afterward.

Neither spoke for a very long time.

Then suddenly—

Akira whispered something so softly it almost disappeared into the silence.

“The house is going to feel empty now.”

Paari immediately began crying again.

Because he knew.

Every corner of the home carried her.

The balcony.

The kitchen.

The coffee cups.

The laughter.

The warmth.

Yuki had not simply lived in that house.

She had become part of its soul.

Venitha slowly walked toward the balcony door and opened it slightly.

Cold morning wind entered the room gently carrying the smell of rain and wet earth.

The storm had finally ended.

Only soft drizzle remained across the hills.

And somehow—

the peacefulness outside felt cruel.

Because the world had continued moving forward anyway.

Birds would still sing.

Morning would still arrive.

People would still laugh somewhere.

Even after their entire world had stopped.

Akira slowly looked toward Yuki again.

Her face looked peaceful now.

Free from pain.

Free from fear.

And somehow—

that hurt him even more.

Because this was the first time in weeks she looked fully rested.

Then quietly—
 with trembling fingers—
Akira gently brushed a strand of hair away from **Yuki’s** forehead one last time.

The same way he had done thousands of times before.

And brokenly whispered—
 “Thank you for loving me.”

The tears fell silently onto her hand.

Outside—
 morning slowly began touching the hills of Dindigul again.

But inside the house—
the sun would never feel the same anymore.

Morning arrived slowly.

Soft sunlight touched the wet hills outside while the rain finally faded into silence.

But inside the house—
nothing felt alive anymore.

The warmth that once filled every room had disappeared quietly during the night.
 And everyone felt it.
 Immediately.
 Painfully.

The bedroom door remained slightly open.

Cold morning air moved softly through the curtains while the dim yellow lamp still glowed beside the bed.

Yuki rested peacefully beneath the white blanket now.

Still.
 Too still.
 And beside her—
Akira remained sitting exactly where he had been for hours.

One hand still holding hers.

His eyes looked empty now.

Not because he stopped crying.

Because grief had gone deeper than tears.

Paari quietly stood near the doorway unable to fully enter the room again.

Every time he looked toward the bed—

his chest physically hurt.

Because his mother still looked like herself.

Like she might wake up any second and complain about everyone crying too much.

But the silence never broke.

And slowly—
reality became unbearable.

Downstairs, Venitha carefully placed sleeping Lisa inside her cradle before leaning against the kitchen counter and finally collapsing emotionally again.

The smell of coffee still lingered faintly inside the house.

Yuki’s coffee cup from yesterday still rested near the balcony untouched.

And suddenly—

Venitha cried harder than before.

Because grief had started living inside ordinary things now.

Back upstairs, **Akira** slowly lifted Yuki’s hand and pressed it gently against his forehead.

His fingers trembled constantly now.

Then softly—

he whispered,

“You promised we’d grow old together.”

Silence.

Only silence answered him.

And honestly—

that silence had become the cruelest thing he had ever known.

Paari finally walked toward him slowly.

“Appa...”

Akira didn’t respond immediately.

His eyes remained fixed on Yuki’s face quietly.

Then suddenly—

his voice cracked softly.

“I still keep waiting for her to breathe.”

That sentence shattered Paari completely again.

Because he understood.

Love does not stop instantly.

The heart keeps searching.

Keeps waiting.

Keeps refusing reality long after goodbye arrives.

Paari slowly knelt beside his father and held his shoulder tightly.

For several seconds—

both men simply cried together silently beside the bed.

No words.

No comfort.

Just grief too large for language.

Outside, neighbors slowly began arriving after hearing the news.

Soft voices filled the downstairs living room.

Footsteps.

Murmured prayers.

Sympathetic eyes.

But inside the bedroom—

none of it felt real yet.

The world outside had already accepted the truth.

Akira still couldn’t.

Eventually, an elderly woman from the neighborhood quietly entered the room carrying fresh jasmine flowers.

She stopped the moment she saw Yuki.

Then softly whispered through tears—
“She looks peaceful.”

Akira immediately closed his eyes tightly.

Because yes—

she did.

Peaceful.

Like pain had finally left her.

But to him—
peace felt cruel now.

Because it came at the cost of losing her.

A little later, **Venitha** carefully brought Lisa upstairs.

The baby looked around curiously before noticing everyone’s tears.

Then slowly—
she looked toward Yuki.

For one heartbreaking second—
Lisa stretched both tiny hands forward instinctively.

Toward her grandmother.

Toward warmth.

Toward love she did not yet understand she had lost.

The room broke emotionally all over again.

Paari immediately turned away crying.

Venitha buried her face into Lisa’s hair.

And Akira—

Akira gently touched the baby’s head while tears silently fell again.

Because suddenly—

he realized something unbearable.

One day Lisa would ask about her.

And they would spend the rest of their lives trying to explain a woman who could never truly be explained with words.

The balcony doors remained open slightly.

Morning wind entered the room carrying the smell of rain and wet earth.

The same wind Yuki loved.

The same rain she called peaceful.

And somewhere beyond the hills of Dindigul—

the sky slowly cleared after the storm.

But inside the house—

grief had only just begun.

Akira slowly leaned closer toward Yuki one final time.

Then softly whispered against her forehead—

“You were my home.”

His tears fell silently onto her skin.

And for the first time in thirty-four years—

the love of his life could no longer answer him back.

Chapter 18 — The Love She Left Behind

Rain fell quietly across the hills of Dindigul.

Not heavy rain.
Not storm rain.

Just soft evening rain touching the earth gently like memory refusing to disappear.

The house near the hills remained silent beneath the grey sky.

Too silent.

Weeks had passed since **Yuki’s** goodbye.

Yet her presence still existed everywhere.

Inside the curtains she once adjusted every morning.

Inside the coffee cups she always complained about.

Inside the balcony chair nobody touched anymore.

And especially—
inside Akira.

The balcony lights glowed softly against the cold evening mist while Akira sat alone near the railing with untouched coffee resting beside him.

The same place.
The same evening hour.
The same rain.
Only now—
Yuki’s chair remained empty beside him.

At first, that empty chair had destroyed him.

Every time he looked at it, his chest tightened painfully.
Every rainy evening felt unbearable.

Because rain no longer sounded peaceful.

It sounded lonely.

Inside the house, silence had slowly taken over everything after the funeral.

The television stayed off most nights.

Dinner conversations became shorter.

Even laughter sounded weaker.

Paari tried hiding his grief by staying busy with work.

Venitha forced smiles while caring for Lisa.

And Akira—
Akira had become quieter than everyone.

Not broken loudly.

Just slowly fading into silence.

That evening, cold wind moved through the balcony curtains while rain touched the hills endlessly beyond the darkness.

Akira leaned back against the chair tiredly.

His eyes remained fixed on the rain.

Then quietly—
his fingers moved toward the empty chair beside him unconsciously.

Like his heart still expected **Yuki** to be there.

Complaining about the cold.

Stealing his coffee.

Resting against his shoulder.

But only silence answered him now.

Inside the living room, tiny sounds suddenly echoed softly.

Tap.
Tap tap.
Tiny unsteady footsteps.

Then—
a small laugh.

Akira slowly turned toward the balcony door.

And immediately—
his expression softened slightly.

Lisa.

Barely one year old.

Tiny feet.
Messy hair.
And somehow already carrying enough energy to fight the entire world.

She dragged something huge behind her proudly while struggling to walk properly.

Akira blinked once.

Then quietly laughed beneath his breath for the first time that day.

It was Yuki’s blue shawl.

Half of it twisted around Lisa’s tiny legs while the rest dragged dramatically across the floor behind her like royal fabric.

Still—

Lisa looked unbelievably proud carrying it.
“Tha-thaaaa!”

Her tiny voice filled the balcony softly.

Then immediately—
she lost balance because of the shawl.

Akira stood up instantly in panic.

But before he could reach her—
Lisa sat on the floor laughing loudly at herself.

And somehow—
that sound entered the house like sunlight after endless rain.

Inside the kitchen, **Paari** stopped completely after hearing Akira laugh softly.

A real laugh.
Not forced.
Not empty.
Real.

Venitha slowly looked toward him emotionally.

Because neither of them had heard that sound since **Yuki** left.

Lisa finally reached the balcony after surviving her dramatic battle against the oversized shawl.

Then she pointed excitedly toward the rain outside.
“Ahhhh!”

Tiny fingers stretched toward the hills while rain continued falling softly beyond the balcony.

Akira looked at her quietly.

And suddenly—
his chest tightened painfully.

Because Yuki used to react exactly the same way whenever it rained.

Like rain itself was magical.

Lisa clapped happily while watching the raindrops.

Then she looked back toward Akira immediately, waiting for him to react too.

And somehow—
that tiny moment broke something warm open inside his grief.

Because for the first time in weeks—
the balcony no longer felt completely empty.

Akira slowly walked toward her before carefully lifting her into his arms.
Lisa instantly rested against his chest comfortably while still holding Yuki’s shawl tightly.

The rain continued falling softly around them.
Cold wind touched the balcony gently.

And quietly—
Akira closed his eyes.

Because suddenly—
he understood something.

Love had not disappeared from the house.

It had simply changed form.

Very softly—
Akira looked toward the rain-covered hills and whispered,
“She would’ve spoiled you too much.”

Lisa only blinked sleepily at him before grabbing his shirt with tiny fingers.

And somehow—
that tiny touch healed something inside him just a little.

Behind the balcony door, Paari quietly stood beside Venitha watching them silently.

Neither interrupted the moment.

Because the sight before them felt too fragile.

Too beautiful.

An old man holding a little girl wrapped in Yuki’s shawl while rain touched the hills softly beyond them.

It looked like heartbreak and healing existing together in the same place.

The rain slowly became heavier outside.

Balcony lights glowed warmly against the mist-covered darkness.

And somewhere between tiny laughter,

coffee,

and the sound of rain—

the house slowly began learning how to breathe again.

Days passed quietly after that evening.

Not quickly.

Not peacefully.

But slowly—

life began returning to the house one small moment at a time.

Lisa became the center of everything without even realizing it.

Morning silence disappeared because of her tiny footsteps running across the hallway.

The living room no longer stayed clean for more than five minutes.

And every single person inside the house somehow became controlled by one tiny human being.

Especially **Paari**.

One morning, **Akira** walked into the kitchen carrying Lisa carefully against his shoulder while she held his glasses in both hands proudly.

“Lisa...”

Akira sighed dramatically.

“I need those to see.”

Lisa immediately laughed and tried wearing the glasses upside down.

Inside the kitchen, **Venitha** burst into laughter.

“She already acts like Appa.”

“That’s a dangerous sign,” Paari muttered while preparing milk bottles sleepily.

Ever since Lisa entered the house—

the atmosphere slowly changed again.

The television turned on more often.

Dinner conversations became louder.

Laughter returned unexpectedly.

And sometimes—

for a few brief seconds—

the grief almost disappeared completely.

That evening, rain returned once again.

Soft monsoon rain covered the hills while cold wind moved gently through the balcony curtains.

Akira sat near the railing holding coffee quietly.

And exactly as expected—

tiny footsteps attacked the floor again.

Tap tap tap tap.

“Thathaaaa!”

Akira smiled before even turning around.

“There’s the disaster.”

Lisa proudly ran toward him carrying a steel spoon for absolutely no reason.

Then dramatically raised it toward him like treasure.

Akira blinked slowly.

“What is that?”

Lisa only laughed proudly.

Inside the kitchen, **Paari** immediately realized what happened.

“She stole my spoon again?!”

Venitha laughed helplessly.

“She steals everything now.”

Outside, Lisa climbed onto Akira’s lap comfortably while rain continued falling beyond the hills.

Then suddenly—

she stretched one tiny hand toward the rain.

Exactly the way **Yuki** used to.

Akira froze for one painful second.

Because some similarities hurt beautifully.

“Rain,” Akira whispered softly.

Lisa immediately repeated badly—

“Rai.”

Akira quietly laughed.

“Yes.”

“Rain.”

Lisa clapped proudly after saying it properly.

And somehow—

the balcony felt alive again.

For several moments, both grandfather and granddaughter simply watched the rain together peacefully.

Then slowly—

Lisa became sleepy against his chest.

Tiny fingers still holding the useless spoon tightly.

Akira carefully wrapped Yuki’s shawl around her once again.

And suddenly—

everything felt painfully beautiful.

The rain.

The warm balcony lights.

The little girl sleeping against him.

The house breathing softly behind him.

Inside, **Paari** quietly watched the balcony from the hallway.

Then softly whispered toward **Venitha**,
“Amma would’ve loved this.”

Venitha smiled emotionally.
“She’s probably watching proudly.”

The smell of dinner slowly filled the house.

Paari and Venitha argued about salt levels again.

Lisa mumbled sleepy baby sounds against **Akira’s** shoulder.

And outside—
rain continued falling softly across Dindigul.

Very quietly—
Akira looked toward the rain-covered hills once more.

Then softly whispered into the darkness,
“You stayed.”

Cold wind moved gently through the balcony curtains.

And for the first time since goodbye—
the rain no longer sounded completely lonely.
Weeks slowly turned into months.

And little by little—
the house changed.

Not completely.

There were still quiet moments.

Still sudden silences when someone accidentally mentioned Yuki.
Still nights when Akira stared too long at the empty chair beside him.

But now—
the silence no longer felt heavy all the time.

Because **Lisa** had unknowingly declared war against sadness itself.

And somehow—
she was winning.

One rainy afternoon, the entire house became chaotic because Lisa disappeared for exactly three minutes.
“Lisa?!”

Venitha searched the kitchen first.

Paari checked the hallway dramatically like a police officer investigating a national emergency.

Akira quietly walked toward the balcony already knowing where she would be.

And of course—
there she was.

Sitting proudly near **Yuki’s** chair with biscuit crumbs all over her face.

Akira slowly crossed his arms.
 “So this is where criminals hide.”

Lisa gasped dramatically before offering him half a destroyed biscuit proudly.

Akira laughed softly.
 “Bribery too?”

Lisa clapped happily at hearing his laugh.

Rain touched the hills softly beyond the balcony.

Cold wind moved gently through Lisa’s tiny hair while she sat wrapped badly inside Yuki’s oversized blue shawl again.

At this point—
the shawl had unofficially become hers.

Akira carefully sat beside her with coffee in his hands.

Lisa immediately climbed onto his lap naturally like it belonged there.

And honestly—
it did.

For several moments—
 both simply watched the rain together quietly.

Then suddenly—
 Lisa pointed toward the hills excitedly.
 “Pretty!”

Akira blinked once in surprise.

It was one of the clearest words she had spoken so far.

He slowly looked toward the rain-covered hills again.

Silver mist moved across the trees beautifully while soft rain covered the earth endlessly.

Then quietly—

Akira smiled.
 “Yes.”

Very softly—
 “Pretty.”

Inside the kitchen, **Paari** immediately shouted loudly after hearing Lisa speak clearly.
 “SHE SAID A WORD!”

“She already says words,” **Venitha** replied.

“No, but this sounded intelligent.”

“That’s surprising considering her father.”

“Disrespect.”

Lisa burst into laughter hearing their voices.

And suddenly—
the house felt warm from corner to corner again.

Evenings slowly became the family’s favorite time now.

Rain outside.
Dinner smells inside.
Balcony lights glowing softly.
Lisa running around causing emotional and physical destruction equally.

And **Akira**—
Akira slowly learning how to smile without guilt again.

That night, rain became slightly heavier.

Soft thunder rolled beyond the hills while cold wind moved through the balcony curtains.

Lisa sat on the floor beside Akira playing with steel containers loudly because apparently silence was illegal for her.

Then suddenly—
she stopped moving.

Akira looked down immediately.

Lisa was staring at **Yuki’s** framed photograph near the balcony door.

Tiny curious eyes.

Complete concentration.

Then softly—
she pointed.
“Paati.”

The world suddenly became quiet.
Not painfully quiet.
Gentle quiet.
Because this was the first time she had said it clearly.

Akira slowly turned toward the photograph.

Yuki’s warm smile still rested inside the frame softly.

The same smile that once made the entire house feel alive.
Then quietly—
Akira lifted Lisa into his arms again.
“Yes.”

His voice became softer.
“Paati.”

Lisa smiled proudly after repeating it correctly.

Then immediately pointed toward the rain outside too.
“Paati rain.”

Akira stopped breathing for one brief second.

Because somehow—
without anyone teaching her—

Lisa had connected Yuki and rain together naturally.

Exactly the same way the family carried her inside their hearts.

Behind them, Paari quietly lowered his eyes emotionally.

Venitha gently held **Paari’s** hand.

Neither spoke.

Because moments like this always felt too fragile for words.

Lisa slowly became sleepy afterward while resting against **Akira’s** chest.

Tiny fingers held part of **Yuki’s** shawl tightly.

Rain continued falling softly beyond the hills.

And quietly—

Akira closed his eyes.

Because for the first time since losing Yuki—

peace finally entered his heart gently instead of painfully.

Very softly—

he kissed Lisa’s forehead.

Then whispered toward the rain-covered darkness,

“She would’ve loved you so much.”

Cold wind moved through the balcony one final time that night.

And somewhere inside the sound of endless rain—

the house no longer carried only grief anymore.

Now—

it carried love that stayed behind.

Chapter 19 — Years Passed Quietly

Years passed quietly through the house on the hill.

Not empty years.
Warm years.

The kind filled with ordinary moments that slowly become memories without anyone noticing.

Lisa grew older.

The tiny girl who once dragged **Yuki’s** shawl across the floor now walked through life with confidence, sharp humor, and the exact same warmth Yuki carried inside her smile.

And somehow—
the house grew with her.

Rain still visited Dindigul often.

The balcony lights still glowed warmly during evenings.
Coffee still smelled too strong because Akira never learned how to make it properly.

And every time rain touched the hills—
the family still thought about Yuki.

Only now—
the memories no longer hurt the same way.

That evening, monsoon rain covered the roads heavily while buses moved slowly through the crowded Dindigul bus stand.
People rushed through puddles carrying bags above their heads desperately.
Vendors shouted near tea stalls.

Rainwater reflected yellow streetlights across the wet roads beautifully.

And near the entrance—
Akira stood quietly holding a black umbrella.

Waiting.

A dark BMW remained parked nearby beneath the rain.

Soft old melodies played quietly inside the car while mist covered the streets gently.

Akira checked the time again.

Then sighed dramatically to himself.
“This girl will make me grow older faster.”

Suddenly—
a familiar voice echoed loudly across the bus stand.
“THATHAAAA!”

Akira immediately turned.
And there she was.

Lisa.

Twenty-one years old.

Hair slightly wet from rain.

Bag hanging carelessly from one shoulder.

Smiling brightly while running toward him through the crowded station like the world around her didn’t exist.

And honestly—
for one impossible second—

Akira’s heart stopped painfully.

Because she looked so much like **Yuki** during rainy evenings.
“You made an old man stand in rain,” Akira complained immediately after she reached him.

Lisa gasped dramatically.
“You came thirty minutes early!”

“That’s called responsibility.”

“That’s called emotional overacting.”

Akira shook his head while hiding his smile.
“You’ve become too disrespectful.”

“I inherited it genetically.”

Lisa immediately moved under his umbrella before hugging his arm naturally.

The rain continued falling heavily around them.

Crowded buses moved slowly behind them.

And somehow—
the entire noisy bus stand suddenly felt peaceful to Akira.

Because Lisa had returned home.

“You ate properly?” Akira asked while walking toward the car.

Lisa looked offended instantly.
“I’m twenty-one.”

“That means no.”

“That’s rude.”

“That means correct.”

Lisa laughed loudly while opening the car door.

And hearing that laughter during rain—

inside the same city where Yuki once laughed beside him too—

felt painfully beautiful.

The BMW slowly moved through the wet roads afterward while rain covered the windshield endlessly.

Old Tamil melodies played softly through the speakers.

Streetlights reflected across puddles beautifully outside.
And Lisa—
like always—

talked nonstop.

About college.
About friends.
About random strangers she judged aggressively for no reason.

Akira listened quietly while driving.

Not because the stories were important.

But because **Lisa’s** voice filled silence beautifully.

“Wait wait wait—stop the car!”

Akira blinked once.

“What now?”

Lisa pointed excitedly toward a roadside bajji shop glowing beneath yellow rain lights.

“Bajji.”

“It’s raining heavily.”

“That’s literally the correct weather for bajji.”

“That logic sounds illegal.”

Lisa already opened the car door before he finished speaking.

A few minutes later—

both stood beneath a tiny roadside tea stall while rain poured endlessly around them.

Hot oil crackled loudly nearby.

The smell of tea and chili bajji filled the cold evening air warmly.

Lisa happily held a paper plate while blowing dramatically on hot bajji.

Akira watched her quietly.

Then softly smiled.

Because suddenly—

another memory returned naturally.

Yuki standing exactly like this years ago during another rainy evening.

Complaining the bajji was too hot.

Then burning her tongue anyway.

Lisa suddenly looked toward him suspiciously.

“What?”

Akira slowly blinked.

“You’re thinking about Paati again.”

The words were gentle.

Not painful.

Just understanding.

Akira looked toward the rain outside the tea stall quietly.

Then softly smiled.

“Always.”

For several moments—

both simply stood there listening to rain hit the roads endlessly.

Warm tea between their hands.

Cold wind touching the city softly.

And somewhere deep inside that ordinary rainy evening—

Akira realized something quietly.

Life had continued moving forward after grief.

Not away from **Yuki**.

But carrying her gently along with it.

Rain continued through the evening while the BMW moved slowly across the glowing streets of Dindigul.

Water streaked across the windows endlessly.

Streetlights reflected beautifully against the wet roads.

And inside the car—

warmth quietly existed between Akira and Lisa like it always had.

Lisa leaned comfortably against the seat while eating the last piece of bajji dramatically.
“You know...”

Akira kept his eyes on the road.
“That sentence always creates problems.”

Lisa ignored him proudly.
“Tomorrow is my birthday.”

“I’m aware.”

“You forgot last year.”

“I was testing your emotional strength.”

“That’s not how memory works.”

Akira laughed softly under his breath.

And hearing that laugh during rain—
inside the warm car filled with old music—

made Lisa smile quietly.

Because even after all these years,
her favorite sound in the world remained simple:

Akira laughing peacefully.

The rain slowly became softer while they entered the market streets near the city center.

Shops glowed brightly beneath wet signboards.

People moved through umbrellas and puddles while festival lights reflected across the roads beautifully.

Lisa suddenly sat up excitedly.
“Stop the car.”

Akira sighed immediately.
“That tone costs money.”

Twenty minutes later—

Akira regretted every life decision that brought him there.

Lisa moved through clothing shops with dangerous energy while carrying too many outfits at once.

“This one?”

“No.”

“This one?”

“You look like a curtain.”

“This one?”

“That color attacked my eyesight.”

Lisa gasped dramatically.

“You are emotionally impossible.”

“You inherited stubbornness from your Paati.”

Lisa froze for one brief second after hearing that.

Then quietly smiled.

And somehow—

the atmosphere became softer instantly.

Inside the shop, warm yellow lights reflected across mirrors while rain tapped softly outside.

Lisa stood near a mirror holding a deep blue saree against herself.

Akira looked up absentmindedly—
then suddenly froze.

For one impossible second—

his chest tightened painfully.

Because the color.

The rain outside.

The smile.

Everything reminded him of Yuki.

Not exactly the same.

But enough to make memory ache beautifully.

Lisa noticed immediately.

Her expression softened gently.

“What?”

Akira slowly shook his head before smiling faintly.

“Nothing.”

A pause.

Then quietly—

“Blue still suits this family too much.”

Lisa’s eyes softened after hearing that.

Because she understood what he truly meant.

After forcing Akira through three more shops against his will—

Lisa finally declared herself satisfied.

The rain outside had become softer now.

Cold mist covered the streets while tea smells drifted through the night air warmly.

“Tea?” **Lisa** asked hopefully.

“You already drank tea.”

“That was bus stand tea.”

“And?”

“That doesn’t count.”

Akira stared at her silently.

Then sighed dramatically.

“Your generation terrifies me.”

A few minutes later—

both sat beneath another roadside tea stall while rainwater dripped softly from nearby rooftops.

Warm tea rested between their hands.

The city glowed quietly around them.

And for several moments—

neither spoke.

Comfortable silence.

The kind shared only between people deeply connected to each other.

Then softly—

Lisa looked toward Akira.

“You’re tired.”

Akira immediately looked offended.

“I survived raising your father.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“I am perfectly healthy.”

Lisa narrowed her eyes suspiciously.

“You made the same sound Appa makes while sitting down now.”

“That is betrayal.”

Lisa burst into laughter instantly.

And honestly—

Akira laughed too.

Warmly.

Freely.

Without heaviness following afterward.

The rain continued softly around the tea stall.

Then quietly—

Lisa’s voice became softer.

“Thank you.”

Akira blinked once.

“For what?”

“For always coming to get me.”

The sentence sounded simple.

But it carried years inside it.

Bus stands.

School pickups.

Late-night drives.

Rainy evenings.

Silent support.

Love shown through ordinary things.

Akira slowly looked toward the rain-covered city.

Then softly smiled.

“That’s what family does.”

Lisa rested her head briefly against his shoulder afterward.

Just for one second.

But that one second carried the same warmth Yuki once left behind in the family years ago.

Later that night, the BMW slowly drove back toward the house near the hills.

Rain touched the windshield softly.

Old songs played quietly.

And somewhere deep inside the peaceful night—

Akira realized something gently.

Tomorrow would be Lisa’s birthday.

But somehow—

it also felt like another celebration of Yuki’s love surviving through the years.

Chapter 20 — Lisa’s Birthday

Rain continued through the night softly.

Not loud enough to disturb sleep.

Just gentle enough to make the entire house feel peaceful beneath the cold monsoon sky.

And sometime before sunrise—

the smell of coffee slowly drifted through the home once again.

The house near the hills woke earlier than usual that morning.

Because today was special.

Today was Lisa’s birthday.

Inside the kitchen, warm yellow lights glowed softly while Venitha prepared breakfast with dangerous levels of concentration.

Steam rose from fresh idlis.

Coffee boiled nearby.

And soft devotional songs played quietly from an old speaker near the window.

Paari entered the kitchen half-asleep with messy hair and absolutely no awareness of human civilization.
“Morning.”

Venitha looked at him once.
“You forgot.”

Paari froze instantly.

His soul visibly left his body.

“NO I DIDN’T.”

“You absolutely did.”

“I was emotionally preparing!”

Venitha stared silently.

Paari immediately panicked.
“WAIT WAIT I REMEMBERED.”

Upstairs—

Lisa slowly walked out of her room wearing a simple blue salwar while drying her hair with a towel.

Rain touched the windows softly behind her.

And for one brief second—

Akira stopped moving while looking at her.

Because blue.

Rain.

Morning light.

The peaceful expression.

Everything reminded him painfully of **Yuki** again.

Not enough to hurt anymore.

Just enough to stay inside his chest quietly.

Lisa noticed him staring immediately.

“What?”

Akira slowly blinked.

“You look older.”

Lisa gasped loudly.

“That’s violence before breakfast.”

Akira smiled faintly into his coffee.

“Good. Your energy deserves suffering.”

A few minutes later—

the house became noisy again.

Paari searched everywhere for the hidden birthday gift he forgot to wrap.

Venitha yelled at him from the kitchen.

Lisa laughed nonstop watching the chaos.

And Akira—

Akira simply sat quietly listening to all of it.

Because this sound...

this ordinary family noise...

was exactly the kind of life Yuki once protected with all her heart.

Outside, rain continued covering the hills softly while mist drifted across the roads beautifully.

The family finally left for the temple together after breakfast.

The roads were still wet from the night rain.

Small puddles reflected temple lights softly while cold morning wind moved through the city.

Inside the car, devotional songs played quietly.

Lisa sat near the window watching rain slide across the glass peacefully.

And beside her—

Akira watched her quietly sometimes without speaking.

Because moments like this always made him feel something strange.

Like time had moved forward...

but love somehow stayed behind too.

The temple stood beautifully against the cloudy sky.

Fresh rainwater covered the stone steps outside.

The smell of incense and jasmine flowers filled the cold morning air softly.

Temple bells echoed peacefully through the mist-covered surroundings.

And for one brief moment—
everything felt calm.
Sacred.
Still.

Lisa removed her slippers carefully before stepping onto the cool wet stone floor.

Cold rain wind moved through the temple corridors gently while lamps flickered near ancient walls.

Paari walked ahead carrying prayer plates dramatically like he personally managed spirituality for the entire family.

Venitha rolled her eyes immediately.
“Walk properly.”

“I am spiritually glowing today.”

“You almost slipped near the entrance.”

“That was divine balance.”

Lisa burst into laughter instantly.

Even **Akira** smiled softly.

Inside the temple sanctum, golden lamps glowed against the darkness beautifully.

The priest chanted prayers quietly while rain continued falling outside the ancient stone walls.
And slowly—

the family stood together silently before the deity.

No arguments.
No jokes.

Just peace.

Akira closed his eyes quietly.

For several moments—
he said nothing.

But inside his heart—
he prayed softly.
Not for wealth.
Not for success.

Only for this.

For the family beside him to remain warm,
safe,
and together for as long as life allowed.

Beside him, Lisa secretly looked toward Akira once.

Then slowly lowered her eyes again.

And inside her own silent prayer—

she wished for only one thing too.

For Akira to stay with her for many more rainy evenings.

Outside, temple bells rang softly once more while rain touched the stone courtyard peacefully.

And somewhere deep inside the quiet morning air—
Yuki’s presence still remained gently around them.

Not as grief anymore.

As blessing.

Rain had softened by the time the family left the temple.

Tiny droplets still clung to trees and rooftops while cold mist drifted through the streets of Dindigul peacefully.

The entire city looked washed clean beneath the grey monsoon sky.

Lisa stood near the temple entrance adjusting the edge of her blue shawl while waiting for the others.

Fresh jasmine flowers rested in her hair softly.

And for one impossible second—
Akira stopped walking.

Because standing there beneath temple bells and rainlight—
she looked painfully like Yuki again.

Not exactly.
But enough for memory to touch his chest quietly.

Lisa immediately noticed him staring.
“What?”

Akira slowly blinked before looking away.
“Nothing.”

Lisa narrowed her eyes suspiciously.
“That ‘nothing’ looked emotional.”

“You inherited too much observation skill.”

“Thank you.”

“That wasn’t praise.”

Lisa laughed softly.

And hearing that laughter echo near the rain-washed temple steps made something warm settle inside Akira again.

Paari finally appeared carrying prasadam proudly like he completed a heroic mission.
“Move aside. Spiritual VIP service arriving.”

Venitha sighed immediately.
“You almost dropped it twice.”

“But I didn’t.”

“You absolutely did.”

Lisa burst into laughter while Akira quietly shook his head.

Some things truly never changed.

The family slowly walked through the temple streets afterward.

Small flower shops lined the roadside beneath colorful umbrellas.

Tea stalls released warm steam into the cold air.
Temple bells echoed softly behind them while rainwater reflected golden lights across the road beautifully.

Lisa suddenly stopped walking.

Akira immediately looked suspicious.

“That face means money.”

Lisa pointed dramatically toward a tiny roadside jewelry stall.

“I just want to see.”

“That sentence has destroyed my bank account for twenty years.”

Ten minutes later—

Akira stood helplessly near the stall while Lisa tried on silver bangles excitedly.

Rain tapped softly against the shop roof above them.

Cold wind moved through the hanging flower garlands nearby.

And for several moments—

Akira simply watched her smile.

Because honestly—

nothing in the world felt more beautiful to him than seeing his family happy during ordinary moments like this.

Lisa finally held up one delicate bracelet.

“This one?”

Akira adjusted his glasses carefully.

“It looks fragile.”

“Like your patience?”

“That disappeared in 2004.”

Lisa laughed loudly again.

The shopkeeper smiled quietly watching them.

Because love like this was easy to recognize.

Without saying anything—

Akira bought the bracelet.

Lisa blinked in surprise.

“You actually bought it?”

“You sound shocked.”

“You usually negotiate for forty-five minutes.”

“That’s called wisdom.”

“That’s called harassment.”

Outside, the rain became slightly heavier again.

So the family entered a nearby restaurant glowing warmly beneath yellow lights.

The smell of fresh dosa,
ghee roast,
and hot coffee instantly filled the air around them.

And somehow—

the entire place felt comforting against the cold rainy weather outside.

Lisa sat beside Akira while Venitha and Paari argued about ordering too much food again.

“We are four people.”

“Exactly. I ordered responsibly.”

“There are twelve dishes.”

“That’s optimism.”

Lisa nearly choked laughing.

Even Akira laughed softly into his coffee cup.

And honestly—

the sound of everyone together like this made the entire day feel complete already.

During lunch, Lisa quietly looked around the table for a moment.

At Paari’s dramatic complaints.

At Venitha pretending to be angry while smiling secretly.

At Akira drinking terrible coffee peacefully near the window while rain touched the glass softly behind him.

And suddenly—

her chest tightened emotionally.

Because she realized something important.

This was home.

Not the building.

Not the city.

These people.

These ordinary noisy moments.

This love.

Outside, rain continued falling peacefully across Dindigul.

And somewhere beyond the mist-covered hills—

***Yuki’s love still remained quietly inside every laugh,
every family argument,
and every warm moment shared together.***

By evening, the rain had returned softly once more.

Not heavy.

Just enough to cover the hills in silver mist and make the balcony lights glow beautifully against the darkness.

The house felt warm from corner to corner.

The smell of food filled the air.

Soft music played somewhere from the kitchen.

And for the first time in many years—
birthdays inside the house no longer carried hidden sadness.

Now—
they carried peace.

Lisa walked downstairs slowly after getting ready for dinner.

And the moment she entered the living room—

everyone became quiet for one brief second.

She wore the deep blue saree from yesterday’s shopping trip.

Her hair rested softly over one shoulder.

The silver bracelet **Akira** bought her glowed faintly beneath the warm lights.

And somehow—
standing there beneath the rainy evening glow—
she looked painfully like Yuki again.

Not in appearance alone.

In warmth.

In presence.

In the way the room itself felt softer when she entered it.

Paari immediately pointed dramatically.
“I raised this child successfully.”

Venitha looked offended.
“You forgot her birthday yesterday.”

“That’s unrelated to my emotional contribution.”

Lisa burst into laughter instantly.

Akira quietly smiled into his coffee.

The house sounded alive again.

Fully alive.

Outside, rain tapped softly against the balcony railings while cold wind moved through the curtains gently.

Lisa walked toward it slowly.
“What happened to this one?”

Paari crossed his arms proudly.
“Artistic shape.”

“That balloon is suffering.”

“That balloon has personality.”

Venitha shook her head helplessly.
“I married a child.”

Akira laughed softly after hearing that.

And honestly—
that small laugh warmed the entire room.

Dinner slowly turned chaotic in the best way possible.

Paari spilled juice accidentally.

Lisa laughed too hard at it.

Venitha threatened everyone equally.

And Akira quietly watched all of them together from his chair near the balcony.

Because somewhere deep inside his chest—
something peaceful settled completely at last.

Rain continued falling softly beyond the hills.

The same rain that once carried unbearable grief.

The same rain that once reminded him only of loss.

Now—
it carried warmth too.

Family.
Laughter.
Life continuing gently forward.

After dinner, the lights inside the house dimmed slightly.

The birthday cake rested near the balcony entrance glowing beneath candlelight softly.

Lisa looked around immediately.
“You actually bought a big cake?”

Paari looked offended.
“What kind of father would I be otherwise?”

Venitha answered immediately.
“The same kind you already are.”

“Violence. In front of guests.”

“We ARE the guests.”

Lisa nearly collapsed laughing again.

The candles flickered gently while rain touched the windows softly behind them.

And quietly—

everyone sang for Lisa together.

Not perfectly.
Not beautifully.

But warmly.

Like family always does.

Lisa closed her eyes before blowing the candles slowly.

For one brief moment—
Akira simply watched her silently.

And suddenly—
he remembered another birthday long ago.

Yuki laughing beneath balcony lights.

Cake cream on her cheek.

Rain outside.

Warmth inside.

The memory hurt softly now.

Not sharply anymore.

Just enough to remind him how deeply he had loved her.

“Cut the cake before Appa eats it,” **Venitha** warned.

“I am being targeted unfairly,” **Paari** complained immediately.

Lisa laughed before finally cutting the cake.

Cream somehow ended up on Paari’s face within thirty seconds.

Nobody understood how.

Not even Paari.

Later that night, after the chaos finally settled—

Lisa quietly stepped onto the balcony carrying two cups of coffee.

Akira already sat there watching rain cover the hills peacefully.

She walked toward him slowly before placing one cup beside him.

Then naturally—

she sat in Yuki’s chair.

Cold wind moved softly through the balcony curtains.

Rain touched the darkness endlessly beyond the hills.

And for several moments—

neither spoke.

Because silence between them never felt uncomfortable.

Only peaceful.

Then quietly—
Lisa wrapped **Yuki’s** old blue shawl around herself against the cold.

Akira slowly turned toward her.

And suddenly—
time itself seemed to stop.

The rain.

The balcony.

The blue shawl.

The soft smile.

For one impossible second—

it felt like Yuki sat there again beside him.

Lisa noticed him staring.

“What?”

Akira’s eyes softened quietly.

Then finally—

he smiled.

“Nothing.”

A long pause.

Then softly—

“You just reminded me of someone beautiful.”

Lisa’s expression slowly became emotional after hearing that.

But neither spoke further.

Because some feelings were too deep for conversation.

Rain continued falling softly across the hills of Dindigul.

Warm balcony lights glowed against the darkness.

And somewhere between memory,
family,
love,
and the sound of endless rain—

Akira finally understood something fully.

Yuki had never truly left them.

She had simply become part of the home forever.

Chapter 21 — Whenever It Rains

The house became quiet slowly after midnight.

Not silent.

Never completely silent.

Because somewhere inside the kitchen, **Paari** still searched for leftover cake like a criminal operating at night.

Venitha caught him exactly three times.

And somehow—
that made Lisa laugh harder every single time.

Eventually, the lights inside the house dimmed one by one.

Doors closed softly.

Footsteps faded.

And the rainy night settled peacefully around the home near the hills.

Outside, rain continued falling gently across Dindigul.

Silver mist covered the distant hills while cold wind moved softly through the balcony curtains.

The world looked slower at night during monsoon season.

Quieter.
Softer.

Like the rain itself wanted people to rest.

Akira sat alone on the balcony with coffee resting beside him.

The warm yellow balcony light glowed softly against the darkness while rain touched the railing endlessly.

And beside him—
Yuki’s chair remained exactly where it always had.

For several moments—
Akira simply listened to the rain quietly.

No sadness.

No heaviness.

Just memory sitting peacefully beside him.

Because after all these years—
grief had changed.

It no longer felt like drowning.

Now—
it felt like love refusing to disappear completely.

The balcony door opened softly behind him.

Akira smiled faintly before turning.
“You’re awake.”

Lisa walked outside carrying a blanket around her shoulders while holding two fresh cups of coffee carefully.

“You thought you’d escape without company?”

“I was hoping.”

“Too bad.”

Lisa placed one cup beside **Akira** before sitting naturally in **Yuki’s** chair once again.

Rain touched the hills softly beyond the balcony while cold wind moved through the curtains gently.

And for several moments—

both simply sat together listening to the rain.

No conversation needed.

Because some people become home to each other beyond words.

Lisa slowly wrapped the blanket tighter around herself.

Then softly asked,

“You’re happy today?”

Akira looked toward the rain quietly.

A small smile appeared on his face.

“Yes.”

The answer came easily.

Naturally.

Peacefully.

Lisa rested her chin against her knees while staring toward the mist-covered hills.

“You know...”

Akira hummed softly.

“When I was younger, I used to think rain made everyone emotional for no reason.”

Akira laughed quietly.

“That sounds accurate.”

“But now I understand.”

Lisa’s voice became softer.

“Rain slows everything down.”

Cold wind touched the balcony gently.

Lisa looked toward the darkness beyond the hills.

“And when things become quiet...”

A faint smile touched her face.

“...you can hear your heart properly.”

Akira slowly turned toward her after hearing that.

And honestly—

for one impossible second—

it felt like Yuki was speaking through the warmth she left behind inside Lisa.

Not replacing her.

Continuing her.

Inside the house, a loud noise suddenly echoed from the kitchen.

Then immediately—

Venitha shouted,
“PAARI PUT THE CAKE DOWN.”

“I WAS CHECKING QUALITY.”

“AT ONE IN THE MORNING?!”

Lisa burst into laughter instantly.

Akira laughed too.
Warmly.
Comfortably.

The kind of laughter that once disappeared from the house completely after Yuki’s goodbye.

Rain continued falling peacefully outside.

Then quietly—
Lisa looked toward Akira again.
“Do you still miss her?”

The question carried no fear inside it.

Only love.

Akira slowly looked toward the empty darkness beside him.

Toward the chair.

Toward the rain.

Toward memory itself.

Then softly smiled.
“Every day.”

A pause.
“But now...”

His eyes lifted toward the rain-covered hills.
“...missing her feels warm too.”

Silence settled gently around the balcony afterward.

Not sad silence.
Peaceful silence.

The kind that comes only after people survive grief together.

Cold wind moved softly through the balcony once more.

Rain touched the hills endlessly beneath the night sky.

And somewhere inside the sound of it—

Yuki still remained.
Not as heartbreak anymore.
Not as loss.
But as love that became part of the family forever.

The rain grew softer as the night deepened.
Tiny droplets touched the balcony railing gently while mist drifted across the sleeping hills of Dindigul.

Inside the house, the lights were mostly off now.
 Only the kitchen light remained glowing faintly because **Paari** still insisted “one last cake piece” was a basic human right.

Venitha strongly disagreed.
 Outside, **Akira** quietly held his coffee between both hands while listening to rain settle over the world peacefully.

Lisa remained beside him wrapped inside the blanket silently.

And somehow—
the balcony felt exactly the same as years ago.

But completely different too.
 The same rain.
 The same cold wind.
 The same balcony lights.

Yet the pain that once lived there had softened into something gentler.

Something warmer.

Like memory itself had finally found peace.

Lisa slowly looked toward the hills again.

Then softly smiled.
 “You know what I think?”

Akira glanced toward her carefully.
 “That sentence usually becomes dangerous.”

Lisa ignored him proudly.

“I think Paati would’ve loved today.”

The rain continued softly around them.

Akira quietly looked toward the darkness beyond the balcony.

And deep inside—
he knew she was right.

Yuki would’ve loved:

the temple bells during rain
 Paari ruining decorations
 Venitha pretending not to laugh
 birthday cake chaos
 Lisa smiling beneath balcony lights
 this warm noisy house still full of love

Ordinary things.

Yuki always loved ordinary things most.

Lisa slowly leaned back against Yuki’s chair comfortably.

Then softly asked,
 “What was she like when nobody else was around?”

The question carried curiosity.

Not grief.

Because Lisa had grown up hearing stories about Yuki her entire life.

But tonight—
she wanted to know the small details.

The real ones.

Akira smiled faintly into his coffee.

“She talked too much.”

Lisa laughed instantly.

“That sounds familiar.”

“She stole my fries constantly.”

“That ALSO sounds familiar.”

“And she complained every single time I made coffee.”

Lisa gasped dramatically.
“She was correct.”

Akira looked betrayed immediately.
“I raised disrespectful people.”

Rain tapped softly against the railing while cold wind moved through the curtains gently.

Then quietly—

Akira’s expression softened again.
“But...”

He looked toward the hills peacefully.
“She made ordinary days feel important.”

Silence settled softly afterward.

Because somehow—

that sentence described Yuki completely.

Not through grand moments.

Through small ones.

Lisa slowly lowered her eyes.

Then quietly whispered,
“I wish I met her properly.”

Akira turned toward her gently.
“You did.”

Lisa blinked once.

Akira smiled softly.
“She’s part of the reason you became who you are.”

The wind moved gently around them.
“The way you care for people.”

“The way you laugh loudly.”

“The way rain makes you stop and look outside.”

A faint smile touched **Akira’s** face.
“That’s her too.”

Lisa’s eyes slowly filled after hearing that.

Not with sadness.
With warmth.

Because suddenly—
she understood something deeply.

Yuki had helped raise her even after goodbye.

Through stories.

Through love.

Through the family she left behind.

Inside the house, another loud noise suddenly echoed from the kitchen.

Then immediately—
“PAARI THAT WAS THE DECORATION CHOCOLATE.”

“I thought it was free-use chocolate!”

“There is no such thing!”

Lisa burst into helpless laughter again.

Akira laughed too.

And honestly—

the sound of all of them together beneath rain felt like healing itself.

Slowly—

the laughter faded again into peaceful quiet.

Rain continued falling softly beyond the hills.

And somewhere deep inside the stillness of the night—

Akira realized something finally.

He no longer feared rainy evenings.

Because rain no longer reminded him only of loss.

Now—

it reminded him of everything love managed to leave behind.

Very softly—

Akira looked toward the empty darkness beside him one final time.

Then whispered into the rain,
“We’re okay now.”

Cold wind moved gently through the balcony.

Warm.
Familiar.
Almost like an answer.

And beneath the endless sound of monsoon rain—
the old house near the hills finally felt complete again.

The night slowly became quieter after that.

Rain softened into a gentle drizzle while cold mist settled across the hills of Dindigul peacefully.

Inside the kitchen, **Venitha** finally forced **Paari** to stop eating leftover cake.

Not successfully.

But spiritually.

Outside on the balcony, **Akira** and **Lisa** still sat together beneath the warm yellow lights.

Coffee had already gone cold beside them.

Neither cared.

Because moments like this were never really about coffee.

They were about staying.

Lisa quietly watched rain slide across the balcony railing.

Then softly asked,
“Were you scared of forgetting her?”

The question settled gently into the night.

Akira remained silent for a long moment.

Not because he didn’t know the answer.

Because he remembered that fear too clearly.

Years ago—
after Yuki’s goodbye—
he had feared many things.

Loneliness.
Silence.

The empty chair beside him.

But most of all—
he feared time.
Because time moves forward even when hearts beg it not to.

And somewhere deep inside himself—

Akira once worried that one day her voice,
her laugh,
or the way she looked at rain would slowly fade.

But now—
sitting beside Lisa beneath monsoon rain—
he finally understood something important.

Love does not survive through memory alone.

It survives through people.

Akira slowly looked toward Lisa.

Then softly smiled.
“No.”

Lisa blinked once.

Akira’s eyes moved toward the house behind them.

Toward the warm lights glowing inside.

Toward the family noise still echoing faintly through the hallway.

Rain touched the hills softly beyond the darkness.
“She’s everywhere here.”

Rain continued falling endlessly across the hills of Dindigul.

The balcony lights glowed warmly against the dark night.

Inside the house, laughter still echoed softly from the kitchen.

And somewhere between memory,
rain,
family,
and love—

Yuki remained exactly where she always promised she would be.

Home.

Final Epilogue — And Whenever Rain Returned

Years passed quietly after that night.

Beautiful years.

Not perfect years.

Because no family lives without arguments,
mistakes,
or difficult days.

But they were warm years.

And in the end—

warmth mattered more than perfection ever could.

The house near the hills of Dindigul slowly grew older with time.

The balcony wood faded slightly from years of monsoon rain.

The kitchen walls carried faint marks from countless family dinners.

And the old yellow balcony light still flickered sometimes because Paari continued refusing to replace it properly.

“Character,” he called it.

“Electrical failure,” **Venitha** called it.

Lisa called both of them impossible.

Rain still remained part of the house.

Every monsoon evening,
cold mist still wrapped around the hills beautifully.

Coffee still filled the air.

And somehow—

everybody still gathered near the balcony whenever rain arrived.

Like the house itself remembered Yuki too.

One evening, years later, rain covered the city heavily once again.

Thunder rolled softly beyond the hills while cold wind moved through the curtains gently.

Inside the kitchen, Venitha prepared dinner while arguing with Paari about absolutely nothing important.

As usual.

Outside, **Akira** sat peacefully on the balcony wrapped in a light shawl.

Age had slowed him now.

His hair had turned completely silver.

His hands trembled slightly while holding coffee.

But his eyes—

his eyes still softened every time rain touched the hills.

Because rain would always belong to Yuki somehow.

The balcony door opened softly behind him.

Lisa walked outside carrying another cup of coffee carefully.

Older now.

Stronger.

Still carrying warmth everywhere she went.

And somehow—

still carrying pieces of Yuki inside her too.

“You’ll get cold again,” Lisa complained while placing the coffee beside him.

Akira smiled faintly.

“You sound exactly like your Paati.”

Lisa proudly wrapped the shawl tighter around his shoulders anyway.

“Someone has to keep you alive.”

“That’s rude.”

“That’s love.”

Akira quietly laughed.

And honestly—

that sentence sounded painfully familiar.

Exactly like **Yuki**.

Rain continued falling peacefully outside.

For several moments—

both simply listened to it together.

No sadness.

No heaviness.

Just peace.

Inside the kitchen, **Paari** suddenly shouted loudly again.

“WHO FINISHED THE MURUKKU?”

Venitha immediately answered—

“YOU DID.”

“That accusation lacks evidence.”

“You left the empty box on the sofa.”

“That proves nothing.”

Lisa burst into helpless laughter instantly.

Akira laughed too.

And the old house—

the house that once drowned in silence after heartbreak—

felt alive from corner to corner again.

Lisa slowly leaned against the balcony railing.

Then softly asked,
“Do you think love ever disappears?”

Akira looked toward the rain-covered hills quietly.

A long silence followed.

Then finally—

he answered softly.
“No.”

Cold wind moved gently around them.
“People leave.”

A faint smile touched his face.
“But love learns how to stay.”

Lisa’s eyes slowly filled after hearing that.

Because somehow—
that sentence carried the entire story of their family inside it.

Rain touched the balcony softly.

Coffee slowly became cold beside them.

And somewhere deep inside the peaceful sound of monsoon rain—

Akira could almost hear her laugh again.

Not like a ghost.

Not like pain.

Like memory becoming warmth.

Then quietly—
Akira looked toward Yuki’s chair one final time.

And instead of heartbreak—

he only smiled.
Softly.
Lovingly.

Like someone finally understanding that goodbye was never truly the end.

Inside the house, dinner waited on the table.

Family voices echoed warmly through the hallway.

Rain wrapped itself around the hills of Dindigul beautifully.

And beneath the warm balcony lights—

love remained exactly where it always belonged.

Home.

Whenever It Rains

When rain touched the hills,
we thought it carried sadness.
But years quietly taught us something else.
Rain was never about goodbye.
It was about memories returning home.

About warm lights inside old houses.
About coffee growing cold
during long conversations.
About laughter echoing from
kitchens late at night.
About people who stayed beside
each other through every
season of life.

Some people leave this world softly.
Yet their love remains behind
in ordinary things.

In a favorite chair.
In familiar voices.
In family traditions.
In the silence between
two heartbeats.

And sometimes—
on quiet evenings beneath
endless monsoon skies—
love returns again
through the sound of rain.

Because hearts that truly
loved each other
never completely say goodbye.

*They simply become
part of home forever.*

— written by —

— Gopinath.r —

